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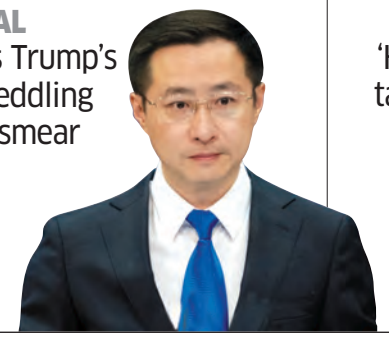

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SPORTS
'Kohli, Gambhir talk 10 times in a day'

PM sounds the poll bugle in Punjab

Mixing development with politics, the PM hit at State Government pitching the BJP as the alternative

MONIKA MALIK
Chandigarh/Jalandhar

Wearing a green turban in a symbolic outreach to Punjab's farming community, Prime Minister Narendra Modi turned his Jalandhar visit into a high-voltage mix of development and politics on Friday. Unveiling and inaugurating projects worth ₹5,470 crore, PM Modi launched a blistering attack on the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)-led Punjab Government, accusing it of corruption, mounting debt, poor governance, deteriorating law and order, and betraying farmers, women and youth.

With the Punjab Assembly elections just months away, PM Modi also targeted Congress over its leadership tussle and the Shiromani Akali Dal for being trapped in its own internal crisis. The sharp criticism of the SAD, coupled with his repeated call for an independent BJP Government in Punjab signals that the party is preparing to chart its own electoral course rather than banking on a traditional alliance. Greeting the gathering in Punjabi with "*Punjabio, kiven ho...chardi kala ch ho?*", PM Modi repeatedly switched between Punjabi and Hindi, drawing loud applause from the packed rally. Earlier, after inaugurating projects worth over ₹4,700 crore in Chandigarh and flagging off India's first hydrogen-powered train in Haryana, he arrived in Jalandhar, interacted with passengers, schoolchildren and saints, and flagged off the Shri Sant Ravidas Express connecting Amritsar and Varanasi. He also met Dera Sachkhand Ballan head Sant Niranjan Das aboard the inaugural train.

Projecting the Union Government's commitment to Punjab despite the BJP not being in power in the State, PM Modi said that NDA Government was leaving no stone unturned for its development.

He inaugurated 75 redeveloped Amrit Bharat railway stations, including the modernised Jalandhar Cantt railway station, inaugurated the Daulatpur Chowk-Kartoli railway line, opened another section of the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra Expressway, and laid the foundation stone for the 25.2-km Southern Ludhiana Greenfield Bypass.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Prime Minister Narendra Modi flags off India's first hydrogen-powered train, between Jind and Sonipat, at Jind Railway Station, Haryana PTI

New Commissioner of Delhi Police, Anurag Kumar PIONEER PHOTO

Ex-IB officer takes charge of Delhi Police

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi

In a notable administrative reshuffle, the Union Government has appointed Anurag Kumar, a 1994-batch IPS officer and former Special Director of the Intelligence Bureau (IB), as the new Commissioner of Delhi Police. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, approved Kumar's repatriation from the IB.

An official order issued on Friday stated, "With the approval of the Competent Authority, Anurag Kumar, IPS (AGMUT:1994), is hereby appointed as Commissioner of Police, Delhi, with effect from the date of assumption of charge and until further orders." The incumbent, Satish Golchha, a 1992-batch IPS officer, has been directed to report to the Lieutenant Governor of Delhi for further posting upon Kumar's assumption of office. The transition is anticipated to proceed smoothly. Kumar's predecessor, Golcha, who assumed command in 2023, focused on technological enhancements, women's safety initiatives, and community policing. Kumar is expected to build on these initiatives while placing greater emphasis on intelligence integration and rapid-response capabilities.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

SIR GARFIELD SOBERS NO MORE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Bridgetown

Sir Garfield Sobers, one of the greatest all-rounders in cricket history and a former West Indies captain, died here on Friday at the age of 89. The death of the legendary cricketer was confirmed by his son Daniel.

Sir Garry Sobers in 2012 WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Sobers was only 10 days shy of completing his 90th birthday. One of the finest all-rounders the game has ever seen, Sobers played 93 Tests and scored 8,032 runs at 57.78 with 26 centuries and 30 half-centuries between March 1954 to April 1974.

A left-handed batter and also a left-arm fast medium pace bowler, Sobers claimed 235 wickets in Test cricket.

The ByStander

CM removal Bill hits a pause

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Just days before the onset of Monsoon Session of the Parliament, a Joint Parliamentary Committee (JPC) examining a Bill on removal of prime minister and chief ministers detained on serious charges decided to defer the adoption of a draft report when voting was underway on each of the five recommendations made by the panel.

AIMIM's Asaduddin Owaisi and NCP (Sharad Pawar) MP Supriya Sule had submitted their dissent notes but withdrew them after the panel decided to defer the adoption of its report in the last minute. Members of the BJP also voted against some recommendations.

"The joint parliamentary committee unanimously said that we needed more consultations with stakeholders," said panel chief Aparajita Sarangi (BJP). Members present in the meeting said voting on two of the recommendations was already done and discussions were underway on the third when the decision was taken to defer the adoption of the draft report. The JPC on 130th Amendment Bill had made the five recommendations in its draft report which was circulated to members recently. On Friday, when the committee was voting on each of the recommendations separately, it was decided that more consultations with stakeholders and discussions among members were required.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

JPC chair and BJP leader Aparajita Sarangi

SIT readies interim report on Ram Temple row

Accused being escorted by police after being produced before a court in connection with the alleged Ram Mandir donation theft case in Ayodhya on Wednesday PTI

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi/Lucknow

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) investigating allegations of embezzlement of donations at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple in Ayodhya is anticipated to submit an interim report to the Supreme Court on Monday, according to sources familiar with the matter.

This development follows the recent directives issued by the SC during hearings on petitions seeking a fair and expeditious investigation. Sources also indicated that the SIT may seek additional time from the Uttar Pradesh Government to complete its investigation.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Delimitation push takes shape

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A crucial meeting of the NDA group of ministers, including Union Minister of Defence, Rajnath Singh and Union Minister for Home Minister, Amit Shah was held at Kartavya Bhavan on Friday.

The meeting, held ahead of the Monsoon session of the Parliament, was also attended by Union ministers and NDA allies Lallan Singh (JD-U), Jayant Chaudhary (RLD) and Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu (TDP), to discuss the ruling coalition's strategy in the upcoming Parliament session beginning July 20, sources said.

Sources said the meeting discussed Government business for the upcoming session and its push for of converting the delimitation and the women's quota Bills into an Acts of Parliament during the session. Another round of meeting of NDA Parliamentary Party has been scheduled for Tuesday in Parliament House which has been christened 'Mangal Milan'. The parliamentary party meeting is traditionally held on Tuesdays during Parliament sessions.

Sources said the delimitation Bill is again on the agenda of the Government next week Monsoon Session and the Government is confident of gathering support to get the legislation passed.

The NDA is confident in getting the required two-thirds number with the support of various Opposition parties, except the Congress and the Samajwadi Party.

The Government is learnt to be working on multiple formulations to increase the number of Lok Sabha seats for all states by 50 per cent to assuage the concerns of southern States, as it seeks to operationalise a fresh draft of the Constitution amendment Bill on women's quota law.

The Government also plans to introduce the Income-tax (Amendment) Bill in the upcoming session to replace the ordinance effected to exempt foreign investors from income tax on interest earnings and capital gains from investment in Government securities (G-secs).

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Representative image WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

SOURCES SAID THE DELIMITATION BILL IS BACK ON THE GOVT'S AGENDA FOR NEXT WEEK'S MONSOON SESSION, WITH CONFIDENCE OF PASSAGE

GUJARAT ATS ARRESTS FIVE IN SUSPECTED TERROR BUST

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
New Delhi/Ahmedabad

The Gujarat Anti-Terrorist Squad (ATS) has apprehended five young men on suspicion of their involvement with a Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) module. ATS officials allege they were attempting to acquire knowledge related to bomb-making techniques and actively preparing to execute detonations within the State. The arrests were conducted on July 15, however, the ATS has not disclosed whether any incriminating material has been recovered.

All five suspects, in their early twenties and residents of different districts across Gujarat, were presented before a court in Kadi, Mehsana district, on Thursday and remanded into eight days of police custody under the supervision of the ATS. Senior officials indicated that the arrests followed crucial disclosures made during the interrogation of Mohammed Amin Shera, who was detained earlier this month in connection with the same module.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Former temple officer arrested in Badrinath donation theft probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jyotirmath

Uttarakhand Police on Friday arrested a former temple officer in connection with the alleged misappropriation of donations at the Badrinath Shrine. The arrest comes in the backdrop of continuing probe into the incident by the Special Investigation Team.

Chamoli superintendent of police Surjeet Singh Panwar informed that on the basis of electronic, documentary and oral evidence, which emerged during the investigation, the involvement of another accused in the case has been proved and subsequently has been arrested.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

Badrinath temple WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Centuries-old cannon in MP vanishes in daring midnight raid

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Bhopal

A nearly 400-year-old cannon has been stolen from the historic Narwar Fort in Shivpuri district of Madhya Pradesh, triggering concerns over the security of protected monuments and reviving memories of a similar theft in the State nearly two decades ago.

The theft is believed to have taken place on the intervening night of July 15 and July 16 at the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI)-protected fort. According to preliminary investigations, a group of unidentified persons entered the fort through a less-guarded rear approach using a vehicle and escaped with the massive artillery piece.

Security personnel stationed at the fort alleged that around 25 to 30 armed men carried out the operation. The intruders reportedly threatened the unarmed guards before loading the cannon onto vehicles and fleeing. Investigators suspect the theft was carefully planned and executed in multiple stages to avoid detection. The stolen cannon was one of 14 historic artillery pieces displayed in the fort's open courtyard. With the latest theft, only 13 cannons remain at the centuries-old monument.

Karera Sub-Divisional Officer of Police (SDOP) Prashant Sharma said police reached the spot immediately after receiving information and have launched a detailed investigation. He said all possible angles, including the involvement of an interstate or international smuggling network dealing in antiques and heritage artefacts, are being examined. Officials said preliminary findings indicate the cannon had fallen from its designated platform a few days earlier but was not restored to its original position or shifted to a secure location, making it vulnerable to theft.

Describing the incident as "extremely serious," Deputy Director of the State Archaeology Department Tarun Kumar Srivastava said he would personally visit Narwar Fort to review the security arrangements and assess the circumstances surrounding the theft.

Police teams are analysing CCTV footage from nearby areas, mapping possible escape routes and collecting technical evidence to identify those involved. The incident has also brought back memories of a similar theft in 2007, when another Mughal-era cannon, measuring nearly seven feet in length and weighing around 30 quintals, was stolen from the Kachahari Mahal complex within the same fort.

Narwar Fort, believed to have been rebuilt by the Kachhwaha Rajputs in the 10th century, is one of Madhya Pradesh's prominent heritage sites. The hill fort is also associated in local tradition with Kush, the son of Lord Rama, and the legendary King Nala and Damayanti. The latest theft has once again raised serious questions over the protection of priceless historical artefacts housed at ASI-protected monuments.

The stolen cannon was one of 14 historic artillery pieces displayed in the fort's open courtyard WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

Govt approves ₹33.31 cr relief to farmers after crop losses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government, led by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, has approved over ₹33.31 crore in ex-gratia relief for farmers whose crops suffered 100 per cent damage due to heavy rainfall and waterlogging in August-September 2025.

The relief will be provided at ₹75,000 per hectare, benefiting farmers across 4,442.41 hectares of agricultural land in the national Capital. The amount will be transferred directly into eligible farmers' bank accounts through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) from next month.

According to a statement issued by the Chief Minister's office, as per the government's decision, a total of 4,442.41 hectares of affected agricultural land across various districts and sub-divisions in Delhi has been brought under the relief scheme. Assistance approved includes ₹2.74 crore for 364.74 hectares in Alipur (Narela), ₹13 lakh for 17.33 hectares in Burari, ₹38.63 lakh for 51.50 hectares in Punjabi Bagh (Mundka), and ₹19.92 lakh for 26.55 hectares in Vikaspuri.

Similarly, under the Kanjhawala area, relief of ₹8.70 crore and ₹4.49 crore has been approved for a total of 1,758.76 hectares of affected agricultural land in Mundka and Bawana, respectively. Assistance of ₹1.03 crore has been sanctioned for 137.59 hectares in Rohini (Mundka), ₹4.69 crore for 625.93 hectares in Kapashera (Matiala), while affected areas covering a total of 1,459.97 hectares under Najafgarh and Matiala have been sanctioned ₹9.98 crore and ₹96.74 lakh, respectively.

The Chief Minister has directed the Revenue Department and the concerned District Magistrates to begin the distribution process without any delay so that the relief amount reaches the bank accounts of eligible farmers at the earliest.

She said the Delhi Government stands firmly with its farmers in both good times and bad. The assistance is an effort to help farmers recover from the heavy losses caused by nature's fury.

She added that the affected areas have been assessed as having suffered 100 per cent crop loss, and the assistance will be transferred directly to eligible farmers with complete transparency.

According to her, the Delhi Government has laid down clear eligibility conditions to ensure that the assistance reaches only genuine and eligible farmers.

CM launches 45 Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday inaugurated 45 new Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs across the capital at an event in Shakurpur. She also inaugurated development projects worth about ₹14.25 crore in the Tri Nagar assembly constituency.

Speaking on the occasion, the Chief Minister said the Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs offer general OPD services, maternal and child healthcare, routine immunisation, free screening for non-communicable diseases, essential medicines, health counselling and nearly 80 types of free diagnostic tests. She added that the centres would also place special emphasis on disease prevention, early detection, timely treatment and health awareness.

She said the initiative was not merely about opening new health centres but a significant step towards ensuring that every resident of the capital has access to quality, affordable and dignified healthcare. MLA from Tri Nagar Shri Tilak Ram Gupta, along with public representatives, officials of the Health Department, doctors, nursing staff and a large number of local residents, attended the programme.

The Chief Minister said that with the inauguration of these new centres, more than 415 Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs are now providing quality and accessible primary healthcare services close to people's homes across Delhi. She expressed confidence that the Delhi Government would soon achieve its target of establishing more than 1,100 Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs. She said the Government's aim is not only to treat illnesses but also to encourage people to adopt a healthier lifestyle. She urged citizens to undergo regular health check-ups, maintain a balanced lifestyle and make yoga and exercise a part of their daily routine.

After inaugurating the Ayushman Jan Arogya Mandirs, the chief minister also inaugurated development projects worth around ?14.25 crore in the Tri Nagar Assembly constituency. The projects include the reconstruction of five roads and a drain in the Netaji Subhash Place area. The beautification of Samrat Enclave Market was also launched. In addition, the Chief Minister inaugurated development works at Gurjar Chaupal, Saini Chaupal and the Shakurpur cremation ground.

Along with this, eight major roads developed by the PWD at a cost of ₹6.25 crore, including Lawrence Road, Maharshi Parashuram Marg, Parwana Road, G & H Shakurpur Road, Ekalavya Marg, Thiruvalluvar Marg, and Veer Hemu Marg, were also inaugurated.

The objective, she said, is to build a system where every citizen has timely access to healthcare, better roads and modern public facilities, enabling Delhi to move forward as a healthier, more prosperous and developed capital. She said that, for the first time, development work is being carried out on a large scale across every Assembly constituency, covering roads, drains, colonies and slum clusters.

Azadpur APMC runs night raids to clear illegal vendors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Agricultural Produce Marketing Committee (APMC) at Azadpur Mandi has been conducting a series of special anti-encroachment drives since May 2026.

The drive aims to clear unauthorised vendors, illegal structures, and unlicensed traders from Asia's largest wholesale fruit and vegetable market, with the most recent operation conducted at night on July 16 in the D-Block of New Sabzi Mandi.

All seized fresh produce that is collected during the drive is distributed to registered orphanages and children's homes across Delhi rather than being allowed to go to waste.

The campaign, running through both business hours and night hours, has been carried out jointly by APMC Azadpur's enforcement branch, the E&M branch, and the security branch, with police support from the SHO of Mahendra Park police station.

The first major operation was conducted on May 30, targeting Sheds 7, 9, 13, and the C-Block crossing of New Sabzi Mandi. During the drive at Shed 13, unlicensed vendors who were illegally occupying space fled when they saw the enforcement team approaching, while goods belonging to other unauthorised occupants were seized on the spot. After a detailed discussion with licensed traders at Shed 13, it was decided to deploy additional round-the-clock security guards at the location to prevent any future unauthorised occupation.

In the C-Block area of New Sabzi Mandi, the joint team, with police support, removed unauthorised vendors who had been selling fruit and vegetables from handcarts, footpaths, and the roadway.

Illegal handcarts and other unauthorised structures were demolished using APMC's JCB machine, and the remaining goods were seized.

Showing quick administrative response, on June 7, a Sunday, information was received that a 20-by-20-foot illegal tin shed structure had been erected on land reserved for the MNI Azadpur park. Enforcement and security staff immediately removed the temporary structure.

A further special drive was conducted on June 30 in the NFM and NSM areas of Azadpur to remove hawkers and unauthorised fruit and vegetable vendors who had been causing traffic jams and vehicle congestion at these locations.

Delhi plans permanent drainage project to end chronic waterlogging in Dera Mandi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Friday announced a permanent drainage project to address the recurring waterlogging at Dera Mandi Road near Mandi village in south Delhi's Chhatarpur area, following an inspection by PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh.

The Minister visited the affected stretch after heavy rainfall led to severe water accumulation, disrupting traffic and inconveniencing residents. Senior officials from the concerned departments accompanied him during the inspection to review the condition of the road, drainage network and sewer system.

According to the government, the affected road falls under the jurisdiction of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD). As an immediate measure, PTO pumps have been deployed to continuously drain the accumulated water while authorities work on a long-term solution.

Officials informed the Minister that the stretch is a natural low-lying area where rainwater collects during heavy showers. Earlier, the excess water would flow through a natural drainage channel into Haryana.

However, with the outlet no longer available due to urban development, rainwater now remains trapped, leading to frequent waterlogging during the monsoon. To address the issue permanently, the Public Works Department (PWD) will construct a new precast reinforced cement concrete (RCC) drain from Dera Mandi Road to Dera Bhati Road, extending to Bandh Road.

KEY CORP LIMITED

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NOTICE OF POSTAL BALLOT AND E-VOTING INFORMATION

Notice is hereby given pursuant to the provisions of Section 110 read with Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 ("the Act") and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Act, and Rules 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 as amended from time to time (including any statutory modification or re-enactment thereof for the time being in force) ("the Rules"), Regulation 44 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 ("SEBI Listing Regulations") and the Secretarial Standard on General Meetings issued by the Institute of Company Secretaries of India ("SS-2"), as amended from time to time read with the General Circular No. 14/2020 dated April 8, 2020, 17/2020 dated April 13, 2020, 09/2024 dated September 19, 2024 and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being 03/2025 dated September 22, 2025 issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") (hereinafter collectively referred to as "MCA Circulars"), and other applicable laws, rules and regulations (including any statutory modification(s) or re-enactment(s) thereof for the time being in force), the approval of members of Key Corp Limited ('the Company') is being sought for the following special resolutions proposed to be passed by means of postal ballot only by way of remote electronic voting ('remote e-voting') for special businesses set out in the postal ballot notice dated July 15, 2026 along with explanatory statement ("the Notice").

Sr. No.	Description of Resolution(s)
1.	Alteration of The Object Clause of the Memorandum of Association and to Amend Memorandum of Association of the Company as Per the Companies Act, 2013
2.	Appointment of Mr. Yogesh Yashpaul Chadha (DIN: 01681680) As an Independent Director of the Company
3.	Appointment of Mr. Devesh Srivastava (DIN: 08646006) As an Independent Director of the Company
4.	To Approve the Borrowing Limits of the Company Under Section 180 (1)(c) Of The Companies Act, 2013
5.	To Approve the Creation of Security by Way of Charge/ Mortgage/Hypothecation and/or Otherwise Pursuant to The Provision of Section 180(1)(a) Of The Companies Act, 2013

In compliance with the aforesaid MCA Circulars, the Company has sent the Notice of Postal Ballot on Friday, July 17, 2026 through electronic mode to those Members whose names appear on the Register of Members/List of Beneficial Owners as on Friday, July 10, 2026 (Cut-off date) and whose email addresses were registered with the Company/Depositories/Registrar to an issue and Share Transfer Agent ("RTA") of the Company. Members whose email addresses are not registered with the Company/Depositories/RTA may also cast their vote by following the remote e-voting process given in the Notice. Members who have not received the said Postal Ballot Notice, may write to the Company at **keycorpltd@gmail.com** mentioning their DP ID/Client ID. Members may please note that the Postal Ballot Notice is also be available on the website of the Company at www.keycorpltd.com and may also be accessed from the relevant section of the websites of the Stock Exchange i.e. BSE Limited at **www.bseindia.com** and also on the website of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") at **www.evotingindia.com**. Members who do not receive the postal ballot notice may download it from the above mentioned Websites. Physical copies of the Notice along with Postal Ballot forms and pre-paid business reply envelopes are not sent to Members. The Communication of the assent or dissent of the members would only take place through the remote e-voting system. The Company has engaged the services of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") for facilitating e-Voting to enable the Members to cast their votes electronically.

All the Members are informed that:

a) Members whose name are recorded in the Register of Members/list of Beneficial Owners as on the Cut-off Date, are eligible to exercise their right to vote by remote e-voting system on the business(es) specified in the Notice.
b) The remote e-voting facility will be available during the following voting period:

Commencement of Remote e-voting	Monday, July 20, 2026, at 9.00 a.m. (IST).
End of Remote e-voting	Tuesday, August 18, 2026, at 5.00 p.m. (IST).

c) The remote e-voting will not be allowed beyond the aforesaid date and time and the remote e-voting module shall be disabled upon expiry of the aforesaid period.
d) Voting rights shall be reckoned on the paid-up value of share registered in the name of the members as on the cutoff date. A person who is not a member as on the cut-off date should treat the Notice for information purpose only.
e) Once the vote on the resolutions is cast by the Member, the Member shall not be allowed to change it subsequently or cast the vote again. The manner of remote e-voting for Members is provided in the Notice.
f) The proposed Special Resolutions, if approved, will be taken as having duly passed on the last date specified for remote e-voting by the requisite majority by means of postal ballot, i.e. Tuesday, August 18, 2026.

The Board has appointed CS Ankit Dhanotia (COP-25667), as Scrutinizer for conducting the Postal Ballot through remote E-Voting process in a fair and transparent manner in accordance with the provisions of Companies Act, 2013 and Rule 20 and 22 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014.

The results of the postal ballot/remote e-voting shall be declared, either by the Chairman of the Board or any person authorized by him within the stipulated timeline and the same, along with the Scrutinizer's Report, will be displayed on the notice board at the registered office of the Company and on the website of the Company i.e. **www.keycorpltd.com** and on the website of the CDSL i.e. **www.evotingindia.com**. The results shall simultaneously be communicated to the Stock Exchanges.

In case you have any queries or issues regarding e-voting, you may refer the Frequently Asked Questions ("FAQs") and e-voting manual available at **www.evotingindia.com**, under help section or write an email to **helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com** or contact Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, Sr. Manager, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, A Wing, 25th Floor, Marathon Futurex, Mafatlal Mill Compounds, N M Joshi Marg, Lower Parel (East), Mumbai -400013 or call at toll free no. 18002109911.

For Key Corp Limited
Sd/-
Daya Nath Misra
Company Secretary
M. No.: F2656

Date: 18/07/2026
Place: Kanpur

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	RC26-46550409	UNINSULATED CADMIUM COPPER CATENARY WIRE	400.00 MT	10.08.2026
02	09272300	CUT OFF ANGLE COCK WITH VENT	21813 NOS	10.08.2026
03	06265015	M.S. ANGLE-200X200X25MM	200000 KGS	14.08.2026
04	06265016	M.S. ANGLE 130X130X16MM	100000 KGS	14.08.2026
05	19260751A	E-70 VIGILANCE UNIT FOR 3-PHASE LOCOMOTIVE	08 NOS	17.08.2026
06	02260079	BRUSHLESS DC RAILWAY CARRIAGE FAN	6911 NOS	17.08.2026
07	77265080	COMBINATION FISH PLATE 1 M LONG	419 SET	21.08.2026
08	02260068	HERMETICALLY SEALED COMPRESSOR SCROLL TYPE, 3	778 NOS	24.08.2026
09	02262427	DIESEL LOCOMOTIVE STARTER LEAD ACID BATTERY	140 NOS	31.08.2026

Note:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. **www.ireps.gov.in** for details. **2.** No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No.: 28/2026-2027 Dated: 17.07.2026 **2473/2026**

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

Public Notice

Whereas Amolik Buildcon LLP in collaboration with M/s Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP, Shop No. 201-P, Sector-21C, Shopping Center, Faridabad-121012 in the process of setting up of a Residential Plotted Colony (under NILP-2022 policy) namely "87th Avenue" situated in the revenue estate of village Baselwa at Sector-87, Faridabad over an area measuring 10.15 acres under License No. 81 of 2026 dated 02.05.2026 valid upto 01.05.2031 granted by Directorate of Town and Country Planning Haryana, Chandigarh and having RERA registration No. HRERA-PKL-FBD-933-2026 dated 07.07.2026.

And whereas Amolik Buildcon LLP in collaboration with M/s Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP, obtained registration from Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority, Punchkula, and as per the special condition imposed by HRERA, are providing the details of bank account for the information of general public.

S. No.	Account name	ICICI Bank Account no.	Head	Bank details
01.	Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP Master Account for 87th Avenue	777705503320	100% collection Account	Bank Name: ICICI Bank Ltd. Branch Name: SCOF No. 56, Shopping Center, Sector-29, Faridabad. IFSC Code: ICIC0001400
02.	Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP RERA Account for 87th Avenue	777705503321	70% Rera Account	Bank Name: ICICI Bank Ltd. Branch Name: SCOF No. 56, Shopping Center, Sector-29, Faridabad. IFSC Code: ICIC0001400
03.	Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP Free Account for 87th Avenue	777705503322	30% current Account	Bank Name: ICICI Bank Ltd. Branch Name: SCOF No. 56, Shopping Center, Sector-29, Faridabad. IFSC Code: ICIC0001400

M/s Elite Housing Estate Maintenance Services LLP

ESAF

ESAF SMALL FINANCE BANK
REGD. OFFICE: ESAF Bhavan, Mannuthy, Thrissur- 680 651, Kerala

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts and remaining overdue/ unredeemed despite repeated notices will be auctioned for recovery of the Bank's dues, in accordance with applicable banking regulations and policies.

DETAILS OF AUCTION

Mode of Auction: Off-line (Physical Auction through Branches)
Date of Auction: 20-08-2026 **Time:** 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM
Auction Venues: The auction will be conducted at the following ESAF Small Finance Bank branches in **Haryana**

Interested bidders are requested to visit the respective branches for participation. For detailed branch addresses and contact numbers, please visit the Bank's official website

BRANCH NAME - LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER

Faridabad: 75260000044519.

Important Instructions: Borrowers may redeem their pledged gold ornaments by clearing the total dues along with applicable charges at least two days prior to the auction date. Interested bidders must carry valid KYC documents. GST Registration Number is mandatory for firms/companies, wherever applicable. Bidders are required to deposit an Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Rs.2,500 before participating in the auction. The auction will be conducted on an **"as is where is"** and **"as is what is"** basis. The Bank reserves the right to cancel/postpone the auction or reject any bid without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBJA Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.

Place: **Thrissur** (Sd/-) Authorized Signatory
Date: **18-07-2026** **ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd.**

JASCH GAUGING TECHNOLOGIES LTD.

Regd. Office: 502, Block-C, NDM-2, NSP, Pitampura, New Delhi 110034
CIN: L33111DL2021PLC381513
Website: www.jasch.net.in | Email: cs@jasch.biz
Phone: 0130-2216666

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to general public that 24-07-2026 has been fixed as the Record Date to determine the name of members who are entitled to receive notice of third Annual General Meeting (Post-listing) ("AGM") of the Company scheduled to be held on Tuesday, 25th August 2026 at 10.00 hours IST through video conferencing/ other audio-visual means. The process of sending emails to the registered email id of members is expected to be completed by 31st July 2026. The said email will contain link to the webpage where the soft copy of notice of the AGM, Annual Report, detailed instructions for participating in the AGM and for e-voting will be available. Any member who does not receive the aforesaid email may download a soft copy of these documents from the Company's website https://jasch.net.in/annualreports or from website of BSE www.bseindia.com. Members who have not provided/updated their email ids to/with their DP are requested to do so without any further delay. Members requiring hard copy of the Annual Report must write to the Company at least 5 days before the expected date of completion of the aforesaid process.

For any queries, kindly visit "Investors" Section of our aforesaid website, before writing to the Company or its Registrar & Share Transfer Agents as this Section contains answers to all general queries.

for Jasch Gauging Technologies Ltd
Sd/- (Neeraj Kumar)
Company Secretary

Sonipat,
17-07-2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Notice No.- Scrap Used Oil/E-Auction/SSB/2026-27 Dated:-16.07.2026

Ministry of Environment & Forests (MOEF) registered Purchasers/Firms, as recyclers/ re-processors for used oil, are invited to attend the E-Auction for Purchasing of used oil through bidding, conducted by General Store Depot, Northern Railway, Shakurbasti, Delhi-34 on 29.07.2026 at 10.30 A.M.

S. No.: 1, **Lot No.:** 4-2026-27-ELS-GZB, **Description:** Used Mixed Oil with M.S. Drums (Drum with Oil Capacity-205 Kgs Approx.) on As is Where is Basis. Sold along with Drums. Drum Qty.-100 Nos. As it is. **Location:-** Lying Near Machine Shop in Electric Loco Shed, Ghaziabad. **Qty.: 100 Nos.**

Railway reserves the right to cancel the E-Auction for used oil on the said date without assigning any reasons thereof. Unsold Material (Used Oil, if any) shall again be put up for sale in ensuing E-Auction. The detail of Lots/Qty. are available on website **www.ireps.gov.in** in auction catalogue Dated 29.07.2026.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE **2478/2026**

AXIS BANK

Retail Asset Centre: Axis House, Jaypee Green Wish Town, Tower-2, 4th Floor, Sec-128, Noida Expressway, Noida-201301 **Corporate Office:** 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 **Registered Office:** 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samartheswar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006 **Also at:** Axis Bank Ltd. Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor & First Floor, KG Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi-110001

POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) attentions is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower & Co-borrower	Date of Demand Notice/ Date of Possession/ Amt. in Demand Notice (Rs.)
1. Nitesh Kumar R/o Flat No.3, Khajani Devi Aparts, Near Navshakti Aparts, Ghitorni, New Delhi-110030 **Also At** Nitesh Kumar R/o Unit No. 1702, 17th Floor Tower-T, Canacy Green Sec-73, Gurugram Haryana-122004 **2. Bhawna Bhatia** R/o Flat No.3, Khajani Devi Aparts, Near Navshakti Aparts, Ghitorni, New Delhi-110030 **Description of Property :** All Piece & Parcels Unit No. 1702, 17th Floor Tower-T, Canary Green Sec-73, Gurugram Haryana	08-12-2025 / 15-Jul-2026 Rs. 29,16,550/-(Rupees Twenty Nine Lakhs Sixteen Thousand Five Hundred Fifty Only)
2. Mr. Rajbir Sharma S/o Om Prakash Sharma R/o H. No. 960, Sector-6 Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana- 124507 **Also At-** Mr. Rajbir Sharma S/o Om Prakash Sharma A-67, Vill-New Grain Market, Najazgarh, Delhi-110043 **Also At-** Mr. Rajbir Sharma (Proprietor) M/s. Bhagwan Dass Ramesh Chand Jain A-67, Ground Floor, Vill-New Grain Market, Najazgarh, Delhi-110043 **2. Mrs. Rajwati** W/o Mr. Rajbir Sharma R/o H. No- 960, Sec. 6 Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana- 124507 **Also At-** Mrs. Rajwati House No- 202-a, Lokesh Park, Nazafgarh, South West Delhi Delhi-110043 **Description of Property :** H No 960- P, Sec. 6, Urban Estate Huda, Dist. Jhajjar, Bahadurgarh, Haryana and bounded as under- East: as per title deed, West: as per title deed, South: as per title deed, North: as per title deed	23-04-2026 / 14.07.2026 Rs. 2,93,02,952/- (Rupees Two Crore Ninety Three Lakh Two Thousand Nine Hundred Fifty Two Only)
3. Bhagwan Dass Ramesh Chand Jain Through Its Proprietor Mr. Rajbir Sharma (Proprietor) M/s. Bhagwan Dass Ramesh Chand Jain A-67, Ground Floor, Vill - New Grain Market, Najazgarh, Delhi-110043 (Applicant) **2. Mr. Rajbir Sharma** S/o Om Prakash Sharm 0041' R/o: H. No- 960, Sector-6 Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana- 124507 **Also At-** Mr. Rajbir Sharma S/o. Om Prakash Sharma A-67, Vill- New Grain Market. Najazgarh, Delhi-110043 (Co-applicant) **3. Mrs. Rajwati** W/o. Mr. Rajbir Sharma R/o. H. No- 960, Sector-6 Bahadurgarh, Jhajjar, Haryana- 124507 Also At- Mrs. Rajwati H No- 202-A, Lokesh Park, Nazafgarh, South West Delhi Delhi-110043(Co-applicant) **Description of Property :** Residential Property Bearing H.no-960- P, Sector 6, Urban Estate Huda, Bahadurgarh, District Jhajjar, Bahadurgarh, Haryana And Bounded As Under- East: As per Title Deed, West: As per Title Deed, South: As per Title Deed, North: As per Title Deed	23-04-2026 / 14-Jul-2026 Rs. 1,63,60,514/- (Rupees One Crore Sixty Three Lakh Sixty Thousand Five Hundred Fourteen Only)
4. Mr. Tushar Chawla S/o Mr. Om Prakash Chawla Villa No VA-30, Tata Primanti, Southern Peripheral Road, Near Vatika Chowk Sector-72 fazilpur, Gurgaon, Haryana-122101 **Also At-** Mr. Tushar Chawla M/s. Fitness Thugz 1st Floor 139-141, DLF Qutab Plaza, Near Corporation Bank, DLF Phase-1, Gurgaon Haryana- 122001 **2. Mr. Om Prakash Chawla** S/o Mr. Tulsi Ram Chawla Villa No.VA-30, Tata Primanti, Southern Peripheral Road, Near Vatika Chowk Sector-72 Fazilpur, Gurgaon, Haryana- 122101 **Description of Property :** Apartment Bearing Villa No. Va-30, in the project known as " Primanti " Situated at Sector-72, Fazilpur, Gurgaon, Haryana and bounded as under-North: as per site plan , East : as per site plan, West: as per site plan, South: as per site plan	23-04-2026 / 15-Jul-2026 Rs. 2,52,85,490.62/ (Rupees Two Crore Fifty Two Lakh Eighty Five Thousand Four Hundred Ninety and Paisa Sixty Two Only)

The above-mentioned borrower/ Co-Borrower/guarantor are hereby given a 30 days Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged property will be sold on the expiry of 30 days from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002. The borrower's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub Section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Place: Delhi/NCR, Date: 18.07.2026 **-SD/- Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.**

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA — CORRIGENDUM

SR. NO.	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	OLD REFERENCE/NIT NO.	NATURE OF CORRIGENDUM	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	DIRECTORATE OF STATE TRANSPORT HARYANA,	DST/LNB/PIPLI/01 TENDER ID- 2026_HRY_525923_1	DEVELOPMENT OF BUS TERMINAL AT PIPLI (KURUKSHETRA) ALONG WITH COMMERCIAL FACILITIES UNDER PPP MODE. THE CLOSING DATE IS EXTENDED UP TO 17.08.2026 TILL 17:00 HOURS AND OPENING OF TECHNICAL BID WILL BE 18.08.2026 AFTER 12:00 HOUR	https://hartrans.gov.in http://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722710371 landbuilding0002@gmail.com
2	DIRECTORATE OF STATE TRANSPORT HARYANA,	DST/LNB/GURUGRAM/01 TENDER ID-2026_HRY_525884_1	DEVELOPMENT OF BUS TERMINAL AT SECTOR- 29 GURUGRAM ALONG WITH COMMERCIAL FACILITIES UNDER PPP MODE. THE CLOSING DATE IS EXTENDED UP TO 17.08.2026 TILL 17:00 HOURS AND OPENING OF TECHNICAL BID WILL BE 18.08.2026 AFTER 12:00 HOURS	https://hartrans.gov.in http://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722710371 landbuilding0002@gmail.com
3	DIRECTORATE OF STATE TRANSPORT HARYANA,	DST/LNB/KARNAL/01 TENDER ID- 2026_HRY_525904_1	DEVELOPMENT OF BUS TERMINAL AT KARNAL (BALARI BYE- PASS) ALONG WITH COMMERCIAL FACILITIES UNDER PPP MODE. THE CLOSING DATE IS EXTENDED UP TO 17.08.2026 TILL 17:00 HOURS AND OPENING OF TECHNICAL BID WILL BE 18.08.2026 AFTER 12:00 HOURS	https://hartrans.gov.in http://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722710371 landbuilding0002@gmail.com
4	DIRECTORATE OF STATE TRANSPORT HARYANA,	01/2026-27/SPA-1/TECH TENDER ID:- 2026 HRY 53109 1	ONLINE TENDER FOR INSTALLATION AND COMMISSION OF 24 NOS. OF 125 KVA GEN SETS THE CLOSING DATE IS EXTENDED UP TO 24.07.2026 TILL 15:00 HOURS AND OPENING OF TECHNICAL BID WILL BE 27.07.2026 AFTER 15:00 HOURS	https://hartrans.gov.in http://etenders.hry.nic.in	01722710371 jstchry@gmail.com
5	EMPLOYEES STATE INSURANCE (ESI),HARYANA	MEMO NO. 1/336-ESI-G2-2026/4167 DATED 07.07.2026	APPLICATION FOR TIE-UP OF PRIVATE HOSPITALS FOR SECONDARY CARE HEALTH FACILITY FOR INSURED PERSON UNDER ESI SCHEME IN HARYANA (EXCEPT FARIDABAD &GURUGRAM) THE CLAUSE 3 POINT NO.2 (PROCEDURE FOR DE-EMPANELMENT/BLACKLISTING) ON PAGE NO. 17 OF EOI HAS BEEN MODIFIED WITH ADDENDUM. KINDLY VISIT CORRIGENDUM COLUMN OF TENDER ON E-TENDER HARYANA WEBSITE	hryesi.gov.in	9988701049 esi@ihry.nic.in

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT : www.etenders.hry.nic.in RO 47295-I-27-7

PUBLIC NOTICE

It isto inform to the public at large that **Mrs. Shakeena Khatoon** is purchasing the **L.I.G. Flat No. G-5, Ground Floor without roof right, measuring 30.65 Sq. Mtrs., Plot No-II-B/91, Sector-II-B, Vaishali, Ghaziabad, U.P.** from **Mrs. Kalpana, Mrs. Upasna Goyal, Mr. Megh Gopal, Mr. Nikunj Kumar Agarwal & Mr. Prabhat Goyal** and same to be mortgage from **Hinduja Housing Finance Ltd., Branch-Laxmi Nagar.** That, **Mrs. Kalpana & Mrs. Kusumlata** are the owners of the property vide **Sale Deed dated 09.04.2015 (Doc. No.6809)**. Further, **Mrs. Kusumlata died on 26.12.2021 leaving behind her legal heirs namely (1) Mr. Prabhat Goyal (Son) (2) Mr. Megh Gopal (Husband) (3) Mr. Nikunj Kumar Agarwal (Son) (4) Mrs. Upasna Goyal (Daughter)**. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within **7 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
B-93B, Second Floor, Opp. SBI Bank Sector 2,Noida,UP-201301Contact#0120-4269379

Four Delhi districts achieve 100% SIR form distribution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Four districts in Delhi have achieved 100 per cent distribution of enumeration forms under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, marking the near-completion of the door-to-door exercise as booth-level officers shift their focus to collecting and digitising completed forms.

According to the cumulative status report issued by Delhi's Chief Electoral Officer on Thursday, four districts — Old Delhi, New Delhi, North East and South — have completed distribution of forms to all electors in their districts. Overall, 1,44,44,600 forms have been distributed, covering 99.55 per cent of Delhi's 1.45 crore electors.

The number of digitised forms has risen to 26,02,654, taking digitisation to nearly 18 per cent of the electorate. With the distribution exercise virtually complete, election officials expect the pace of digitisation to pick up in the coming days.

The Election Commission on Wednesday revised the SIR schedule for Delhi.

House-to-house visits by booth-level officers (BLOs), earlier scheduled to conclude on July 29, will now continue till August 8.The draft electoral rolls will be published on August 17, while the final electoral rolls will now be published on October 19, instead of October 7.

Meanwhile, claims and objections can be filed from August 17 to September 16 and will be disposed of by October 15.

While the extension gives BLOs more time, many said the challenge has now shifted from door-to-door visits to uploading thousands of completed forms through the Election Commission's mobile application.

"Everything has to be uploaded digitally. Learning the app, scanning documents and entering every detail correctly takes me much longer. Whenever there's a technical issue, I often seek help from my son or younger colleagues," said Manish, a teacher in his 50s serving as a BLO.

Another BLO, Abhishek, said the exercise remained time-bound despite the large number of voters to be covered. "There is pressure to move quickly because so many voters have to be covered," he said.

Many BLOs, most of whom are teachers, anganwadi workers and other government employees assigned election duty alongside or in place of their regular work, have also spoken of long hours, repeated visits to locked houses, and the pressure of meeting deadlines while ensuring accurate digitisation.

Besides the four districts with complete coverage, Central and Outer North recorded 99.89 per cent distribution, while South East stood at 99.85 per cent. North West remained the lowest at 97.26 per cent.

In terms of digitisation, South West led with 3,45,526 uploaded forms, followed by West (3,13,489), Outer North (2,77,429), North East (2,77,102) and North West (2,69,813).

Percentage-wise, Outer North recorded the highest digitisation rate at 33.32 per cent, followed by South West (25.98 per cent), Central North (21.91 per cent), West (21.53 per cent) and North West (21.13 per cent). Meanwhile, South East had the lowest digitisation rate at 11.22 per cent, followed by Old Delhi (11.25 per cent), East (11.34 per cent), Central (13.87 per cent) and South (13.89 per cent).

Under the SIR exercise, BLOs have distributed two copies of the enumeration form to every elector. One copy is retained by the voter as acknowledgement, while the other is submitted to the BLO after being filled. Voters can also submit their forms online.

VOTERS DELETED, FORMS NOT DELIVERED: DELHI'S ELECTORAL ROLL DRIVE HAS A GROUND PROBLEM

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
New Delhi

Sushil Kumar, who came to Delhi from Bihar and has been a resident of Delhi for multiple decades. In the year 2003, he was a resident of East Delhi, Pandav Nagar area. He voted in that year's Delhi assembly election from the Laxmi Nagar booth. He had filled an enumeration form earlier, but nothing moved until a Booth Level Officer knocked on his door this month as part of Phase III of the Special Intensive Revision.

The BLO came, the form was filled properly, and his family's voter registration is now in order. For Sushil Kumar, the system eventually worked. For his neighbours in other parts of the city, it has not. In Khajuri Khas, three residents who say they have lived in the same locality for 15 years, Jugnesh Singh, Aryan Singh, and Reema Devi, have found their names missing from the electoral roll. The reason, they allege, is BLO inefficiency. Their EPIC numbers were cancelled, and they are now outside the roll entirely.

When they contacted the election office, they were told to fill Form 6 or apply afresh for an EPIC card. In a city where 1.45 crore voters are being revisited door to door, the quality of the person doing the visiting is making the difference between being a voter and being erased as one.In Trilokpuri, residents say their BLO has been genuinely helpful, going out of the way to resolve documentation issues and ensure eligible voters are not dropped.

These ground-level experiences have now acquired political weight. The Aam Aadmi Party on Friday alleged serious irregularities in the SIR exercise, claiming that eligible voters, particularly from poor and migrant communities, are being systematically left out.

Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj alleged at a press conference that around 14 lakh voters had been removed during a pre-SIR exercise. However, the enumeration forms for Delhi's SIR of electoral rolls have been distributed to 1,44,60,313 of the city's 1,45,10,298 registered electors, covering 99.66 percent of the total electorate as of 8 pm on Friday, with five districts, Old Delhi, New Delhi, North East, and South, each achieving 100 percent distribution, according to the cumulative status report from the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer.North West District has the lowest distribution at 97.57 per cent, with 1,24,61,08 forms distributed out of 12,77,126 electors.

Over 66,000 DU aspirants accept UG seats allotted in first round

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

More than 66,000 candidates have accepted the undergraduate seats allotted to them by the University of Delhi within a day of the release of the first allocation list under the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS), according to admission data shared by the university on Friday. The university said 66,251 candidates had accepted their allotted seats till Friday.

Of these, applications of 6,826 candidates had reached the "Approved by Principal" stage, while 896 candidates had completed the admission process by paying the requisite fees. The university also said that 5,141 candidates had been allotted their first preference in the initial round of admissions.

Delhi University has made over 21,000 additional seat allocations in the first round of undergraduate admissions this year, with officials saying the move, based on data from previous admission cycles, is aimed at ensuring optimal seat occupancy.

On Thursday, the university announced the first allocation list for admissions to 221 undergraduate programmes across 67 colleges, offering seats to 93,033 candidates against more than 71,000 available seats for the 2026-27 academic session.

The allocations were made from among 2,08,043 candidates who completed Phase 2 of the admission process by submitting their programme and college preferences. Overall, 2,18,284 candidates completed registration on the CSAS portal.

According to the university, 93,033 candidates, including 42,019 male and 51,014 female applicants, received seat allocations in the first round, reflecting an overall allocation rate of 86.1 per cent. A total of 15,942,385 unique programme-college preferences were considered during the allocation exercise. Among special category admissions, 1,243 single girl child candidates and 242 orphan candidates, including 109 male and 133 female applicants, were allotted seats.

Candidates allotted seats in the first round can accept their allocations till 11.59 pm on July 18. Colleges will verify and approve the applications after which candidates will have to complete fee payment.

The university has advised candidates wishing to be considered for a higher preference in subsequent rounds to opt for the "upgrade" option. The second allocation list is scheduled to be released on July 25.

Meanwhile, the Delhi University Sports Council has released the schedule for sports trials under the Sports Supernumerary Quota for undergraduate admissions. The trials will be conducted from July 29 to August 3 across various venues in Delhi for different sports disciplines.

DU FORMS PANEL TO CONSIDER INCREASE IN SEATS FOR ONE-YEAR PG PROGRAMMES

New Delhi: Delhi University has constituted a six-member committee to examine requests for increasing the number of seats in its one-year postgraduate programmes for the 2026-27 academic session. According to a notification issued on Friday, the university has received requests seeking an increase in seats in the one-year postgraduate courses being offered across various departments.

"The competent authority has constituted the following committee to consider the request and suggest measures for implementation of the same. The committee may submit its recommendations within ten days," the notification said.

The committee will be chaired by Dean (Academic Affairs), with Dean (Admissions), Dean (Social Work), the Head of the Department of Chemistry, Joint Registrar (Legal) and Deputy Registrar (Recruitment and Promotion) as members.

The move comes amid concerns over the limited intake in the newly introduced one-year postgraduate programmes under the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.Earlier this week, Delhi University said 12,639 candidates had registered for admissions to its one-year postgraduate programmes.

The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) on Friday held a demonstration outside the Arts Faculty, demanding an increase in seats in the one-year postgraduate courses. *(PNS)*

Over 14,700 register for AUD UG admissions

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Dr B R Ambedkar University Delhi (AUD) has received more than 14,700 registrations for its undergraduate programmes for the 2026-27 academic session against 1,194 available seats, with the admission process currently underway, the university said on Friday.

According to the university, admissions to its 23 undergraduate programmes began on July 1 and will continue till July 20, after which admission lists will be published. A total of 14,758 registrations have been received so far for the undergraduate courses.

The university also reported a strong response to its postgraduate, doctoral and Integrated Teacher Education Programme (ITEP), attributing the trend to growing student interest in its interdisciplinary and research-oriented academic environment.

Admissions to 28 two-year master's programmes and seven one-year master's programmes commenced on May 21 through the CUET-PG admission portal. The registration process concluded on June 26 after being extended twice to facilitate greater participation.

The university said it received 12,445 registrations for postgraduate admissions against 1,613 seats across its one-year and two-year master's programmes. Further rounds of seat allocation are currently underway.

For its PhD programmes, AUD has received 2,455 registrations against 188 seats so far. Applications for admissions to 21 doctoral programmes opened on June 5 and will remain open till July 31.

The university is also conducting admissions for its four-year Integrated Teacher Education Programme (ITEP) at the Lodhi Road campus. Introduced in line with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, the programme has received 872 registrations for its two offerings, B.A. B.Ed. (Preparatory Stage) and B.A. B.Ed. (Secondary Stage), against a combined intake of 100 seats.

The university said the programme integrates disciplinary knowledge with professional teacher education through a multidisciplinary and practice-oriented curriculum aimed at preparing future educators.

DU issues warning over defacement ahead of DUSU polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi University's proctor has warned office-bearers of the Delhi University Students' Union (DUSU) and representatives of various student organisations against defacement of public property and violations of the election code of conduct ahead of the 2026 DUSU elections, expected to be held in September.

The advisory was issued during a meeting on Thursday between University Proctor Manoj Kumar Singh, his team, DUSU office-bearers and representatives of various student bodies to discuss the conduct of the elections and compliance with the Delhi High Court guidelines and the Lyngdoh Committee recommendations.

According to the advisory released on Friday, signed by the proctor, "Discussions were held, and it was very clearly affirmed that there shall be no defacement of public property in and around the campus and no billboards (printed and digital) and banners are to be pasted or suspended from the polls."

Only handmade posters displayed at the designated "Wall of Democracy" will be allowed. The university also prohibited block printing or spray painting on walls and said that flex posters cannot be displayed on Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) advertisement boards.

The proctor stated that the university would inform the MCD commissioner if any such violations were detected by authorities.

"The student elections are to be held within six to eight weeks from the start of the academic session. Since the session is scheduled to start from July 28, the elections are expected to be held in the second or third week of September," Singh said

Singh added, "We want to ensure a smooth election, without any hurdles, which is why we have started creating awareness early."

The university also barred candidates from pasting stickers bearing their names on vehicles, including cars, jeeps, buses, auto-rickshaws and e-rickshaws.

It said that each candidate would be allowed only five cars for election campaigning, while the use of tractors, JCB machines or animals would not be permitted.

Vehicles with tinted windows or concealed registration numbers would also be prohibited, and unauthorised vehicles parked on the campus could be challaned or towed away in accordance with traffic police regulations.

Govt plans global tender for secretariat building project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to issue a global tender in its ambitious plan to construct the new 'twin-towers' Secretariat building at ITO, a plan that will see two major buildings functioning as a unified administrative hub built on 17.5 acres of land, divided by a major road.

Conceived several years ago, the twin-tower project is moving to its preliminary stage as the government plans to bring all its departments at one location that are currently scattered across the city.

"ITO has emerged as the most feasible location after discussions. Especially with cooperation from the Income Tax department now, we have availability of a bigger plot to come up with development of the twin-towers project for which we will float a global tender," Parvesh Sahib Singh, PWD minister said.

A global tender will be floated to carry out the work, where major construction companies from across the world, can participate, bring in their technology and expertise, he added.

"The Income Tax department's Ayakar Bhawan located at ITO is an old building. The department has expressed its agreement to share its 4.5 acre land for the proposed twin-tower project in return of 10 lakh square feet built up area in the new buildings to shift its office," a senior official said.

Several models are proposed for the twin-tower project. Earlier, six locations were shortlisted out of which the ITO location emerged as the most feasible due to possibility of easy land availability.

"The Delhi government has 13 acres of land available in the form of PWD building and Vikas Bhawan at ITO. The Vikas Bhawan and PWD building lie across the Vikas Marg. If the plan moves in the right direction and 4.5 acre land of the IT department is made available, the twin-towers may come up at ITO, linked through a skywalk," Singh added.

With several of its offices scattered around and limited space available at the Players Building near Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium where the chief minister, her cabinet colleagues and top bureaucrats currently operate, the Delhi Government has decided to build a new Delhi Secretariat at Indraprastha Estate, where the MSO building and Vikas Bhawan, north and south of Vikas Marg, would be connected by a skywalk.

The new secretariat building will be a high-rise comprising 30 to 35 storeys, having offices of CM, ministers, bureaucrats and staffs.

It will also be a green building with facilities for parking, seminar room, conference room with each of the above offices and other facilities.

Neighbour held for murder of missing 3-year-old girl in Kapashera

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

A 37-year-old tailor has been arrested for allegedly murdering his three-year-old neighbour in Delhi's Kapashera, days after the child went missing. The accused was injured in an exchange of fire with police during his arrest, officials said on Friday.

According to Delhi Police, the three-year-old girl had gone missing on the evening of July 10. Following this, an FIR was registered at Kapashera police station under Section 137(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), and an investigation was launched.

On the intervening nights of July 14 and 15, police received information about the recovery of a child's body from the Kapashera drain near FIMT College. The body was identified as that of the missing girl. A crime team examined the spot, while the post-mortem confirmed that the child had been murdered before her body was dumped in the drain.

During the investigation, police analysed CCTV footage and identified Chandan Kumar (37) as a suspect after finding his movements suspicious. Police said Kumar, who lived in the same building as the victim's family and was the child's neighbour, was traced to his hideout in Kapashera village on July 16.

According to police, the accused allegedly opened fire on the raiding team when officers attempted to apprehend him. In response, police fired one round in self-defence and to effect his arrest, injuring him in his left leg. He was subsequently arrested, and a country-made pistol along with one live cartridge was recovered from his possession. Kumar was shifted to a government hospital for treatment and remains stable.

During preliminary interrogation, Kumar allegedly confessed to murdering the child, police said.

The accused is a native of Ballia district in Uttar Pradesh and worked as a tailor while residing in Kapashera. Police said he is married, though his wife and five-year-old son live in his native village. Police said efforts are underway to ascertain the motive behind the murder, and further investigation is in progress. Appropriate legal action is being taken in accordance with the law.

Police file 973-page chargesheet in UPSC aspirant rape-murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Nearly three months after a 24-year-old UPSC aspirant was allegedly raped, murdered and robbed at her East of Kailash residence, the Delhi Police has filed a 973-page chargesheet against the accused, stating that scientific and forensic evidence has established a complete chain of evidence in the case.

The chargesheet was filed before a Delhi court on July 16, with the matter scheduled for a hearing on July 18. According to police, the case pertains to the April 22 incident at Kailash Hills under the Amar Colony police station limits, where the woman was found dead after allegedly being sexually assaulted. Police said valuables were also stolen from the house.

Investigators identified the accused, Rahul Kumar Meena, 23, through CCTV footage analysis and arrested him the same day after sustained efforts by multiple police teams.

The allegedly stolen property was also recovered from his possession.

According to the police, more than 100 CCTV cameras were scanned to trace the accused's movements before and after the crime.

The investigation also involved extensive field enquiries, with officers examining neighbours, security guards, domestic workers, labourers, drivers, sweepers and other people in the area. Teams were simultaneously dispatched to Rajasthan, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh and different parts of Delhi to gather evidence and verify leads.

The Pioneer
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IN FOCUS

SFI and DYFI members hold placards as they stage a protest to express solidarity with Sonam Wangchuk over his ongoing hunger strike demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in NEET examination in Guwahati on Friday PTI

India's longest water tunnel nears opening in MP

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
Jabalpur

The Sleemanabad Tunnel, a flagship component of the Bargi Diversion Project, has become a significant milestone in irrigation infrastructure within central India. Following seventeen years of persistent efforts and the overcoming of substantial geological challenges, the project has entered its final phase.

Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav, widely recognised as the 'Bhagirath' of the Vindhya region for his unwavering dedication to water resource development, is anticipated to inaugurate the tunnel for public use. Located in Sleemanabad, Katni district, and constructed by the Narmada Valley Development Authority, the tunnel extends approximately 11.952 kilometres, rendering it India's longest and most complex water tunnel. Its notable feature is the sole reliance on gravity to convey Narmada waters, obviating the need for pumping. This gravity-driven system ensures efficiency and long-term sustainability, exemplifying advanced engineering and strategic planning.

The construction process faced extraordinary difficulties. Engineers and workers contended with extensive seepage ranging from 18,000 to 25,000 litres per minute, highly resistant rock formations, large underground cavities resembling dark pits, and repeated damage to the Tunnel Boring Machine (TBM). Over 4 crore cubic metres of material were excavated amid high groundwater levels and extensive cuttings spanning several hundred metres. These obstacles were successfully surmounted by

deploying state-of-the-art German Herrenknecht Tunnel Boring Machines and specialised TBM grouting technology. This achievement reflects the determination of Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav, combined with modern engineering and scientific innovation.

The broader Bargi Diversion Project, initiated in 2008, has achieved 96.66 per cent pper cent in physical development. Both the 11.952-kilometre main water tunnel and the 12.135-kilometre open-cut canal have been fully completed. Additionally, 0.725 kilometres of the 0.913-kilometre cut-and-cover canal have been constructed. To date, the project has incurred a total expenditure of ₹1,610.47 crore.

The benefits of this transformative initiative are extensive. It will provide irrigation to 245,000 hectares across six districts- Jabalpur, Katni, Maihar, Satna, Rewa, and Panna, serving approximately 1,450 villages. This development is expected to significantly enhance agricultural productivity, promote water conservation, and strengthen the rural economy in the Vindhya and Mahakaushal regions. District-wise irrigation potential includes 21,823 hectares in Katni, 54,227 hectares in Maihar, 104,970 hectares in Satna, 3,532 hectares in Rewa, and 448 hectares in Panna. The project follows a phased implementation plan, with irrigation capacity projected to reach 44,160 hectares by March 2026, 87,433 hectares by December 2026, and 154,693 hectares by December 2027.

Furthermore, water will be supplied to 30,307 hectares under various Water Resources Department projects, contributing to a cumulative coverage of 185,000 hectares across five districts. By channelling the sacred waters of the Narmada River to agricultural fields in Vindhya and Mahakaushal through this gravity tunnel, the project realises Chief Minister Dr Mohan Yadav's vision of "*Har Khet Ko Jal, Har Kisan Ho Sabal*," ensuring water access for every field and empowerment for each farmer. As the final works near completion, the Sleemanabad Tunnel is poised to usher in a new era of agricultural prosperity, sustainable development, and economic upliftment for the farming communities of Madhya Pradesh.

Delhi marks 100th martyrdom day of Teja Singh Samundri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday paid tribute to his grandfather, renowned Akali leader Sardar Teja Singh Samundri, on his 100th martyrdom anniversary at Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib, where several eminent dignitaries gathered to honour the freedom fighter's legacy.

The commemorative programme, held at Bhai Lakhi Shah Vanjara Hall, was attended by former President Ram Nath Kovind, Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant, former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's wife Gursharan Kaur, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, members of the Delhi Cabinet, judges of the Supreme Court and High Court, and a large gathering of devotees. The event also featured soulful Shabad Kirtan by Padma Shri Bhai Harjinder Singh (Srinagar Wale), followed by Guru ka Langar.

Sardar Teja Singh Samundri, one of the foremost leaders of the Akali movement and a key architect of the Gurdwara Reform Movement, was martyred in Lahore Jail on July 17, 1926, while serving the Panth. He played a pivotal organisational role in the formative years of the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) and was instrumental in leading several peaceful protest movements, including the Guru Ka Bagh Morcha, Rakabganj Morcha, Jaito Morcha, Nabha Morcha and Chabiyan Morcha.

Beyond his contribution to Sikh religious reform, Samundri was also remembered for championing social equality. According to the note, he took a stand against caste discrimination by encouraging Dalits to draw water from common village wells and publicly serving them, while also establishing schools in Sarhali and Lyallpur in 1917 to promote education. His work earned recognition beyond the Sikh community, with the Indian National Congress reportedly seeking his inclusion in its Working Committee. He was also associated with the founding efforts of the Hindustan Times in 1924.

Samundri as a leader known for his humility, organisational ability and commitment to non-violent resistance. Despite repeated imprisonment, he remained steadfast in his service until his death in Lahore Jail a century ago. His ideals of selfless service, moral courage and dedication to public life continue to inspire generations, the LG said.

Maharashtra's SIR deadline extended by 10 days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai

The Election Commission has extended the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Maharashtra by 10 days, with the exercise now set to wrap up on August 8 instead of July 29, an official said on Friday.

As per a notification from the poll authority, the draft electoral rolls for the State will now be published on August 17 instead of the earlier scheduled date of August 5.

The period for filing claims and objections is from August 17 to September 16, and the disposal of the same will be done by October 15, with the final publication of electoral rolls scheduled on October 19, it stated. The drive, which began in the state on June 30, is part of the Election Commission's efforts to update and verify electoral rolls.

The official said that the deadline was extended following requests from political parties and the poll personnel in view of the recent heavy rains in parts of Maharashtra.

During the SIR exercise, booth-level officers (BLOs) are conducting house-to-house verifications, while voters are required to submit enumeration forms and supporting documents where necessary to ensure accurate registration.

PM Modi opens 4 redeveloped railway stations in Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Ahmedabad

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday virtually inaugurated Pratapnagar, Godhra, Porbandar and Bhaktinagar railway stations in Gujarat that have been redeveloped at an investment of ₹109 crore under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, an official said.

These are among 75 such redeveloped railway stations nationwide that Modi dedicated under the scheme, marking another milestone in the modernisation of Indian Railways, stated an official release.

Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel participated in the inauguration ceremony held at Pratapnagar railway station under Vadodara division. He also visited a special exhibition highlighting its transformation with state-of-the-art facilities, the release said.

"With four more railway stations - Pratapnagar, Bhaktinagar, Porbandar and Godhra dedicated to the nation under the Amrit Bharat Station Scheme, Gujarat now has 22 redeveloped Amrit Bharat stations," it said.

Notably, Modi had earlier inaugurated 18 redeveloped railway stations in the State in May last year.

"As many as 87 more railway stations across Gujarat are currently undergoing redevelopment, reflecting the State's continued commitment to strengthening railway infrastructure and supporting India's railway modernisation mission," the release informed.

Entire education system involved in paper leaks, says Rahul Gandhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Dehradun

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Friday alleged that the entire education system, from top to bottom, is involved in paper leaks, due to which 7.5 crore students have suffered so far.

Addressing a 'Chhatron ki Goonj' rally here on Friday evening, Gandhi said while cases of paper leaks are rising

by the day due to the "corrupt system", no action against the guilty, including conviction, has been taken till now.

He also said that no political party should have a "hold" on educational institutions, which should be independent. "The vice-chancellor should not be from one organisation. The in-charge of the National Testing Agency (NTA) should not be from a political outfit," he said.

The Congress leader claimed that 1 per cent of students with money and connections are getting paper leaks done, affecting 99 per cent of the "honest middle class" and "poor students".

TV journalist questioned in TVK MLA bribery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

A journalist of a Tamil news television channel has been questioned in connection with the case of "alleged offer of bribe" to a ruling TVK legislator, police said on Friday.

The senior news editor was questioned for a couple of days, and his mobile phone was seized for a cyber forensic analysis, they said.

An official Chennai city police release said that a case was registered at Triplicane Police Station based on a complaint lodged by the ruling TVK legislator N Elaiyaraja (Uthangarai Assembly constituency in Krishnagiri).

In his complaint, he alleged that Thirunavukkarasu, a YouTuber from Arumbakkam, Chennai, who runs an "opinion survey organisation", along with several other persons, attempted to influence him to vote contrary to the decision of his party, the TVK, during "voting" in

the Legislative Assembly.

It was further alleged by the MLA that he was offered an illegal gratification of Rs 35 crore for voting as instructed by the accused.

Also, the legislator claimed that since he refused to cooperate, the accused intimidated him and his family members and issued "death threats." Based on the complaint, a case was registered at Triplicane station, and an investigation was taken up.

Investigation revealed that Thirunavukkarasu, along with several others, had hatched a conspiracy under the code name "Meghalaya Project", with the objective of inducing nearly fifteen TVK MLAs through illegal monetary inducements, thereby attempting to destabilise the elected Government.

During examination of the documentary and digital evidence collected during the investigation, it was found that Vijayan, senior news editor of the Tamil channel, had exchanged "objectionable electronic communications with the arrested accused, Thirunavukkarasu, and had remained in continuous contact with him during the period of the alleged criminal conspiracy."

FROM PAGE - 1

PM sounds the poll bugle in Punjab

PM Modi also accused the Punjab Government of surviving on borrowed money while development had stalled.

Alleging that it was "enjoying on debt", he claimed Government funds meant for Punjab were not being properly utilised and that the State Government merely pasted its own stickers on Union Government schemes while "hiding Punjab's reality behind advertisements".

Describing the ruling party as a "kattar beimaan" (hardcore dishonest) outfit, the PM alleged that corruption, bribery, and extortion had become its political identity, referring to corruption cases involving its leaders. Without naming him, he also cited the recent conviction of a former AAP leader in the 2020 Delhi riots case, accusing the party of questioning a court verdict for vote-bank politics.

The PM further accused the AAP Government of allowing law and order to deteriorate, claiming gang wars, extortion, attacks on police stations and drug trafficking had become common.

Drawing comparisons with neighbouring Haryana, Modi claimed farmers there were receiving MSP on 24 crops while employees received 60 percent dearness allowance, unlike in Punjab.

Making one of his strongest electoral pitches ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections, Modi said Punjab now needed a BJP Government, insisting that only a "double-engine" administration could accelerate development. The rally also marked the first major BJP platform appearance of former AAP Rajya Sabha members Vikramjit Singh Sahney, Harbhajan Singh and Ashok Mittal after joining the party. However, Punjab political veteran and two-time former Chief Minister Capt Amarinder Singh skipped the event.

Gujarat ATS arrests five in suspected terror bust

ATS Deputy Inspector General Sunil Joshi stated that Shera's questioning revealed the existence of an additional group involved in planning explosive activities. "During the interrogation of Mohammed Amin Shera, detail emerged indicating the involvement of another group in the preparations for an explosion," Joshi explained.

The suspects remain in ATS custody and are undergoing further interrogation. They have been identified as Bilal Shera, 24, a resident of Ahmedabad; Mohammad Ayyub Kadiwal, 22, from Patan; Mohammad Ayyubbhai Sunsara, 20, also from Patan; Shafi Raees Mukhi, 21; and Mohammad Hasan Hanifbhai Kardiya, 20, from Patan. Despite diverse backgrounds, they are interconnected through their association with different madrasas across Gujarat.

Investigators are examining their movements, communications, and potential links to other individuals associated with the JeM module. They are also verifying whether the group has identified specific targets or has begun procuring materials for explosive devices.

Additional information is anticipated as interrogations proceed. The court will reconvene following the completion of the eight-day remand period. Further updates are expected as authorities assemble a comprehensive understanding of the module

SIT readies interim report on Ram Temple...

The SIT, formed by the State Government, has been reviewing claims of mismanagement and misappropriation of funds and offerings at the temple. The SC had directed the SIT to provide a status report on the handling of donations and called for increased transparency and accountability. Petitioners had demanded an independent, time-bound investigation to address allegations related to the collection, counting, and recording of cash and valuables offered by devotees.

Submission of the report to the SC is seen as a step toward complying with judicial directives and providing the court with updates on the investigation.

The allegations have sparked debate regarding the management of temple finances and the necessity for robust systems to protect devotees' offerings made in good faith. The trust has affirmed its cooperation with the investigation and its commitment to transparency.

Former temple officer arrested in Badrinath...

Identified as Rajendra Chauhan, he was arrested from Jyotirmath and brought to the Shri Badrinath police station. It is learnt that was a permanent employee of Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee and late became temple officer and counting in-charge before retiring from the job. Police said that CCTV footage had clearly shown Chauhan pocketing bundles of Rs 500 notes, donations and jewelry on several occasions on June 22, 25 and 29.
Based on the available electronic evidence and other evidence, he was named as a co-accused, police added.

Police further said that the accused is currently being questioned in detail. Notably, based on the complaint received in the matter, a case was registered at Shri Badrinath Kotwali and based on the preliminary investigation and available evidence, the police team arrested the prime accused, Pramod Nautiyal on 12 July. He is currently in judicial custody.

Ex-IB officer takes charge of Delhi Police

This appointment places a highly experienced intelligence professional at the helm of Delhi Police during a period when the security environment in the Capital remains complex and multifaceted.

Kumar has been extensively involved in national intelligence operations, threat assessment, and inter-agency coordination. His background is expected to enhance intelligence-led policing in Delhi Colleagues and analysts describe Kumar as a low-profile, results-oriented officer known for meticulous work. His tenure at the IB has provided him with a nuanced understanding of internal security dynamics and the delicate balance between law enforcement and civil liberties, traits that are especially valuable in Delhi, which frequently hosts protests, diplomatic events, and high-stakes political activities.

CM removal Bill hits...

The panel had recommended that the prime minister, Union ministers and chief ministers be suspended from their posts, if they are detained for 30 straight days on charges of serious offences — pending the outcome of legal proceedings. It also proposed an automatic reversal clause if such persons are acquitted or the prosecution does not proceed within a specified period.

It had proposed that the term "serious criminal offences" as mentioned in the statement of objectives and reasons of the Bill may be defined as "...serious criminal offences which are punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to five years or more".

Sarangi said the Government brought the Bill with the intent to stop corruption and to prevent criminalisation of politics. "This is a national cause. There should be unanimity in thought and expression," she said. Introduced last August by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the Bill seeks to automatically remove the PM, ministers or CMs on the 31st day of their detention if they don't step down on their own. The opposition has dubbed the Bill a tool to destabilise Governments run by them. Subsequently, the draft laws were referred to a Joint Committee of Parliament. Most opposition parties have opted out of the JPC examining the Bill.

Delimitation push takes...

The Ordinance was promulgated last month to attract foreign capital to ease pressure on the depreciating rupee due to the West Asia crisis. The Income-tax (Amendment) Bill, 2026, will replace the Income Tax (Amendment) Ordinance, 2026. Sources said the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, listed for introduction, consideration and passing, may be first brought in the Rajya Sabha. The amendment Bill seeks to give the national song Vande Mataram the same statutory protection as the national anthem Jana Gana Mana.

The Monsoon session of Parliament, beginning July 20, is likely to see Opposition attack on the Government on a variety of issues, including NEET paper leak, death of Indian seafarers in the West Asia conflict and the issue of blended petrol. The Opposition will also raise the issue of alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya. A weakened Opposition following assembly poll results in West Bengal, Assam, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, and differences between the Congress and the DMK over the formation of Government by the TVK in Tamil Nadu are likely to embolden the ruling alliance in Parliament during the session.

The DMK on Friday said it will study the Bill on proposed delimitation, as and when it is tabled in Parliament, and take a decision based on "merits" to protect Tamil Nadu's interests.

PM flags off India's first hydrogen-powered train

MANOJ KUMAR ■ Jind/Chadigarh

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday flagged off India's first hydrogen-powered train connecting Jind and Sonipat in Haryana, describing it as a landmark step towards clean and sustainable transportation and a successful example of the 'Make in India' campaign.

With this, India has joined a select group of countries that have operational hydrogen-powered trains and marks an important step towards the adoption of clean and sustainable mobility in the railway sector. After flagging off the train from Jind, the Prime Minister also dedicated to the nation and laid the foundation stone of various development projects worth ₹14,700 crore.

Modi said, "The hydrogen-powered train is a proud symbol of Aatmanirbhar Bharat and our commitment to cleaner, future-ready transportation." Today, Indian Railways has taken a major step and this is the world's most powerful hydrogen train, he said addressing a public gathering later. The 89-km distance between Jind and Sonepat will be covered in two hours, with the train halting at 12 intermediate stations.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the flag off ceremony of India's first hydrogen-powered train, between Jind and Sonipat, in the presence of Haryana Governor Ashim Kumar Ghosh, Union Minister Ashwani Vaishnaw and Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini at Jind Railway Station, Haryana PTI

Modi also took a veiled dig at the previous Congress-led UPA Government, saying had the situation due to West Asia conflict arisen before 2014, the work of Indian Railways would have come to a standstill as trains in large parts of the country used to run mainly on diesel.

"At that time, in large parts of our country our trains used to run on diesel only. Had diesel supplies been disrupted then, how would diesel-powered trains have operated? The country would have faced a massive crisis. But friends, this is not the situation of 2014. It is Modi, who thinks well before and also turns solutions to problems into reality on the ground," he said.

Referring to the West Asia conflict, Modi said, "You are seeing that for past several months, war has been going on in West Asia, across the entire region of (Strait of) Hormuz, involving Iran, and the Gulf. It is through this sea route through Hormuz that India receives a huge quantity of petrol, diesel, LPG gas, and fertilisers for our farmers. But for the last three to four months, this route has continuously remained a battlefield, surrounded by crisis."

He said Indian Railways has taken a big step in this 21st century technology as only three to four countries have the capability of running hydrogen-powered train.This train has 3200 horsepower and it is not only the most powerful, but also the longest one (10 coaches), Modi said. "At other places in the world, hydrogen train has three to four coaches only. But in India, this train has 10 coaches," he said.

By running a 10-coach hydrogen train, India has established its presence in the world (janda gaad diya hai), he said. "Here in Jind, all such things have been made for it. In the coming time, more infrastructure connected with hydrogen train will be made. New factories will come up which will meet the need of the hydrogen train network. This will generate new avenues of employment for Haryana youths," he said. Recalling his association with Jind, he said, "I cannot forget the love I have got." Jind's 'ghee' and 'ghevar' have not changed in years but its 'tevar' (attitude) has, he said, adding Jind is becoming a model of BJP's and NDA's good governance. Names of Jind, Sonepat and Haryana will come up whenever there is mention of hydrogen train, I congratulate the entire country, he added.

During his speech Modi also made a mention of 'Swachhta Se Swagat' (welcome through cleanliness) campaign in Jind which had been going on for past few days ahead of his visit.

Modi, while appreciating the working style of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that Haryana's double-engine Government is working on the mantra of Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Saini, the Haryana Government is doing excellent work for the youth, farmers, and women of the state.

The path shown by the Haryana Government of providing jobs without '*kharchi-parchi* ' was not easy, but the BJP Government has made it possible. Haryana is now moving rapidly on the path of development. Agriculture and industry are the two pillars that are strengthening Haryana, Modi added.

Nation Focus

SHAH ARRIVES IN SILIGURI ON THREE-DAY VISIT TO WEST BENGAL

Union Home Minister Amit Shah arrived at Bagdogra airport here on Friday night for a three-day visit to West Bengal, during which he will review border security, law and order, and the implementation of the new criminal laws, officials said. He is also scheduled to inaugurate development projects in Siliguri and Kolkata.

He was received by West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on his arrival at Bagdogra Airport around 9.10 pm.

After his arrival, Shah went to the Border Security Force's (BSF) North Bengal Frontier Headquarters at Kadamtala here, where he is scheduled to stay the night.

On Saturday, he will visit the BSF's 18th Battalion Border Outpost at Jumagach near the boundary with Bangladesh. (*PTI*)

'NO DAMAGE TO TERMINAL IN US ATTACKS ON CHABAHAR PORT'

The Shahid Beheshti terminal at the Chabahar port in Iran has not faced any damage in US strikes on the key maritime gateway, India said on Friday. US officials had acknowledged that the US struck the Chabahar port this week as part of its renewed military campaign against Iran.

The Chabahar port is being developed by India and Iran to boost connectivity and trade ties. Both the countries are also strongly pitching for making Chabahar port an integral part of the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC). The US waiver from its sanctions on Chabahar had come to an end in April. "There was a waiver which was given by America and that waiver got over some time back. Post that, we have been in discussion with relevant stakeholders as to how to take this particular issue forward," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said. (*PTI*)

TN CM Vijay conducts surprise inspection at social justice hostel in Chennai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay conducted a surprise inspection on Friday at the MC Raja Social Justice Hostel in Saidapet, where students presented a slew of grievances regarding substandard facilities, severe security lapses, and staff apathy.

During the interaction, students informed the Chief Minister that rigid hostel curfew timings are severely impacting residents who attend part-time jobs or competitive exam coaching, such as UPSC and TNPSC classes.

They reported that latecomers are routinely locked out of the premises, forcing them to sleep in public parks or outside the gates.

While locked out, students alleged they have faced harassment from local miscreants and instances of robbery.

Highlighting poor living conditions, the inmates complained of frequent water shortages, uncleaned and broken restrooms, and a lack of adequate drinking water.

Furthermore, students stated that the quality of food is persistently poor, noting that catering staff do not adhere to basic hygiene protocols like wearing gloves or hairnets.

Security remains a primary concern, added the students, pointing out a severe shortage of CCTV surveillance.

Although there is a requirement for 64 cameras, the existing setup provides only two cameras per floor, which cover only the reading areas and leave residential corridors unmonitored. Students told the Chief Minister that this lack of oversight has led to frequent thefts, internal altercations, and incidents of senior-junior ragging.

The residents also flagged the abusive behaviour of hostel personnel. They alleged that watchmen and supervisors frequently use derogatory language, subjecting the students from economically weaker sections to significant mental distress.

Additionally, students pointed out a general shortage of staff and stated that recreational facilities, including the volleyball court, have been kept locked and inaccessible for an extended period despite repeated requests.

West Bengal CM Adhikari lays foundation of ₹15,000 crore steel plant in Bankura

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

In yet another big ticket investment push Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday laid the foundation stone of a ₹15,000 crore extension project of a steel plant at Mejia in Bankura district some 200 km from Kolkata.

The steel plant is owned by the Shyam Steel Group which is likely to invest ₹15,000 crore in phases. The industrial unit was likely to generate about 15-20 thousand jobs. Out of the total ₹15,000-crore ₹10,000 crore is likely to be invested in a new 2-million-tonne-per-annum (MTPA) integrated steel plant and the remaining ₹5,000 crore would be used for defense manufacturing, real estate, and infrastructure, inside source said.

West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari greets the gathering during the foundation stone laying ceremony of Shyam Steel Group's integrated steel plant at Mejia in Bankura district on Friday. State Cabinet Minister Agnimitra Paul is also seen. PTI

"This plant promises massive job opportunities in the region and the surrounding areas of Purulia, West Bardhaman and West Midnapore, the Chief Minister said," adding it was not enough to recall the migrant workers back to Bengal from other States.

"If we cannot build the infrastructure in the State then how will the migrant workers return," he said adding these projects would not only help build industrial infrastructure but also generate revenue for the State.

Saying that the investors were returning to Bengal because of the political change of power that had taken place in the State after the recently concluded elections. "Had the change not taken place in Bengal the investments would have gone to Odisha ... in the coming days thousands of crores would be invested in Purulia, Bankura and Jangalmahal generating jobs for thousands of people who have been leaving Bengal as migrant workers," he said.

Speaking at the event, Adhikari promised an investor-friendly ecosystem, saying improved law and order, easier land availability, and employment-linked incentives would woo back the investors.

Ex-Japan minister accuses India over bullet train delays, Delhi hits back

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

A senior Japanese politician has triggered a diplomatic row by publicly blaming Indian authorities for the slow pace of the Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor, India's ambitious first bullet train project.

Hideki Makihara, former Justice Minister and a key figure in Japan's ruling Liberal Democratic Party, described the delays as stemming from "sheer recklessness" on the Indian side, claiming broken commitments and inconsistent decision-making have hampered progress.

In strongly worded remarks, Makihara alleged that Indian negotiators frequently reversed positions, prioritised domestic considerations, and failed to deliver on assurances related to the Shinkansen-based project. He singled out the handling by the concerned minister as particularly problematic, asserting that responsibility for the setbacks lay entirely with India.

The comments have drawn sharp attention as the project — funded substantially by Japan and touted as a symbol of bilateral friendship — has missed multiple deadlines since its foundation stone was laid in 2017.

India's Ministry of External Affairs responded swiftly, rejecting the criticism as one-sided.

Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal emphasised that the project continues to enjoy strong Japanese Government support, as reaffirmed in recent high-level summits.

Officials pointed to tangible advancements on the ground, including extensive viaduct work, bridge completions, and progress on the undersea tunnel section near Mumbai.

Indian authorities have consistently attributed the timeline slippages to practical challenges such as land acquisition hurdles in Maharashtra, pandemic-related disruptions, environmental clearances, and the technical complexities of integrating advanced systems. The National High Speed Rail Corporation Ltd (NHSRCL) has achieved significant physical progress, with plans for initial operations on a Gujarat segment by August 2027.

Originally envisioned for completion in the early 2020s, the 508-km corridor has seen its cost rise due to inflation, revised engineering needs, and extended timelines. Japan is providing next-generation Shinkansen technology, while India is simultaneously developing indigenous high-speed train prototypes to boost self-reliance.

Both nations have expressed commitment to overcoming remaining issues through ongoing technical dialogue.

The project is viewed not only as a transport upgrade but as a cornerstone of broader Indo-Japanese cooperation in infrastructure, technology transfer, and regional connectivity.

While Makihara's outspoken views have sparked debate, diplomatic sources indicate that core bilateral ties remain robust. The Government has assured that safety standards, quality benchmarks, and timely delivery will not be compromised as the country moves closer to realising its high-speed rail ambitions.

India's 1st geothermal wells commissioned in Ladakh's Puga Valley

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

India is gradually inching closer to realising its dream of establishing the first-ever Geothermal Power Plant in the cold desert region of Ladakh. Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Friday commissioned India's first and deepest two geothermal wells at Puga Valley in Ladakh, executed by ONGC Energy Centre.

The commissioning of the two 1000-meter-deep wells, at a high altitude of over 14,000 feet, would significantly advance Ladakh's journey towards becoming a clean energy hub, powered by renewable sources, as envisaged by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The two geothermal wells are critical for the successful implementation of the 1 MW pilot geothermal power project at Puga, which will be India's first demonstration-scale geothermal power project.

Speaking on the occasion, the LG termed the commissioning of the geothermal wells as a historic milestone in India's clean energy journey and a defining moment in Ladakh's transition towards a carbon-neutral future.

"This Geothermal Power project would act as a catalyst for Ladakh's holistic development. Beyond its scientific significance, this initiative will strengthen Ladakh's energy security, promote environmental sustainability and contribute to regional socio-economic development.

What has been achieved in Puga Valley would serve as a blueprint for India's net-zero journey and significantly contribute towards making Ladakh a carbon-neutral and environmentally sustainable region," LG Saxena said.

LG VK Saxena lauded the ONGC engineers, saying the Indian engineers and technicians were among the best in the world, capable of achieving the most difficult engineering feats, and they truly symbolise India's growing stature in the field of global engineering.

He also appreciated every worker associated with the project, saying it was a true testament to their grit, determination and perseverance.

The project has been undertaken in one of the world's most challenging operating environments, characterised by extreme weather conditions, rugged terrain and a limited annual working season.

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena commissions the first and deepest geothermal wells developed by the ONGC Energy Centre at Puga Valley in Ladakh PTI

The project also fulfils the PM's vision of Carbon-neutral Ladakh and the call to harness alternative, renewable energy sources for our future security.

Notably, the geothermal power project had suffered a major setback following the expiry of the earlier tripartite MoU between the Ladakh Administration, LAHDC Leh and ONGC Energy Centre, resulting in critical delays of several months in project execution.

Recognising the strategic importance of geothermal energy for India's energy security and clean energy transition, LG Saxena personally intervened to facilitate the renewal of the MoU for another five years, in June this year, following which works resumed for the completion of the two geothermal wells.

Successful completion of the two wells would facilitate critical reservoir evaluation, power plant planning and the eventual commercial development of geothermal resources in Ladakh. Project Engineers informed that the maximum temperature of 135 degrees Celsius was recorded at a depth of 400 meters.

Further testing is on and the engineers are hopeful to achieve even higher temperatures for operation of the 1MW pilot geothermal power project and eventual commercial exploration of geothermal energy.

Despite encountering geothermal activities, complex sub-surface conditions and operational challenges, the first of the two wells was successfully drilled to its target depth of 1000 metres on 22 May 2026.

Subsequently, the other geothermal well was spudded on 03 June 2026, and in a record time of just over a month, it was successfully drilled and completed to 1000 metres depth on 08 July 2026.

RSS misunderstood despite century of service: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday said the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) has been serving the country and society continuously for the last 100 years, but a large section of people remains either "uninformed" or "misinformed" about the organisation because of narratives built around it.

Addressing the release of the book 'RSS at 100: A Century of Service, Unity and Sacrifice' at the Vice President's Enclave here, Singh said the RSS has grown from a small voluntary organisation founded by Keshav Baliram Hedgewar in 1925 into the world's largest and financially self-reliant voluntary organisation.

"The RSS has been serving the nation and society for 100 years. Yet, even today, a large section of society is either uninformed or misinformed about it," he said.

Referring to American scholars Walter Andersen and Shridhar D Damle's book 'The Brotherhood in Saffron', Singh said the authors observed that the RSS is "difficult to understand and easy to misunderstand".

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta, and RSS leader Shyam Jaju release the book 'RSS at 100: A Century of Service, Unity & Sacrifice', authored by Shyam Jaju and Anupam Trivedi at the Vice-President's Enclave in New Delhi PTI

"One major reason for this, in my view, is the relative lack of objective and impartial academic work on the organisation. I believe this book will go a long way in filling that gap," he said.

Rejecting allegations that the RSS had no role in the freedom movement, Singh said such a narrative has been promoted for years and asserted that the organisation actively participated in the struggle against British rule.

"Those who hold this view should read the fourth chapter of this book. It explains that RSS volunteers actively participated in the freedom struggle. Dr Keshav Baliram Hedgewar himself went to prison during the freedom movement. During the Quit India Movement, RSS volunteers provided shelter to several revolutionaries in their homes," he said.

He also referred to the role of RSS volunteers during Partition, saying they worked in violence-hit areas to protect people.

States Focus

₹45 cr released to clear MIS apple procurement dues: CM

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu on Friday said payments for produce procured from apple growers under the Market Intervention Scheme (MIS) from 2022 to 2025 have been cleared through Direct Benefit Transfer.

Chairing a meeting of the horticulture department here, the chief minister said payments have already been made to growers who supplied up to 30 bags of apples under the Market Intervention Scheme (MIS) and the process for releasing payments to growers who supplied 100 bags or more was now underway.

In a statement, he said the state Government has released Rs 45 crore to clear the pending liabilities. Sukhu, who reviewed preparations for apple procurement under the scheme this season, launched the Horticulture MIS website and mobile application. The digital platform would facilitate end-to-end recording of the procurement process, from apple purchase to processing, ensuring greater transparency and efficiency. (*PTI*)

No room for lapses in WAVES 2027 preperations: Fadnavis

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday directed officials to begin preparations for WAVES (World Audio Visual and Entertainment Summit) 2027 conference on a war footing, stressing there should be no shortcomings in planning for the global event.

Chairing a review meeting here, Fadnavis asked officials to complete planning related to departmental responsibilities, budgeting, publicity, transport, technical infrastructure and inter-departmental coordination well in advance. He said the next edition of the conference should be "broader, more streamlined and more impactful" than the inaugural event. "The first WAVES conference created a strong impression globally and enhanced Maharashtra's brand value. The next edition should be organised on an even grander scale through meticulous planning," the chief minister said. (*PTI*)

ED raids 8 locations across Bihar, Delhi and Rajasthan

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) conducted coordinated searches at eight locations across Bihar, Delhi, and Rajasthan as part of an investigation into alleged large-scale illegal sand mining in Bihar's Banka district, amounting to ₹131 crore.

The operations took place on Friday and targeted premises associated with Mahadev Enclave, a company based in Banka controlled by Ashok Chandak and his son Raghav Chandak, both originally from Sri Ganganagar, Rajasthan. The locations searched included sites in Banka and Patna districts of Bihar, as well as in Delhi, Sri Ganganagar, and Jaipur. Preliminary investigations indicated that Mahadev Enclave engaged in illegal sand extraction in Banka without obtaining necessary permits or reporting to the Bihar Mining Department.

The extent of the violations was revealed following a geospatial analysis commissioned by the Enforcement Directorate from IIT Patna in October 2024, which concluded that the company had excavated sand valued at approximately ₹131 crore between the fiscal years 2015-16 and 2022-23. These findings were shared with the Bihar State Mining Corporation Limited, prompting the state's Mines and Geology Department to file an FIR with the police in August 2025.

The ongoing money-laundering investigation is a direct follow-up to that FIR. The operation spanning multiple states exemplifies the Enforcement Directorate's strategy to trace financial flows linked to environmental violations across jurisdictions. Officials said the raids in Delhi and Rajasthan suggest efforts to examine layered assets and proceeds held outside Bihar. Illegal sand mining remains a significant challenge, contributing to substantial revenue loss for Governments and irreversible ecological damage.

In Banka, the alleged extraction over nearly eight years underscores deficiencies in monitoring and enforcement by state authorities.

The involvement of IIT Patna in geospatial analysis indicates a shift towards data-driven investigations in such cases. The agency is expected to scrutinise bank accounts, property records, and financial transactions linked to the Chandak family and the company. No arrests have been made to date; however, the searches are likely to result in further questioning and potentially the provisional attachment of properties under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act.

The involvement of a Rajasthan-based family operating within Bihar also highlights the inter-state nature of such illicit activities.

The ED's actions align with increased scrutiny of sectors vulnerable to large-scale illegal extraction and money laundering. "The outcome of this investigation could set a precedent for the application of geospatial technology and inter-agency cooperation in combating environmental crimes with significant financial implications", an official said.

5 dead as train hits car at crossing in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

At least five people including four school girls and a cyclist were on Friday killed when a speeding train rammed against school van at a manned railway crossing near Karna Subarna of Behrampore in Murshidabad district the railway police said adding gateman Anupam Karmakar was instantly suspended by the authorities for dereliction of duty and subsequently arrested.

The incident occurred at around 7 in the morning locals said when Nimtita-Katwa local passenger train hit a pool car crossing the Gobindopur railway gate. The driver of the mangled vehicle which was dragged several metres away by the train was not at fault locals said adding the gateman had left the gates open for road traffic.

While three persons died on the spot two succumbed in the hospital while being treated in the ICU, sources said.

"He is a drunkard and regularly does so and repeated complaints to the authorities would not yield any result," one of the villagers said adding the negligent gateman was locked inside his cabin and later handed over to the police in a drunken state.

Another railway staff had also been suspended following complaints from the local villagers.

Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari immediately sent two of his ministerial colleagues to eh spot and warned that his administration would tolerate no negligence and if found guilty the erring staff would be criminally punished.

"I have been told that the police have already been arrested the gateman... I have told them not to tolerate any negligence... it is a shocking news... that we lost four little ones... four innocent school children... the Government will take strictest possible action," the Chief Minister said.

Meanwhile, both the Indian Railways and the State administration announced a compensation of ₹10 lakh and ₹5 lakh for the kin of the deceased.

Jagannath chariots reach Puri's Gundicha temple

A large number of devotees gather around the chariots of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra and Goddess Subhadra near the Shree Gundicha Temple during the annual Rath Yatra festival in Puri, Odisha PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puri

The chariots of Lord Jagannath and his siblings deities reached their destination of Shree Gundicha Temple here on Friday afternoon, a day after the Rath Yatra.

Shree Jagannath Temple Administration's (SJTA) chief administrator Arabinda Padhee said that according to tradition, the idols will remain on their chariots for the night and be carried into the Shree Gundicha Temple, considered the birthplace of the sibling deities, on Saturday evening. The return car festival, called Bahuda Yatra, will be held on July 24.

The three chariots could not reach the Shree Gundicha Temple, around 2.6 kilometres from the 12th-century Jagannath Temple, on Thursday due to a delay in the ritual of moving the idols from the sanctum sanctorum to the carriages.

As per tradition, the chariots cannot be pulled after sundown. Though the carriages were scheduled to reach Shree Gundicha temple by Thursday evening, the chariot pulling was suspended around 7 pm due to fading light and it resumed on Friday morning, an official said.

Lord Balabhadra's Taladhwaja chariot, which began moving at 5.10 pm on Thursday against its scheduled time of 4 pm, stopped at Market Chhak after covering around 700 metres on the Grand Road.

Devi Subhadra's Darpadalana chariot halted at Marichikote Chhak after covering around 400 metres, while Lord Jagannath's Nandighosha chariot was pulled only for a few yards and remained near the main gate of the 12th-century shrine.

Shree Gundicha Temple is considered the birthplace of the sibling deities.

The idols were kept on their chariots on Thursday night, and lakhs of devotees jostled to catch a glimpse of the deities amid tight security. "There was no closure of 'darsan' all night," Padhee said.

In a video message, Puri's titular king, Gajapati Maharaja Dibyasingha Deb, who is also the chairman of the Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee (SJTMC), said, "There is nothing wrong in chariot pulling continuing the day after the scheduled Rath Yatra."

"Many a time, chariots cannot reach their destination on time, and they are pulled the next day. The chariot pulling was halted on Thursday due to sundown," he said.

Thousands of devotees spent Thursday night in the holy town braving inclement weather and began pulling the chariots with renewed vigour on Friday morning, chanting '*Jai Jagannath*' and '*Hari bol*'.

BJP slams Congress MP Jawed over remark that Sanskrit came from outside

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday criticised the Congress after its Lok Sabha MP Mohammed Jawed claimed that Sanskrit came from outside, and said this reflects the party's appeasement mindset and its habit of insulting Indian identity and civilisation.

The BJP's reaction came after a video clip, purportedly showing Jawed saying that Urdu originated in India, unlike Sanskrit and English.

In the video, Jawed, MP from Bihar's Kishanganj constituency, was purportedly heard saying, "In Bihar, Urdu is the second language. We will not allow the second language to be wiped out like this. We want Urdu, which is the language of the people of Hindustan and did not come from outside, to be preserved.

"Sanskrit came from outside, English came from outside. Hindi and Urdu are our languages; they originated in Hindustan."

Responding to the remarks, BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari, in a post on social media, said this thought can only come from those who do not believe in Sanatan.

"For those who regard Babur as their ideal, Sanskrit is a foreign language. Every Indian language belongs to India. This statement clearly reflects a mindset of appeasement," he said in a video post.

"They called the Ram Temple useless, and now they are calling Sanskrit a foreign language. Such thinking was characteristic of the Mughals. They consider invaders as their ideals and call Lord Shri Ram imaginary," he claimed.

Another BJP spokesperson, Shehzad Poonawalla, said the Congress has a history of insulting India, its identity and civilisation.

"We have seen not only Sam Pitroda saying that Indians look like Africans and Chinese, but now a Congress MP has claimed that Sanskrit came from outside. Everyone knows Sanskrit is an Indian language. It is a language of India and was born out of India's civilisational heritage," he said in a video statement.

Members of Congress whose leaders came from abroad -- a reference to Sonia Gandhi's Italian origin -- should stop claiming that Sanskrit came from outside India, Poonawalla said.

"Their leaders are imported, their party was formed by imported powers and foreign forces, by the British. They are making such claims. The Congress was formed by Allan Octavian Hume. It has had many foreign presidents.

"Sonia Gandhi herself came from Italy, and Rahul Gandhi loves to be abroad rather than in India. Maybe they should stop insulting Indian identity, Indian culture and Indian civilisation," he said.

BJP criticises Congress for opposing bill to honour Vande Mataram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday criticised the Congress for allegedly opposing the Centre's move to table a Bill that provides for punishment for insulting or obstructing the mandatory singing of Vande Mataram at official events, in the upcoming Parliament session. The ruling party said the Congress has historically shown disrespect towards the national song.

The Government has listed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill — which seeks to give the national song Vande Mataram the same statutory protection as the national anthem Jana Gana Mana — for introduction in the Lok Sabha during the Monsoon session beginning July 20.

A bulletin issued by the Lok Sabha Secretariat said the Bill has been listed for introduction, consideration and passing.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that instead of welcoming the move and celebrating 150 years of Vande Mataram, the Congress has a problem with it.

"Congress and its ecosystem hate Vande Mataram. The Government is bringing the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act in order to give Vande Mataram, as the national song, the same respect given to the national flag and the national anthem. But instead of welcoming this, instead of celebrating the 150 years of Vande Mataram, Congress has a problem with it," he said in a video statement.

Poonawalla alleged that the first Prime Minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, divided the national song into two parts under pressure from the Muslim League, and that several Congress leaders refused to sing even the first two stanzas.

"Nehru ji divided the song into two parts. Congress and many of its leaders refused to sing Vande Mataram even when there were only the first two stanzas. Whether it is Siddaramaiah, the Madhya Pradesh Congress, or Sonia Gandhi, we have seen that they have a hatred towards Vande Mataram," he said.

The BJP spokesperson claimed that while the Congress "eulogises" Naxals and has a "soft corner" for terrorists, it continues to display hatred towards Vande Mataram.

"Even now, they hate Vande Mataram; this shows their mindset. They can eulogise Hidma, say 'Naxali shaheed hai' (Naxals are martyrs); they can have a soft corner for terrorists like Afzal and Yakub. But when it comes to Bharat Mata and Vande Mataram, they have a problem. This shows that it is not the INC, Indian National Congress, but ANC, Anti-National Congress," he said.

"Back then, they opposed Vande Mataram under pressure from the Muslim League. Today, they continue to oppose Vande Mataram because they are in alliance with the Muslim League in Kerala," he added.

CPI(M) concerned over Wangchuk's health, announces nationwide protests on July 20

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk being attended by a medical professional during protest at the Jantar Mantar in New Delhi PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) [CPI(M)] has expressed concern over the reported deterioration in the health of social activist Sonam Wangchuk, who the party said is on a hunger strike demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the alleged NEET examination paper leak.

In a statement issued by its Polit Bureau, the CPI(M) criticised the Union Government for what it described as its refusal to engage with protesting students and leaders.

The party alleged that the Government's response reflected "insensitivity and authoritarianism" amid ongoing protests over alleged irregularities in the conduct of the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET).

The CPI(M) also linked the alleged examination irregularities to the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, claiming that the policy's emphasis on centralisation and commercialisation of education had contributed to the rapid growth of the coaching industry.

The party further alleged that these developments, along with what it termed the "communalisation" of education, were among the underlying causes of paper leaks and other examination-related irregularities.

Conservation effective when communities are stakeholders: President Murmu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Friday said that conservation efforts will be more effective and long-lasting when communities are stakeholders in protecting forests. Addressing probationers of the Indian Forest Service (IFoS), who called on the president at the Rashtrapati Bhavan here, she said technological advancements, demographic changes and rising aspirations will continue to present new challenges before them.

"As officers, you must remain adaptable and forward-looking. You should keep learning and remain open to innovation while staying firmly rooted in constitutional values," Murmu said. The president asked them to encourage people's participation in conservation, restoration and sustainable livelihood initiatives. Understanding the views and concerns of tribal communities, forest dwellers, women, farmers and local institutions will provide you with valuable insight, she said. "Indigenous knowledge has preserved the forests for generations. You should build trust between the administration and the local people. When communities are stakeholders in protecting forests, conservation efforts will be more effective and long-lasting," Murmu said.

The president said that the IFoS officers' responsibilities extend beyond conservation alone.

"Ecological protection must be harmonised with the legitimate aspirations of people who live in and around forests. Development and conservation should not be viewed as opposing goals. You should work towards solutions where both nature and communities can thrive together," she said.

President Droupadi Murmu in a group photograph with probationers of the Indian Forest Service during a meeting at Rashtrapati Bhavan Cultural Centre in New Delhi PTI

Addressing the officers, the president said they are not only administrators of forests but the custodians of India's natural heritage.

"Your role has become more significant today. The world is facing the challenges of climate change and biodiversity loss. Forests are central to addressing these challenges.

"They conserve biodiversity, regulate local climates and sustain the livelihoods of millions of people. Your work will therefore contribute not only to India's environmental security but also to global efforts towards sustainable development," she said.

Asserting that technology is becoming indispensable for environmental governance, Murmu said that the use of technology enables better monitoring of forest health, wildlife movements, fire prevention and restoration efforts.

"However, you should remember that technology can never be a substitute for human touch, ethical decision-making and compassion. The best decisions often emerge when scientific evidence is combined with wisdom gained through experience and dialogue with people," she said.

The president said that their integrity must remain unquestionable. "Your words should reflect humility. You must lead from the front, particularly during difficult situations. You should always remember that empathy is one of the finest qualities of a public servant," Murmu said.

She said that public service is about improving the lives of people and contributing to the nation's progress.

"Ecological security is integral to the national goal of Viksit Bharat by 2047. I am confident that as Indian Forest Service officers, you will play a defining role in ensuring that India's progress remains green, inclusive and sustainable," the president said.

Over 2.7 lakh candidates skip NEET re-test, highest absentee count ever

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Over 2.7 lakh fewer candidates appeared for the medical entrance NEET-UG re-examination than the original test conducted on May 3, according to official data.

The crucial exam conducted on May 3 was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of paper leak. The CBI is investigating the matter.

The exam was re-conducted on June 21. For the re-examination, 19,99,895 candidates appeared compared to 22.05 lakh candidates who had taken the original NEET-UG examination.

The result for the high-stakes exam was announced on Thursday, with the National Testing Agency (NTA) announcing that 11.21 lakh candidates have qualified for the exam.

The result data shows that registrations remained almost unchanged from last year, but a significantly larger number of candidates skipped the re-examination.

Over 22.79 lakh candidates registered for NEET-UG 2026, only marginally higher than 22.76 lakh registrations in 2025.

However, only 19.99 lakh candidates appeared, leaving 2,79,848 candidates absent, the highest absentee count recorded so far.

In 2020, 2.30 lakh candidates had skipped the exam when it was conducted during the COVID-19 pandemic.

The original examination held on May 3 had recorded an attendance of 22.05 lakh candidates, translating to an attendance of 96.72 per cent.

The attendance for the re-examination stood at 87.72 per cent, making it the second-lowest recorded since 2020. The National Eligibility cum Entrance Test-Undergraduate, or NEET-UG, is the largest undergraduate entrance exam in the country, with nearly 25 lakh candidates registering for the crucial test.

The NTA conducts NEET every year for admission into medical colleges, with 1,08,000 seats available for the MBBS course. Of these, approximately 56,000 are in Government hospitals and about 52,000 are in private colleges. Undergraduate courses in dentistry, Ayurveda, Unani and Siddha also utilise NEET results for admissions.

Following the controversy over paper leak and alleged irregularities in the exam process, the Centre announced that the exam will now be conducted as a computer-based test (CBT), rather than in the pen and paper mode.

Over 750 hectares of forest land likely to be diverted for coal mining in Odisha's Angul district

ALIND CHAUHAN
New Delhi

More than 750 hectares of forest land in Odisha's Angul district is likely to be diverted for mining at the proposed Alakananda coal mine, allotted to Rungta Sons Private Limited.

The mining site is about 4.9 kilometres from the Similipal-Satkosia Gorge tiger corridor and 8.5 km from the Sambalpur elephant reserve. In recent years, the site and its surrounding areas have witnessed the presence of not only elephants but also sloth bears and leopards, among other wild animals.

The forest-land diversion, leading to the felling of more than 3.3 lakh trees, was recommended for stage-1 (in-principle) approval by the environment ministry's Forest Advisory Committee (FAC) at its meeting on July 7.

The stage-I clearance stipulates conditions, including compensatory afforestation, which must be fulfilled before the stage-II formal diversion approval can be granted.

At the meeting, the committee also observed that the mining site's eastern and southern boundaries are flanked by the Olhani river. The Tikra river, a tributary of the Brahmani river, flows about 750 metres north of the proposed mining lease area. The proposed project also involves the displacement of 818 families and affects 1,584 families across five villages.

The FAC has recommended approval based on several conditions, including that the state Government must ensure a safety barrier with a minimum width of 50 metres on either side of the Olhani river. Another condition is the implementation of a regional wildlife-management plan, as approved by the chief wildlife warden, according to the minutes of the meeting.

The minutes of the meeting also state that the "tree felling shall be carried out in a phased manner, in consultation with the state forest department and in accordance with the approved mining plan, mine-closure plan and the guidelines of the forest department". (*PTI*)

Gujarat tops Niti Aayog's Investment Friendliness Index

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Gujarat, Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu have emerged as the top three States in NITI Aayog's Investment Friendliness Index for States and Union Territories (UTs), as per a report released on Friday.

Lakshadweep was the worst performer followed by Ladakh and Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

The index focuses on eight parameters: infrastructure, business climate, resources, Government policy, regulatory ease, institutional environment, financial health and environment resilience.

The rankings had three categories — large States, hilly and northeastern States and city States and UTs, as per the report released by NITI Aayog Vice Chairman Ashok Kumar Lahiri.

Among large States, Bihar, Jharkhand and West Bengal were the worst performers. Odisha, Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh were ranked 4th, 5th and 6th among large States.

Gujarat leads the ranking, with an overall score of 56.6. The state's score is driven by its strong performance across infrastructure, business climate, financial health, regulatory ease and Government policy pillars, with areas of improvement in the resources, institutional environment and environment resilience pillars. The report pointed out that Gujarat's high rank in infrastructure is on account of its efficient port operations and power sector, driven by competitive industrial and commercial power costs and well-contained transmission and distribution (T&D) losses.

Maharashtra records an overall score of 53.7, ranking second in both the large state category and at the pan-India level. The State's score is driven by its leading performance in the business climate pillar, the Aayog said, adding that the score is further supported by a strong performance in the resources and financial health pillars, with infrastructure and regulatory ease areas for improvement. Tamil Nadu records an overall score of 53.3, ranking third at the pan-India level and the large state category. The score is driven by its strong performance in the infrastructure and business climate pillar, with financial health emerging as an area for improvement.

Uttarakhand, Assam and Himachal Pradesh emerged as the top three States in hilly and northeastern States category. Releasing the report, Lahiri said investment rate in India is around 25 per cent, which is less than China when its economy was growing fast.

"In the last few years, India has been the fastest growing major economy. Investments play a major role in economic growth. India needs more investments as it also boosts demand. "As we aspire to realise the vision of Viksit Bharat @2047, our challenge is not only to sustain high rates of economic growth but also to ensure that such growth is broad-based, resilient and driven by productivity," he said.

Lahiri said achieving this ambition will require a significant acceleration in investments that expand productive capacity, strengthen manufacturing, create quality employment and foster innovation. The index covers all 28 States and eight union territories (UTs) and evaluates what makes a state attractive for investors, as well as the challenges investors face.

The Union Budget 2025–26 announced the development of an Investment Friendliness Index to strengthen the spirit of competitive and cooperative federalism by promoting reforms and fostering a conducive investment ecosystem across States.

CEC a weapon of mass destruction for electoral rolls: Jairam Ramesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Friday slammed Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar as a "complete weapon of mass destruction" for electoral rolls in the country and said the opposition would push for his removal as the poll panel chief.

Opposition parties on April 24 had submitted a fresh notice in the Rajya Sabha seeking to move a motion for the removal of Kumar.

The opposition's fresh charges on Kumar's "proved misbehaviour" included "continued partisan asymmetry in the enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct".

Asked whether the opposition will push for action against Kumar on the notice submitted in April, Ramesh said, "We haven't heard anything on that. Absolutely, we have to push. I mean he's a complete weapon of mass destruction as far as electoral rolls are concerned."

"The most devastating indictment of Mr Gyanesh Kumar has come from a very senior IAS officer, who was the first director general of the Unique Identification Authority of India, and has a culturally very important name — Ram Sevak Sharma. He's written an article detailing how damaging and devastating the entire SIR exercise has become," the Congress general secretary in-charge communications said.

So, this is not just what the Congress party is saying or what Trinamool Congress is stating, Ramesh said. "I mean this is a retired civil servant who has worked in the Modi Government, he was given important positions and he's come out and of course retired election commissioners have come out very openly (against SIR)," Ramesh said.

He pointed out that opposition parties submitted a notice on April 24 for moving a motion for the removal of the chief election commissioner.

"Mr Gyanesh Kumar is just executing what he's told to do by the home minister (Amit Shah)," Ramesh alleged.

His remarks come days after former chief election commissioner S Y Quraishi hit out at the Election Commission over the ongoing SIR exercise, saying the process is focused more on "exclusion" and has "played havoc with democracy" with free and fair elections having been "disturbed". The Monsoon session of Parliament is scheduled to start from July 20 and conclude on August 13.

All 36 States and UTs adopt KPI framework for health programmes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE New Delhi

All 36 States and Union Territories have unanimously adopted a Key Performance Indicator (KPI) framework to strengthen the implementation, monitoring and evaluation of key public health programmes, the Union Health Ministry said on Friday. The Centre and States have agreed to hold monthly reviews to track progress against the defined KPIs and address gaps, it said.

The decision was taken at the conclusion of a two-day National Review Meeting on Disease Surveillance and Public Health Programmes organised by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare here. According to a statement issued by the ministry, the KPI framework commits all States and UTs to achieve defined targets and performance benchmarks for strengthening disease surveillance and implementing public health programmes.

The Centre and States also agreed to undertake monthly performance reviews to assess progress against the defined KPIs, identify implementation gaps and facilitate timely corrective action. The ministry said the reviews will also draw upon findings from supportive supervision carried out by SPOT (Supportive Supervision and Performance Observation Team) members, with States and UTs committing to address critical operational bottlenecks and improve the delivery of disease surveillance and other public health programmes.

The meeting, held on July 16 and 17, brought together senior health officials from all States and UTs to review the implementation of key public health programmes, assess progress in disease surveillance and deliberate on measures to strengthen data-driven governance.

Lakhanpur to be developed as street food hub in J&K, says Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jammu

Union Minister Jitendra Singh

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Friday said that Lakhanpur has been selected among 50 towns across the country to be developed as a 'street food hub' under the PM SVANidhi initiative, while announcing the construction of a ₹1.5 crore gateway monument at the entry point to Jammu and Kashmir.

The minister, who was accorded a warm welcome by street food vendors and traders during his visit to the Lakhanpur Vendors Market, said the Narendra Modi Government has, for the first time, prioritised the welfare of street vendors through a dedicated national scheme. Addressing vendors and traders, Singh said successive Governments had ignored the concerns of street vendors, but the PM SVANidhi scheme has brought them into the mainstream by providing financial assistance, dignity and sustainable livelihood opportunities. He said Lakhanpur's selection in the first phase of the Street Food Hub initiative reflects the Government's commitment to empowering small vendors while creating organised, hygienic and visitor-friendly vending spaces. According to the minister, the proposed Street Food Hub will be developed in two clusters near the old bus stand and the Sales Tax Office in Lakhanpur market.

Spread over 1,754.25 square metres, the project will provide modern vending infrastructure while promoting Dogra cuisine and other regional delicacies.

Located at the gateway to Jammu and Kashmir from Pathankot and on the route to the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi shrine, Lakhanpur witnesses heavy movement of tourists, pilgrims and transit travellers, making it an ideal location for the project, he said. Singh said the Government had received 126 proposals from 32 States and Union Territories covering 106 Urban Local Bodies and seven Census Towns, with Lakhanpur being selected in the first phase.

The Union minister also announced that a landmark gateway to Jammu and Kashmir, along with beautification works at Lakhanpur, will be developed at an estimated cost of over ₹1.5 crore. He said part of the funding would come from his Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS) allocation, while the remaining amount would be mobilised from other available resources.

IYC, NSUI to gherao Parliament on August 9

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Indian Youth Congress (IYC) and the National Students' Union of India (NSUI) announced on Friday that they would 'gherao' Parliament on August 9 as part of the party's 'Chhatron Ki Goonj (Voice of Students)' campaign to amplify the alleged corruption in education as well as the need for reform.

These two frontal organisations of the Congress reiterated their demands seeking the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, strict action against incidents of alleged paper leaks and the release of an annual examination calendar. Indian Youth Congress (IYC) president Uday Bhanu Chib and NSUI in-charge Kanhaiya Kumar outlined the future roadmap of the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign during a press conference here.

Chib said that the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' campaign began with a press conference, followed by engagement with students and youth through various programmes. He informed that protests and demonstrations would be held in various cities on August 1, and the 'gherao' of Parliament would take place on August 9 under the slogan 'Delhi Chalo (March to Delhi)'.

Sai Prakash Spiritual Trust holds Jagannath Rath Yatra 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Gurugram

Dr Chandra Bhanu Satpathy and Union Minister of Tribal Affairs, Jual Oram during the Jagannath Rath Yatra at the Sai Ka Aangan Temple in Gurugram on Thursday PANKAJ KUMAR

Third Shri Jagannath Rath Yatra 2026 mirthfully celebrated at Sai Ka Aangan, Gurugram, organised by Sai Prakash Spiritual and charitable trust in association with CBS Cultural Foundation, under the guidance of Dr Chandra Bhanu Satpathy Ji Gurugram, Haryana on Thursday.

Dr Chandra Bhanu Satpathy Ji, an internationally respected spiritual thinker, humanitarian, author, and for more than three decades, Dr Satpathy Ji making significant contributions to the preservation and promotion of the timeless spiritual and cultural heritage of Lord Shri Jagannath in India and abroad. He initiated the Shri Jagannath Rath Yatra at the Power Grid Temple, Gurugram, in 2009 and subsequently introduced this sacred tradition in the United States through Rath Yatras in Dallas, USA and Nashville, USA in 2011, followed by Houston, USA in 2012.

Union Minister of Tribal Affairs, Jual Oram visited and had *darshan* of Lord Shri Jagannath, Shri Balabhadra and Maa Subhadra.

Inspired by the vision and guidance of Dr Satpathy Ji, the Rath Yatra was introduced at Sai Ka Aangan in 2024. Within a short span, it has emerged as one of the region's most awaited annual spiritual celebrations, bringing together devotees from diverse cultural, linguistic, and social backgrounds in the spirit of devotion, unity, and universal brotherhood.

The celebrations commenced at 11am with pre-puja rituals, Rath Pratishtha, followed by sacred 'Pahandi Bije' procession of Lord Jagannath, Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra, and Shri Sudarshan at 3:30pm and followed by the traditional 'Chhera Pahara' ceremony, symbolising humility, equality, and selfless service, performed by Dr Chandra Bhanu Satpathy Ji before the ceremonial pulling of the divine chariot.

The festival featured devotional music, traditional cultural performances showcasing the rich heritage of Odisha, and the distribution of prasad, lovingly prepared by traditional Odia cooks from Puri.

Ex-NSG commando held in drug case in Jodhpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Jodhpur

Police arrested a former National Security Guard (NSG) commando here and seized over ₹1.06 crore in cash and 8 kilograms of opium latex during a raid at his residence, officials said on Friday.

According to officials, the accused Ratan Singh Jat allegedly tried to flee after seeing the police team at his house in the upscale Ekta Nagar locality on Thursday following a late-night raid, but police overpowered him.

During the search, police seized ₹1.06 crore in cash, 8 kilograms of opium latex and a Hyundai Creta SUV from the house. "The accused was arrested in connection with drug trafficking. A substantial quantity of opium latex and over Rs 1.06 crore in cash have been recovered from his residence. We are investigating the source of the narcotics as well as the origin of the seized cash," DCP (East) Manish Choudhary said.

The DCP said the accused had earlier served as a soldier in the Assam Rifles and was later deployed as an NSG commando. Police said cash counting continued for several hours and the operation lasted until Friday morning.

Editor's TAKE

Semicon 2.0: India's silicon gambit

The Union Cabinet's approval of a ₹1.27 lakh crore semiconductor programme is timely — the real test now is execution, not intent.

On July 15, the Cabinet cleared Semicon 2.0, a ₹1,27,500 crore programme launched alongside a ₹62,500 crore mobile-phone manufacturing scheme. Together, they mark India's clearest statement yet that its chip ambitions are a sustained industrial project, not a one-time bet. The new phase builds on the original India Semiconductor Mission, under which 12 projects worth over ₹1.64 lakh crore have been approved, and three plants – run by Micron, Kaynes and CG Semi – have already begun commercial production. Semicon 2.0 widens the lens from fabrication alone to six pillars: chip design; the equipment and speciality chemicals that feed fabs; manufacturing capacity; advanced packaging; research into next-generation process nodes; and engineering talent, with over 300 universities already training more than 68,000 students on industry-grade design tools.

The stakes explain the scale of the bet. Semiconductors sit beneath almost everything India wants to build next – smartphones, electric vehicles, defence electronics, data centres and an AI-driven economy – yet the country still imports the bulk of what it consumes. That dependence is both a fiscal drain and a strategic vulnerability at a time when global chip supply chains are concentrated in a handful of geographies and are increasingly entangled in great-power rivalry.

A credible domestic base would cut import bills, generate the high-skilled manufacturing jobs India badly needs, and enable it to position itself as a trusted alternative as multinationals look to diversify beyond China and Taiwan. Yet ambition still outruns capacity. Most Indian plants today work in mature 28-110 nanometre nodes, a generation or more behind the 3-5 nm chips inside flagship phones and frontier AI hardware. Closing that gap takes years of accumulated process knowledge, not just capital.

Fabrication also requires uninterrupted power and ultra-pure water on a scale that few Indian sites can yet guarantee, and much of the specialised machinery and gases on which fabs depend are still imported – precisely why this round adds a materials-and-equipment pillar that the first phase lacked. Talent is being developed, but VLSI and process engineers take years to mature, not months. Nor is India racing alone: the United States, the European Union, Japan and South Korea are all running comparable subsidy programmes to attract the same pool of capital and expertise. Semicon 1.0's own timeline is itself a caution: India's first major fabrication plant is expected to come on stream only in 2028, seven years after that mission was first announced.

None of this makes Semicon 2.0 misguided; it makes it demanding. Capital alone did not build TSMC or Samsung - decades of disciplined execution and ecosystem depth did that. Semicon 2.0 gives India the mandate and the money. What it does with both, far more than the headline figure, will determine whether the country becomes a genuine chip power or merely a well-funded aspirant.

Recalibrating communication for the Global South

India can help build it by placing the orange economy, educational leadership, media exchange and digital cooperation at the centre of its engagement. The objective is not simply to improve how the Global South is seen

CHAITANYA K PRASAD

The Global South does not suffer from a shortage of stories. It suffers from a shortage of control over how those stories are framed, circulated and remembered. Its countries are home to most of the world's population, some of its youngest societies, fastest-growing markets, oldest knowledge systems and most inventive responses to scarcity, climate stress, digital exclusion and social inequality. Yet much of the world still encounters the Global South through a narrow lens: conflict, poverty, instability, aid, extraction or delayed development. This is not merely a problem of image. It is a problem of power.

Communication shapes which experiences become universal, which institutions are treated as credible and which countries are seen as sources of ideas rather than recipients of them. For decades, the Global South has participated in an international communication order whose principal platforms, standards, narratives and gatekeepers were located elsewhere. Its societies have been represented, interpreted and often simplified before being heard directly. That order is no longer adequate.

The Global South now needs a communication strategy built around centrality. It must move from reacting to global conversations to setting them. It must stop appearing only as a subject of development and begin speaking as an author of the future. For India, this is both an opportunity and a responsibility.

India's role cannot be confined to amplifying diplomatic messaging or promoting national achievements. It can help build a wider communication architecture through which the countries of the Global South exchange knowledge, circulate culture, shape policy language and develop direct relationships with one another.

At the heart of this effort should be the orange economy. The orange economy brings together culture, creativity, technology, intellectual property, design, media, entertainment, heritage, fashion, animation, gaming, publishing and digital content. It recognises that ideas and cultural expression are not decorative additions to economic life. They create employment, shape identity, influence aspiration and build international visibility.

India's recent public communication increasingly reflects this understanding. The country presents itself not only through diplomacy, infrastructure, trade and technology, but also through cinema, crafts, music, cuisine, design, digital storytelling, creative entrepreneurship and civilisational knowledge. This shift matters because communication is most effective when audiences do not experience it as communication policy. They experience it as culture.

> THE TECHNOLOGY PILLAR SHOULD STRENGTHEN TRANSLATION, DISTRIBUTION AND DISCOVERABILITY. ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE CAN LOWER LANGUAGE BARRIERS, BUT TECHNOLOGY MUST SERVE CULTURAL CONTEXT RATHER THAN FLATTEN IT. HUMAN EDITORS, TRANSLATORS, RESEARCHERS AND CREATORS WILL REMAIN ESSENTIAL

For too long, culture has been treated as soft power in the weakest sense of the term, something attractive but secondary. In reality, creative industries are central to how countries become visible and memorable. The nations that shape global imagination do so not only through military or economic influence, but through stories, images, language, design and platforms. The Global South already produces extraordinary cultural work. Its weakness lies in circulation. Creators struggle with translation, financing, copyright protection, discoverability and access to regional markets.

India can propose a network for creative exchange that goes beyond ceremonial festivals. It could support film and documentary co-productions, translation funds, digital archives, publishing partnerships, creator residencies, animation collaborations, gaming exchanges and common platforms for cultural content.

The aim should not be to produce propaganda or a uniform Global South identity. The South is too diverse for that. The aim should be to allow its societies to encounter one another without always passing through external filters. This requires direct communication networks. At present, news about one country of the South often reaches another through institutions based in Europe or North America. Research produced in Africa may become visible in Asia only after recognition by a Western university or journal. A policy innovation in Latin America may remain unknown in South Asia. Cultural products often become internationally valuable only after endorsement by global festivals, streaming platforms or award systems located elsewhere.

This indirect model keeps the Global South on the sidelines of its own story. India can help create a communication framework with four connected pillars: culture, knowledge, media and technology. The cultural pillar should focus on the orange economy. It should link filmmakers, writers, designers, musicians, game developers, publishers, museums, heritage institutions and digital creators across the South.

The knowledge pillar should connect universities, think tanks and research institutions. India's educational leadership can be especially important here. Scholarships and training programmes remain valuable, but they are not enough. The deeper need is for a Global South knowledge commons: shared digital libraries, multilingual courses, collaborative research networks and accessible repositories of public-policy experience.

The media pillar should support direct reporting among countries of the South. Journalist exchanges, regional news partnerships and multilingual editorial networks can reduce dependence on second-hand interpretation. The technology pillar should strengthen translation, distribution and discoverability. Artificial intelligence can lower language barriers, but technology must serve cultural context rather than flatten it. India's greatest advantage is not that it has solved every communication challenge. It has not. Its advantage is that it contains many of the tensions the Global South must manage: scale and diversity, tradition and modernity, local languages and global platforms, public institutions and private creativity, democratic debate and strategic messaging. This gives India the ability to act as a convener rather than a lecturer. Its communication strategy for the Global South should therefore avoid paternalism. India should not claim to speak for a large and varied group of countries. It should build platforms on which those countries speak directly, equally and repeatedly.

Global South communication cannot become another exercise in official declarations. It must involve universities, creators, entrepreneurs, students, journalists, teachers, researchers and local communities. Governments can create the architecture, but they should not monopolise the voice. Much official communication across the Global South remains formal, defensive and overloaded with institutional language.

The Global South must also stop communicating through the language of catching up. Its societies are not moving towards a future already perfected elsewhere. They are producing different futures: affordable digital systems, frugal innovation, multilingual education, community-led climate solutions, public technology at scale and new creative markets. These are not regional exceptions. They are global ideas. The Global South does not need a louder version of the old communication order. It needs a different one: more direct, multilingual, creative, networked and confident. India can help build it by placing the orange economy, educational leadership, media exchange and digital cooperation at the centre of its engagement.The objective is not simply to improve how the Global South is seen. It is to change who gets to define what is worth seeing. The South must no longer wait to be invited into the main story. It must build the stage, create the language and draw the map itself.

The author is a Commentator and Writer on Cinema, Branding, Media Management and Geo-Strategic Communication. Inputs provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavie Srinivasan

PIC TALK

A mahout with his elephant at the Vadakkumnathan Temple on the opening day of the Malayalam month of Karkidakam amid rainfall in Kerala.

PHOTO: PTI

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When the unprecedented becomes routine

RAJYOGI BRAHMA KUMAR NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

It was not so long ago that scientists predicted climate change would make monsoons unpredictable; as a result, rain-fed food grain cultivation in South Asia would suffer significantly and total cereal production would decline. Unfortunately, that prediction is becoming true day by day, with many parts of India now battling heavy rains and flooding. What was once a warning has become a pattern.

In 2023, 2024 and 2025, the world witnessed some of the hottest years on record, each surpassing the previous one. There is no doubt that this crisis is unexpected, yet one cannot deny that it has arrived because of man's own deeds. The situation across the globe has become so alarming that one question comes to everyone's mind: "Is there nothing we can do against nature's fury?" Does this question really need an answer?

Despite the galloping scientific achievements mankind has witnessed, we have never been able to question the invincibility of Nature. While textbooks are filled with lessons on natural calamities, there is still no breakthrough in predicting or preventing them with certainty. In such a scenario, the best bet for any country is to be prepared for the worst while hoping for the best. A recent scientific study has concluded that almost all of the summer sea ice in the Arctic Ocean is likely to disappear by the end of this century because of global warming caused by greenhouse gas emissions. In India, another study has predicted that by the middle of the century, sea levels will rise by 24.1 cm, causing coastal floods and more cyclones in the Bay of Bengal, while the average temperature in cities such as Delhi and Mumbai will increase by three to four degrees Celsius. That prediction no longer feels distant. Delhi has already recorded some of its heaviest monsoon rainfall in decades, while Mumbai's low-lying areas now flood with alarming regularity.

It has taken many scientists a long time to accept that the world's climate is changing because of human activity. The burgeoning population, increasing industrial activity, deforestation and the rampant exploitation of the earth's natural resources have altered our ecosystem irreversibly. The devastating consequences are now becoming apparent. However, despite all these developments, many experts continue to explain extreme weather as isolated local phenomena instead of recognising the larger picture. It is obvious that the earth's climate is changing for the worse. Nature, which has sustained human civilisation for thousands of years by providing sunshine, food and water, is turning harsher. The world went agog when a country like the UAE, associated more with deserts, witnessed rare snow and hail on its northern mountain peaks a few years ago. Similarly, the devastating tsunami, which killed lakhs of people, showed how powerless humans are before the forces of nature. The lesson has not faded with time. Dubai, the same desert emirate, was paralysed in 2024 when a year's worth of rain fell in a single day, turning highways into rivers. Closer home, the Wayanad landslides buried entire hillside settlements in Kerala, while glacial lake floods in Sikkim swept away a dam and homes with barely any warning. Each of these events was described as unprecedented. None of them should have been. These manifestations of nature's fury cannot be mere anomalies. They are increasingly becoming the result of the damage done to the environment by human beings. In other words, we are now paying the price for abusing nature. Yet we continue to ignore these warning signs in pursuit of economic growth. Instead of learning from our mistakes, we are trying to outsmart nature.

But no amount of technology or money can save us from nature's wrath. It is still not too late to adopt sustainable, nature-friendly practices. This requires a shift from acquisition and consumption to sharing and caring. These cyclonic rains are nature's warning bells. If we fail to change, even greater disasters may await us.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

CYBER SECURITY SCARE AT KUDANKULAM NUCLEAR PLANT

The reported data breach at the Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant is a cause for concern, notwithstanding the claim by the NPCIL and the Central Government that it does not pertain to nuclear safety or security.

The World Leaks publication of a large cache of files linked to the nuclear plant on the dark web cannot be ignored or downplayed, as it cannot be said with certainty that no risks are involved.

The Anil Ambani-led Reliance Group, entrusted with the Balance of Plant (BoP) construction work for Units 3 and 4, has tried to make light of the breach by irresponsibly describing it as only a "partial breach".

The seriousness of the breach can be gauged from the fact that the leaked data are not otherwise obtainable under the RTI Act.

The fact that the breach occurred on the Reliance Group's side clearly vindicates the position taken by many against bringing private companies into the nuclear sector. The breach makes it clear that the Government failed to verify and confirm Reliance Infrastructure's capability to prevent data theft and keep sensitive data secure before handing them over to the company.

Needless to say, the safety of nuclear facilities is paramount. Data leaks relating to them can be costly. The Government should ensure that such data breaches never occur and that the leaked data cause no harm.

G DAVID MILTON | MARUTHANCODE

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Messi's magic lives on

Lionel Messi, like his legendary countryman Diego Maradona, is God's gift to football. Though short in stature like Maradona, the Argentine's upper-body strength, nimble footwork and quicksilver reflexes are a treat to watch.

Football lovers continue to admire his sublime free kicks, exceptional ball control and match-winning brilliance. Every time he charges towards the goal, creates an opportunity or finds the net, he inspires his teammates with renewed confidence and belief. Calm, humble and smiling, Messi's leadership qualities have rubbed off on the entire team.

As a friend, philosopher and guide, he has been a revelation both on and off the field. When his teammates joyfully tossed him into the air after victories, they made a powerful statement: here was an inspirational leader who had guided Argentina through difficult times and captured the imagination of an entire generation. Leading Argentina to the 2014 FIFA World Cup final, winning the trophy in 2022 and remaining a symbol of excellence are remarkable achievements. Great players may retire, but legends like Messi will always be remembered for their extraordinary skill, humility and enduring contribution to football.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Lessons from NEET 2026

The successful declaration of the NEET-UG 2026 results after a difficult journey brings some relief, yet it also underscores the serious hurdles the process encountered. The original examination in May had to be cancelled due to a paper leak, forcing a re-examination in June under intense scrutiny. Nearly 20 lakh students appeared amid tight security, with many facing months of uncertainty and stress. It is commendable that the NTA declared the results promptly, keeping the admission calendar on track, but the episode exposed gaps in our examination system.

We must now focus on practical solutions. The NTA should invest in stronger digital security for question papers and conduct regular audits of examination centres. Greater transparency in setting question papers and faster grievance redressal would help rebuild trust. At the same time, expanding medical seats and improving the counselling process can reduce the intense competition that makes such leaks so damaging. Supporting students with mental health resources during such disruptions is equally important. Ultimately, a more robust system will ensure future examinations run smoothly and give young aspirants the fair opportunity they deserve.

S M JEEVA I CHENNAI

Balancing law and education

The proposed demolition of a large part of Maulana Mohammad Ali Jauhar University raises a difficult question: should thousands of students suffer because of alleged violations by the management? If buildings have indeed been constructed without mandatory approvals or fail to meet fire safety norms, the authorities are duty-bound to enforce the law. No institution, regardless of its founder or political affiliations, should be above legal scrutiny. However, the action must be proportionate and humane. Nearly 3,000 students pursuing higher education should not become collateral victims of an administrative or political dispute. Before resorting to demolition, every legal remedy should be exhausted, including opportunities for regularisation, wherever permissible, rectification of deficiencies, and compliance with safety standards. If demolition ultimately becomes unavoidable, the Government must ensure uninterrupted education by relocating students and safeguarding their academic future.

The rule of law and the right to education must go hand in hand. Strict enforcement should target those responsible for the violations while safeguarding the interests of innocent students who have invested their aspirations in the institution.

SANJAY CHOPRA I MOHALI

Reimagining urban resilience through labour codes and women's livelihoods

The new labour codes align with global perspectives on resilient cities, focusing on childcare, housing and infrastructure for workers, especially migrant workers in the informal sector. The OSHWC Code also provides portability of benefits between native and destination States, benefiting migrant women workers

ELLINA SAMANTROY

The expansion of urban population and growth of cities in India has contributed in making India as one of the largest urban agglomerations. A recent report of the World Bank and Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs titled "Towards Resilient and Prosperous Cities in India' in 2025 had stated that Indian cities hold tremendous potential as centres of economic growth with 70 percent of new jobs coming from cities by 2030.With these developments, one of the biggest challenges the cities are grappling with is the problem of informality . As Indian cities increasingly depend on workers in the informal sector particularly contract, self-employed, migrant, domestic workers , gig, platform workers etc to sustain urban economies , protecting these workers and strengthening social protection and resilience for urban workers including women workers has remained a challenge. The protection of livelihoods in urban areas is perhaps one of the most important question facing India's urban transformation today.

Women's employment and social protection in urban India

While reflecting on women's employment in urban areas, it is observed that women are mostly engaged in sectors like services, retail, hospitality, healthcare, manufacturing etc . Also one of the pressing demands for women workers has been domestic work and the emerging gig economy. While reflecting on urban employment situation, the estimates from the Periodic Labour Force Survey show a grim picture with only a 3 percent increase in labour force for women from 24.7 percent in 2022 to 27.7 percent participation in 2025 .It is evident from the PLFS data that a large majority of urban women i.e 40.9 percent are engaged in other services, 21.7 percent in Manufacturing and 16.1 percent in trade, hotel and restaurant. Further, there has been dearth of long term job contracts for women ,with only 16 percent having contracts for more than 3 years while a large proportion i.e 77 percent women in the 15-59 age group did not have written job contracts.

Now a question which arises here is how far these sectors are protected by legislative provisions and whether women are entitled to social security? In fact, most of these workers are in informal arrangements with lack of employment contracts and access to social security. Apart from protection under labour legislations, urban livelihood protection also includes access to basic infrastructure facilities like housing, drinking amenities water, health , sanitation, safety etc. The Economic Survey 2025-26 while recognising the importance of informal sector, has emphasised on the need for revisiting urban planning strategies to promote a more integrative and inclusive approach for the informal workers for a more resilient urban transition.

What do the labour codes offer ?

While the announcement of the new labour codes on November 21st, 2025 has been a historic and opens up plethora of opportunities for protecting the livelihoods of urban women. However the concern is how far these provisions will strengthen livelihood protection and well-being of urban women workers? The introduction of fixed term contracts under the Industrial Relations Code 2020 includes employment contracts that promote better access to social security . Workers are eligible for proportionate gratuity after completion of one year of continuous service based on the length of their service and are also entitled to maternity benefit. These new provisions can contribute in regularising employment contracts in the sectors where women are engaged in urban areas. It is a significant step towards formalisation of employment towards promoting better social security.

Another important development under the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions code 2020 has been the introduction of a 'common creche facility' which allows a cluster of establishments to pool resources to provide childcare facilities for workers. These provisions will undoubtedly contribute in reducing the unpaid care burden of women which has remained a significant barrier for them to participate in employment. The Parliamentary Standing Committee on the OSH Code in 2020 had suggested for the provisioning of creche facilities for the Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) which will boost female employment and resilience of urban economy. For urban economies to thrive, greater investment and access to affordable care services is important to retain women's employment and upward career mobility. However, the implementation of these provisions will require interventions like issuing of guidelines to MSMEs or industrial clusters for compliance of these gender sensitive provisions. The State governments have a larger role in terms of issuing appropriate guidelines to these clusters and also streamlining the enforcement machinery for ensuring compliance.

> THE E-SHRAM DATA NEED TO BE LEVERAGED TO IDENTIFY MIGRANT STATUS AND INTEGRATE STATE LEVEL LABOUR WELFARE SCHEMES SO THAT WORKERS ARE NOT DEPRIVED OF SOCIAL SECURITY BENEFITS WHEN THEY MIGRATE. URBAN RESILIENCE FOR WOMEN CAN ONLY BE ACHIEVED BY COMBINING SOCIAL PROTECTION RIGHTS UNDER LABOUR CODES WITH INVESTMENTS IN GENDER RESPONSIVE INFRASTRUCTURE THAT ENCOURAGE WOMEN TO WORK

The new labour codes align well with the global perspectives on resilient cities that focusses on childcare, housing, infrastructure etc especially for workers, particularly migrant workers in the informal sector. The OSHWC codes also includes portability of benefits like the public distribution system either in native or destination State which will impact the migrant women workers significantly. Further, provisions like setting up of toll free helpline for inter-state migrant workers, study on migrant workers etc are important for addressing challenges faced by migrant workers and promote evidence based research for policy formulation. Apart for this, the Eshram portal one of the largest databases on unorganised workers links them to plethora of welfare schemes. While, E-shram registrations are ongoing, it is important to promote awareness about the benefits of the portal to the workers and also facilitate registrations under the portal so the workers can avail the social security benefits.

Way forward

For implementation of these facilities, inter-ministerial convergences are important particularly with regard to dissemination of welfare facilities like housing ,health, education and other social security benefits to women workers in urban areas. There is a need to promote portable and universal social security benefits alongwith affordable childcare, transportation etc. The E-Shram data need to be leveraged to identify migrant status and integrate State level labour welfare schemes so that workers are not deprived of social security benefits when they migrate. Urban resilience for women can only be achieved by combining social protection rights under labour codes with investments in gender responsive infrastructure that encourage women to work.

The writer is a Fellow and Co-ordinator, Centre for Gender and Labour, VV Giri National Labour Institute, Ministry of Labour and Employment, Noida

Scrutiny, not applause: Philosophy meets its skeptics

ACHARYA PRASHANT

Indian spiritual figures have been travelling abroad for more than a century. Halls have filled, applause has sounded, and followings have formed across the world. My tour of Britain in May to July 2026 might look like one more link in that chain. But what mattered was who sat across from me, and the standard against which the argument was placed.

The tour began on May 30, at the Cambridge Union, moderated by Professor Jaideep Prabhu. A student put her point: "At Cambridge, learning is based on evidence, and every belief is tested against a standard. So how is this philosophy any different from any other belief?"

"Let us rebuild this framework right now, right here, from scratch," I said, "leaning as little as possible on belief and dogma." If a framework is universal, it cannot belong to any one person; it has to be built and tested together. A session scheduled for one hour stretched into nearly three sittings across two days. When a participant thanked me for sharing "my philosophy," I corrected her: it had been built together in that room.

At the London School of Economics there was a dialogue with Professor Jonathan Birch, who has led the Jeremy Coller Centre for Animal Sentience and whose work has shaped Britain's animal welfare laws. At University College London there was a long conversation with Professor Steve Fleming, an expert in metacognition. There were dialogues with Cambridge-trained biologist Rupert Sheldrake in Hampstead; Professor Lars Chittka, a Fellow of the Royal Society and an expert in insect cognition, at Queen Mary University; and Harvard-educated psychologist Melanie Joy, who works on the psychology of eating animals.

These gatherings assembled not for emulation but examination. Those present had every reason to challenge the framework in their own professional fields.

At the centre of this philosophical framework is a question that shifts the source of human problems. The real issue is not external but psychological: a mistaken sense of "I" that identifies itself with the body and mind. Vedanta calls it the ego. From it arise fear, desire, conflict and consumption that widen into social and ecological crises. Without examining this inner structure, external solutions such as law, technology and reform remain incomplete, because the same agent that creates the problem stays active within the solution.

At London Climate Action Week, the present climate effort was compared to a society that keeps repairing roads and ambulances without addressing the drunk driver. The belief that technology and policy will solve the crisis has to be abandoned. Technology is born not of human need but human desire, and what the world calls success is, to a large extent, another name for a growing carbon footprint.

At Queen Mary University of London, when the ego was called the "master exploiter" behind every discovery, Professor Chittka offered examples where scientific work led directly to conservation. "I am perhaps a little less pessimistic," he said. The answer was that the agent that does the damage is the one that repairs it too, and the repair does not acquit it: a clean-up campaign run by the exploiter himself.

When animal violence was called instinct rather than psychological, Chittka countered with field observations. The answer was that the observer projects human interiority onto animal behaviour. "Sir, you yourself have long campaigned against anthropomorphism," I said, "and I am afraid that at this moment you are doing exactly that." The dialogue ended without agreement, but with full engagement.

Animal welfare law has been growing for nearly two centuries, yet neither species extinction nor per-capita meat consumption has fallen. The one who makes the law and the one who breaks it are the same person. At LSE, Professor Birch did not give up his ground: "Do laws help? I think they do. But I do not believe they solve all our problems."

The sharpest moment came when Birch said, "But I think we matter." I answered, "No, we do not." His counter-question was direct: what measurable change has come from my work? Media reports record more than a million animals saved from slaughter in 2024, and more than two hundred thousand registered students in structured programmes of self-enquiry.

At UCL, Professor Fleming appreciated an analogy separating metacognition from self-knowledge: a car's speedometer reads the system, while the driver examines himself and finds that there is no driver at all. But Fleming did not agree. "There is one part of your analogy where I would perhaps differ," he said, "and that is the notion of the driver."

If the system has no separate dashboard, then the sense of a separate ego reading it is itself the error. Fleming asked: if the ego is an illusion, then whose is the error? My answer was that the one speaking and thinking is the one predicating itself. No separate observer exists apart from the ego who could say there is an error. Professor Fleming held out a research goal that runs against the framework: an account of the mind so complete in its computations that there is no need to admit any third thing. My answer was direct: "You may explain it, and the ego will say, I did the explaining, but it will still remain."

In Kingston, the conversation with Rupert Spira was the closest philosophically, yet it was not allowed to dissolve into mutual admiration. Where most Advaita teaching turns towards awareness, I keep bringing the conversation back to the ego. "If you are speaking of spirituality without the ego," I said, "then we are speaking of medicine without the patient."

The professors were on their own ground, in their subjects and institutions. The conversation was held in the language of empirical science, not in the tradition's vocabulary. The framework had to be tested; there was no room to escape by saying, "this lies beyond the scope of my tradition." The established guru circuit usually keeps its distance from such a format.

What this proves is limited, but real. It made a demand of both sides that traditional gurudom does not. The speaker had to bear the risk of being shown wrong, and the audience had to take part in examination in place of applause. In a field where success is usually measured by crowd size, this tour set down another test: whether the argument holds up in that room. Whether this can grow larger, or even wishes to, remains an open question.

Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

Female criminality: A lesser-addressed dimension of the criminal justice system

AKLAVYA ANAND
SHALINI SABOO

The alleged unfortunate homicide of Ketan Agarwal has brought the debate surrounding the actors and factors of the criminal justice system to every nook and corner of our nation. Ketan was visiting Lohagad Fort, a scenic spot popular with tourists and trekkers, with his fiancée, Siya Goyal, when he fell into a ditch. Days later, police arrested Siya, 20, and her friend, Chetan Chaudhary, 22, alleging that they murdered Agarwal by pushing him from a height. The alleged motive for this murder was that Ketan was to be married to Siya, though she was clandestinely in a relationship with Chetan. In this particular case, a pattern appears that is similar to other recent incidents in which neither Siya nor Chetan had a criminal record prior to this alleged crime. Their alleged participation and the subsequent public response warrant a thoughtful examination of pertinent questions regarding female criminality.

Societal expectations towards females always seek to create an ideal woman. This notion is challenged when a woman is involved in a particularly heinous crime that involves the killing of her to be husband. As a result, when the criminal justice system puts a woman on trial, we see that the house of justice is marked by two parallel trials. One is the justice system, which is formally designed to conduct a trial; and the second is the media trial. Here deterministic answers are sought about the mores of society which have been broken by the acts of perpetrators at all levels, including those of the accused and of womanhood itself.

Considering the wider outcry around the question of female involvement in the crime, there is a need to examine the theoretical framework for understanding and explaining female criminality and the pathology surrounding the deviant acts of women perpetrators. There is also a need to ensure parity and fairness in the treatment of female offenders compared with their male counterparts so that justice must not succumb to any kind of sexist ideology. The very idea of women being cross examined elicits indignation among stakeholders and justice entrepreneurs globally. Further, the criminal justice system is accustomed to viewing women as victims, and society still struggles to accept that women can also be perpetrators. As a result, when a woman is involved in a homicide case, it often attracts disproportionate public attention. Therefore, when women are accused of serious violence, it challenges not only criminal law but also deeply rooted social expectations. However, a dominant discourse on female criminality, propagated by Pollock, argues that females have an equally strong deviant character, and their methods differ from those of their male counterparts. He argues that it is rooted in manipulation, deceit, and treachery, whereas male criminality is predominantly rooted in physical force. Many landmark cases in criminal law, especially those related to murder, involve male perpetrators. A notable example is the case of South African athlete Oscar Pistorius, who was convicted of killing his girlfriend, claiming he mistakenly believed an intruder was present. In the recent case of the killing of Shraddha Walkar, after killing her, her body was kept in a freezer. Such a narrative portrays males as the primary perpetrators of crime. However, it overlooks female criminality in the current context, in which no gender has a monopoly over deviant behaviour. To substantiate women's role in violent crimes, a few cases are important, showing how violent crime can be committed through deceitful means. Within this context, Battered Women's Syndrome (BWS) emerged as one of the most influential developments in criminal law. This challenges the stereotype that women are inherently non violent, showing that women may use violence as a means of emancipation from prolonged domestic abuse, eventually resorting to lethal violence against their abusers. So, violence could also be a tool to equalise and at times it is an act of rebellion.

Recently, in Kerala, a daughter in law killed six of her husband's relatives by administering cyanide. In another case, Shabnam, along with her lover, killed seven relatives after administering sleeping pills. Mamta Pathak was convicted of murder for electrocuting her husband.

In the recent Sonam Shillong case, the husband was killed in Shillong and the whole episode was again allegedly planned with the active mental participation of the woman who was not so much in the physical aspect of the act. In all these cases one thing is apparent: female criminality is not based on physical aspects. They are a clear sign of treachery. Killing by poison, electrocuting, and hiring an assassin shows that women are capable of committing crimes in their own ways.

It is important to realise here that society finds female criminality shocking because it challenges traditional gender stereotypes. Deviance is often viewed as masculine. The female body is often regarded as sacred and, in many ways, perceived as incapable of committing heinous crimes. When a man commits murder, society typically views him simply as a man who has killed someone. In contrast, when a woman commits the same act, it tends to be viewed in a more complex manner, eliciting a range of emotional reactions that probe the collective conscience.

If gender becomes a basis for justice, it undermines the notion of justice as impartial and objective. In the current case, equality before the law demands more than recognising women as victims. It requires criminal justice professionals to understand that a person can be both a victim and a perpetrator, regardless of gender. Until our public conversations integrate these possibilities, every woman accused of murder will continue to face two trials: one in court and another in the court of public opinion.

Crime can be committed regardless of gender. A criminal must be punished as per the law. Punishment devoid of legal basis becomes revenge. In this context, the statement by the parents of Siya Goyal that if she has committed the crime, she should also be pushed from the same fort from where Ketan was pushed and given the same punishment has no legal basis.

Gandhi has said that an eye for an eye will make the whole world blind. Law needs to be reformative and forward looking.

To understand the current situation, the criminal justice system needs to be better equipped to handle cases of female criminality and society must recognise that it is on the cusp of a transformation in which the dominant narrative that portrays crime as a monopoly of males needs to be rethought.

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Absence of train ticket alone cannot defeat railway accident claim: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

In a significant verdict, the Supreme Court on Friday said the mere absence of a train ticket on the body of a deceased passenger cannot be a ground to deny compensation to the victim's family in a railway accident case.

The ruling, aimed to strengthen the rights of railway passengers and their families, set aside the concurrent orders of the Railway Claims Tribunal (RCT) and the Madhya Pradesh High Court, and awarded a compensation of ₹8 lakh to Lata, the widow of a man who died after falling from a running train in 2015.

A bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiswar Singh allowed the appeal of the widow, whose compensation claim was rejected by the RCT and the high court on the ground that her husband was not proved to be a bona-fide passenger because his ticket was not found after the accident. The top court said the Railways Act is a beneficial welfare legislation and must receive a liberal and purposive interpretation.

Referring to earlier verdicts, Justice Karol, who authored the judgment, said, "The beneficial legislations are to receive purposive and liberal construction in furtherance of the intentions of the legislature, as can be discerned, instead of a literal or restrictive approach being adopted. The overall idea is to make the intention so understood, functional." The verdict said "technical approaches and lapses in procedure should not defeat the welfare aim of the statute as it does not befit the railways, as an instrumentality of the State, to take such a restrictive, pigeonhole view".

The verdict said the proceedings under section 124A of the Railways Act are based on the principle of "no-fault liability", intended to provide speedy compensation to victims of untoward railway incidents, without requiring any proof of negligence.

Relying on earlier decisions, the bench said, "Merely because the ticket of a train journey was not found on the person of the deceased, it will not change his status as a bona-fide passenger. It has been held that the initial burden of the claimant can be satisfied by way of an affidavit."

It observed that the claimant's initial burden can be discharged through a credible affidavit and surrounding circumstances, after which the burden shifts to the railways to rebut the claim.

The case arose from the death of Chandrakant Thakkar, who allegedly fell from the Ahmedabad-Howrah Mail train while travelling from Raipur to Ahmedabad in November 2015.

His travel bag, which reportedly contained the train ticket, went missing after the accident. Allowing the widow's appeal, filed through lawyer Shweta Priyadarshini, the bench awarded the appellant a compensation of ₹8 lakh under the Railway Accidents and Untoward Incidents (Compensation) Rules.

It directed the Centre to release the amount within four weeks, failing which it will carry interest at the rate of 8 per cent per annum from the date of filing of the claim petition.

"Well, the above is about what a passenger or his family members must show to get compensation from the railways. But what is the duty of the railways towards the customer/traveller? To put things in perspective, it must be said that what happened in this case, that a traveller on a train, for whatever reason, fell off the train and injured himself or died, is not a rare occurrence," the court said.

The judgment also contains significant observations on railway safety and passenger welfare.

Referring to recurring incidents of passengers falling from overcrowded trains, the verdict said although the Indian Railways has framed detailed operational manuals requiring ticket checks, crowd-management and passenger-safety measures, effective implementation remains a challenge.

It pointed out that overcrowding continues to be a regular occurrence and has contributed to numerous fatal accidents across the country.

SC seeks data on voters removed under SIR in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday sought responses from the Election Commission, the West Bengal Government and the state poll panel on a PIL seeking disclosure of assembly constituency-wise data of claims and objections filed by deleted voters during the SIR process.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was hearing the plea filed by Prasenjit Bose, chairperson of the SIR Committee of West Bengal Pradesh Congress Committee.

The petition, filed through lawyer Neha Rathi, sought assembly constituency-wise data relating to the West Bengal Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process, including the number of Forms 6 and 7 filed, admitted and rejected, as well as details regarding the pendency and disposal of appeals before the appellate tribunals.

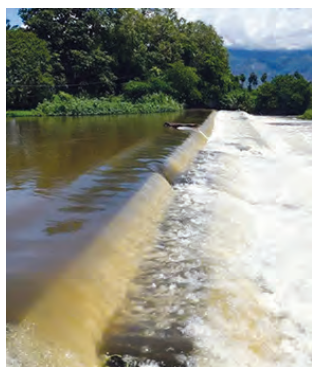
Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayan, appearing for Bose, said that the manner in which 18 tribunals set up to deal with the claims and objections of deleted voters are functioning is causing discrepancies and delays at a practical level. He said due to deletions, the persons are excluded from welfare measures like public distribution and Annapurna schemes in the state and they are being denied the caste certificates as well.

The bench referred to the judgement delivered in the Bihar SIR case and said, "There is a corresponding duty on the Election Commission that when a tribunal says a person cannot be on the SIR list, the EC has to refer the case to the Union ministry for the determination of citizenship under the Citizenship Act."

"The Election Commission is not a constitutional authority concerning the determination of citizenship. There is no confusion in law," the bench added.

Order Order

Authorities neglecting Periyar river conservation: Kerala HC



The Kerala High Court has expressed dissatisfaction with the proposed timeline for setting up a STP to curb pollution of the Periyar River, saying that the authorities concerned, including the PCB, have failed to give due importance to the need to preserve the waterbody.

The observation by a bench of Chief Justice Soumen Sen and Justice Syam Kumar VM came after the PCB submitted a report stating that the work to set up the Sewage Treatment Plant (STP) will be completed by August next year.

"We are not at all satisfied with the progress of the work expected to be carried out by the Pollution Control Board (PCB). The timeline suggested by the Chief Environmental Engineer in the report dated July 14, 2026 is not acceptable to this court. We are of the view that the authorities concerned have failed to attach due importance to the earlier orders passed by this court as well as to the need to preserve the river Periyar and its flora and fauna," the bench said. It directed that the entire work related to setting up of the STP shall be completed on or before December 31 this year. "The said direction is peremptory," it said and listed the matter to January 2027, where the Chief Environmental Engineer has to file a compliance report.

The court's observation and directions came on a batch of petitions seeking to curb the pollution of Periyar river by preventing dumping of effluents into it from industries and the Aluva Market. The bench had, in June, directed the Board to give a revised time schedule for setting up the STP to curb pollution of the river and to strictly follow the same as such a system was "essential for protection of bio-diversity and the flora and fauna" connected with the waterbody. (*PTI*)

Interim bail of Al Falah University chairman refused

The Delhi High Court has refused to grant interim bail of six weeks to Al Falah University group chairman Jawad Ahmed Siddiqui, who is in custody in two money laundering cases.

Justice Saurabh Banerjee, however, permitted Siddiqui to meet his wife – a stage 4 ovarian cancer patient – on custody parole on three dates. Siddiqui sought interim bail on the ground that his wife's health was critical and he wanted to be with her at this stage of her life. Justice Banerjee observed that there was nothing on record to show any "emergent situation", and in fact, the medical record showed that the condition of Siddiqui's wife was not deteriorating but rather improving. The judge further said that Siddiqui may be a flight risk and can influence the witnesses or try to tamper with evidence if released.

"Though this court is sympathetic towards the medical condition of the applicant's wife, however, considering the gravity and nature of the allegations levelled against the applicant, and the status of the proceedings, the role assigned to him, his status and position in the university/ society, this court is of the considered opinion that the statutory rigours governing grant of bail cannot be diluted merely on humanitarian considerations, more so, in the absence of any emergent and/ or exceptional circumstance warranting the applicant's immediate release," the court said in the order dated July 13.

"This court is not inclined to grant interim bail to the present applicant at this stage. However, in order to balance the equities as also taking a humanitarian view, this Court deems it appropriate to grant custody parole to the applicant for a period of three days i.e. 21.07.2026, 23.07.2026 and 25.07.2026," it ordered. (*PTI*)

Nominated members of municipalities not entitled to vote in council polls, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court has said that nominated members appointed in municipalities are not entitled to vote in legislative council elections, dismissing the appeal of BJP's Karnataka Legislative Council (KLC) member Pranesh MK against the recounting of votes in the 2021 polls.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi, in an order pronounced on Thursday, said 12 nominated members appointed in four town panchayats under the Karnataka Municipalities Act (KMA) were ineligible to vote and were not entitled to be in the electoral rolls of the legislative council elections.

"We are of the view that the nominated members appointed under Section 352(1)(b) of the KMA were not entitled to be included in the electoral roll prepared for the Local Authorities' Constituency and their inclusion was contrary to the constitutional scheme and cannot be sustained in law," the top court said in its verdict.

Pranesh was elected as an MLC by a narrow victory margin of six votes after 12 nominated members of four town panchayats voted in his favour. The bench said the crucial question is whether people who are not allowed by the Constitution to vote in municipal matters can still vote in elections for members of the legislative council. "In our considered view, the answer must necessarily be in the negative," the bench said, adding that if Article 171(3)(a) of the Constitution was to be interpreted literally so as to include nominated members, an unreasonable consequence would follow.

The bench said the Constitution should not be interpreted in a way that creates such contradictions and the courts need to contextually interpret the provisions in order to further the constitutional objective, that is, democratic representation.

It further said that the court was in agreement with the view taken by the high court that nominated members appointed under Section 352(1)(b) of the KMA were not entitled to be included in the electoral roll prepared for the local authorities' constituency and their inclusion was contrary to the constitutional scheme and could not be sustained in law.

SC allows release of animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath* after July 28

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday permitted the all India release of animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath* on or after July 28 post Lord Jagannath Yatra festivities.

A bench of Justices BV Nagarathna and R Mahadevan noted that the animated movie was based on a web series already released on Youtube, and that the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC) had granted clearance for its screening. The producers of the film, which was scheduled to be released Friday, had challenged the July 15 order of the Orissa High Court which restrained Ele Animations Pvt Ltd from releasing the movie.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the State, said the Yatra has commenced on Thursday in Odisha and other parts of the country. The bench, which refused to stay the high court order, declined to direct the release of the movie on July 17. "After the Rath Yatra concludes, you can release the movie," Justice Nagarathna told senior advocate Devadatt Kamat, appearing for the film producers.

Kamat strongly urged the bench to allow the release of the film on the date originally announced, saying the web series which was released on YouTube two years back had not created any problem for anyone.

The bench, however, asked him not to release the movie during Rath Yatra festivities. Kamat contended that crores of rupees have been invested and theatres were booked and they would suffer enormous loss if film is not released during the ten days festivities.

He said the CBFC has cleared the film, which is meant for children and is pure fiction like an animated film on Bal Ganesh. The bench disposed of the petition filed by producers against the high court order.

The high court had observed that the objections raised over its portrayal of Lord Jagannath require detailed judicial scrutiny before the film can be exhibited.

Delhi HC to hear PIL on July 20 over intrusive surveillance at Jantar Mantar protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday agreed to hear a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) on July 20, alleging "continuous, indiscriminate and intrusive surveillance" at the ongoing protest at Jantar Mantar here over alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG examination.

The PIL by former JNUSU President Aishe Ghosh sought urgent hearing before a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia.

The senior counsel of the petitioner said that policemen were roaming with mobiles and cameras at the protest site, which, they claim, was breaking the morale of the protesting students.

She claimed that the police's conduct was in flagrant violation of the fundamental right to privacy of the protesters. After the senior counsel urged the court to list the PIL for an urgent hearing, Chief Justice Upadhyaya scheduled it for Monday.

"We are preponing it (from Wednesday when PILs are heard). Come on Monday," Chief Justice Upadhyaya said. The Cockroach Janta Party has been holding a protest for over 26 days demanding Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation over alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG examination.

Activist Sonam Wangchuk joined the agitation on June 28 and has been on an indefinite fast since then.

The PIL, filed through lawyer Subhash Chandran KR, seeks a declaration that "continuous and intrusive mass surveillance" of peaceful protesters is constitutionally impermissible, disproportionate, and cannot be justified under the guise of maintaining public order or national security.

It seeks a direction to the authorities to immediately suspend the mass photography, videography, and surveillance at Jantar Mantar until there is a "proximate, real, and imminent threat to public order" justifying such measures.

"The petitioner has in her possession photographs depicting the permanent surveillance tower and the continuous photography and videography undertaken by police personnel, which demonstrate the pervasive and intrusive nature of the surveillance being carried out by the respondents," the plea said.

SC to hear challenge to HC order on Indian missions visa tender

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday agreed to hear on July 20 the Centre's plea against a Delhi High Court verdict setting aside the tender awarded to private firms for outsourcing Consular, Passport and Visa (CPV) services at Indian missions in Abu Dhabi, Kuwait, Singapore and Canberra.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was urged by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta that the high court's decision has made rendering of visa and other services at these places difficult.

The CJI agreed to hear the plea on Monday.

While setting aside the tender awarded to private firms for outsourcing CPV services, the high court had directed the Centre to issue a fresh Request for Proposals (RFP), inviting fresh bids.

The solicitor general said that fresh tenders were awarded following the procedure, but no new entity can start functioning straightaway, and as a result, such services have almost become dysfunctional.

In its verdict, the high court said that while taking the decision, the Centre relied on undisclosed comparative standards, made unexplained deductions under objective evaluation criteria, and adopted inconsistent marking.

The court said that these deficiencies struck at the very heart of transparency, fairness and equality in the public procurement process.

"The use of undisclosed comparative standards, unexplained deductions under objective criteria, inconsistent marking and complete absence of recorded reasons strikes at the heart of transparency, fairness and equality in public procurement.

Therefore, exclusion of a lower bidder on the basis of an arbitrary evaluation process is not merely an individual grievance but also raises concerns of public interest under Article 14 of the Constitution," the high court said. The technical evaluation processes are set aside, the high court said.

"Consequently, the award of tender in favour of the private respondents shall also stand nullified. Respondent numbers 1 and 2 are directed to issue a fresh RFP for procurement of CPV services across all four Missions, namely, Abu Dhabi (UAE), Kuwait, Singapore and Canberra (Australia), within a period of one month from the date of this judgment and make sincere efforts to conclude the process at the earliest," the court said.

The verdict was delivered on petitions filed by two unsuccessful bidders, E Trav Tech Limited and Verasys Limited.

The firms had participated in the tender process but were disqualified at the technical evaluation stage, since they had failed to secure the minimum 70 per cent marks to qualify for opening of their financial bids. They then challenged the communications, declaring them unsuccessful.

Asaram bail plea: SC says don't want any untoward incident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

"We don't want any untoward thing to happen," the Supreme Court said on Friday while asking the Rajasthan Government to take proper instructions about the health condition of self-styled godman Asaram, who is seeking interim bail on medical grounds.

The Rajasthan High Court on May 27 upheld the conviction and life sentence awarded to the octogenarian in a case of rape of a minor in 2013.

He has filed an application in the apex court seeking interim bail on health grounds.

The matter came up for hearing before a bench of justices M M Sundresh and P B Varale. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Rajasthan Government, told the bench that the AIIMS has said that Asaram needs some lifestyle changes.

"We don't want ourselves to be blamed or yourself to be blamed," the bench observed while asking Mehta to take proper instructions about his health condition. Mehta said the state would file an affidavit by July 20.

"There is some bleeding because of some gastro problem but that appears to be a temporary phenomenon," the top law officer said, adding that Asaram was taking medication.

The bench said, "We will only say that please take appropriate instructions because we don't want any untoward thing to happen."

The counsel appearing for Asaram said he was a high-risk patient.

Mehta said three months ago, Asaram went to Ayodhya and Kashi Vishwanath and he walked everywhere.

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West Asia crisis, weak monsoon major risks to growth: RBI Guv

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said the West Asia crisis and the expectation of a weak monsoon present significant risks to economic growth.

"Despite global uncertainties, India has witnessed an over 7 per cent growth rate in the past few years. Last financial year, India clocked a growth rate of 7.7 per cent supported by strong and robust macroeconomic fundamentals," he said in an interview to DD News.

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has projected a GDP growth of 6.6 per cent for the current financial year despite various challenges, he said.

"Monetary and fiscal policies are robust, and because of that, we are witnessing high GDP growth," the governor added.

On inflation, he said the central bank has raised its inflation forecast to 5.1 per cent for FY27, higher than its earlier estimate of 4.6 per cent.

Inflation going past the Reserve Bank's median target of 4 per cent in June was largely driven by supply-side factors, Malhotra noted.

Retail inflation climbed to 4.38 per cent in June from 3.93 per cent in May, mainly due to costlier food items.

Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra

The food inflation increased to 5.32 per cent in June from 4.78 per cent in the preceding month.

Talking about another risk factor, Malhotra said that how the monsoon behaves is crucial, as a large population depends on the agriculture sector.

Agriculture contributes about 17 per cent to the GDP, he said, adding that "we have to be vigilant about that (monsoon)".

On the rupee depreciation, Malhotra said the domestic currency performance against peers remains stable despite a stronger dollar and heightened global uncertainty.

"After the war in West Asia, the dollar has become strong. The currencies of many countries have weakened. If we look at it from a global perspective, India's rupee situation can be considered normal," he said.

Last year, the gross FDI was around $95 billion, which was a record, Malhotra said, adding that net foreign direct investment in the first two months of the current financial year was around $7 billion.

"In the medium and long term, our balance of payments and our external sector will remain strong. There is no need to worry," he said.

Malhotra further said that the RBI will continue to prioritise inflation while supporting economic growth, and low and stable inflation provides the foundation for sustainable growth.

Inflation control remained the RBI's primary objective under the flexible inflation-targeting framework, while growth was its secondary objective.

"They are not in opposition. They support each other," he added.

Asked about the loan growth, the governor said credit growth remained broad-based across sectors.

Overall bank credit grew around 18 per cent year-on-year in June against 17.5 per cent in May, he said.

On artificial intelligence adoption, Malhotra said the RBI had encouraged banks to adopt AI to improve customer service, lower operating costs, and enhance decision-making while ensuring safeguards against cybersecurity and data privacy risks.

Earlier this week, the governor, while addressing managing directors and chief executive officers of public and select private sector banks, asked them to leverage advanced technologies, including AI, to expand their reach while ensuring robust cybersecurity and safeguards against fraud and data misuse.

Bharat Tex 2026 generates $2.8 billion in business inquiries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Business inquiries to the tune of $2.8 billion, along with textile investment commitments from various States worth ₹14,300 crore, were generated during the first three days of the global textile event Bharat Tex 2026.

The four-day Bharat Tex 2026, which concluded on July 17, brought together 1,647 exhibitors, nearly 95,000 business visitors, 11,315 buyers, including 6,090 international buyers, 3,461 delegates and participants from 138 countries, according to the Textile Ministry.

"Bharat Tex 2026 catalysed around ₹14,300 crore of textile investment commitments with over 30 MoUs signed by various States, including Karnataka (₹2,821 crore, 11,020 jobs), Bihar (₹1,476 crore, over 40,500 jobs), Maharashtra (₹1,095 crore) and Andhra Pradesh (₹4,100 crore)," the ministry said.

It said the above figures reinforce the event's role in driving decentralised, State-led growth in India's textile and apparel sector.

"Further, RE&UP (a textile recycling firm) announced investing ₹4,800 crores in India. Also, the serious business enquiries worth approximately $2.8 billion were generated during the event," the ministry said.

Reliance shares jump 3% ahead of Q1 earnings report

Shares of Reliance Industries Ltd climbed nearly 3 per cent on Friday ahead of the company's June quarter earnings announcement, adding ₹45,334 crore to its market valuation. The blue-chip stock edged higher by 2.59 per cent to settle at ₹1,326.50 on the BSE. During the day, it surged 2.85 per cent to ₹1,329.95. On the NSE, the stock climbed 2.36 per cent to end at ₹1,327.20. The company's market valuation surged ₹45,334.01 crore to ₹17,95,091.26 crore. The rally in the stock was instrumental in driving the equity markets higher. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 964.58 points, or 1.25 per cent, to settle at 78,151.45. The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 261.55 points, or 1.09 per cent, to end at 24,334.30. In volume terms, 8.49 lakh shares of the company were traded on the BSE and 183.02 lakh shares on the NSE during the day. Meanwhile, the promoter group of Reliance Industries increased its shareholding by nearly 0.5 percentage points during the June quarter through market purchases, reinforcing its long-term commitment to the country's most valuable company. (*PTI*)

Gold declines ₹800 to 3-week low of ₹1.45 lakh per 10 grams

Gold price resumed its downward trend to hit a three-week low in the national Capital on Friday, declining by ₹800 to ₹1.45 lakh per 10 grams, and silver dropped ₹2,000 due to sluggish local demand.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated by ₹800 to ₹1,45,500 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from Thursday's closing level of ₹1,46,300 per 10 grams, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Silver also dropped by ₹2,000 to ₹2,22,500 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had closed at ₹2,24,500 per kg in the preceding session.

Gold traded near this level on June 25, when it was quoted at ₹1,45,300 per 10 grams.

Traders said gold prices resumed their decline after a two-session pause, falling to their lowest level in three weeks, while silver continued to witness sustained liquidation.

In international markets, spot gold gained $15.42, or 0.39 per cent, to $3,992 per ounce; however, silver edged lower to $55.37 per ounce. (PTI)

Govt adds iron ore as 9th core industry

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

The Government on Friday said it has included iron ore in the list of core sector infrastructure industries, a move which will help in capturing the performance of the economy in a better way.

Consequently, the number of core industries has increased from eight to nine.

Currently, the Government evaluates the performance of eight key sectors — crude oil, petroleum refinery, cement, electricity, natural gas, fertiliser, finished steel and coal — on a monthly basis.

"In view of the extensive use of iron ore in industrial production and its significant contribution to industrial development, Iron Ore has been included as a core industry in the revised ICI series," the Commerce and Industry Ministry said in a statement.

The new series with base year 2022-23, containing data for nine key sectors, will be released on July 20 this year.

The revised series will replace the existing Index of Core Industries (ICI) series with the base year 2011-12.

The ministry also said that to ensure consistency with the IIP (Index of Industrial Production), the revised ICI series uses gross production data for compiling the Steel Index, replacing the net production data used in the ICI (2011-12) series.

In the coal sector also, only Raw Coal has been retained in the revised series.

Coal Middlings and Washed Coal have been excluded to eliminate double counting, as both are derived from Raw Coal, it added.

In 2011, the Government included two sectors: natural gas and fertiliser.

Production growth of eight core infrastructure sectors slowed to a seven-month low of 0.5 per cent in May due to a fall in output of coal, crude oil and refinery products.

Markets surge on blue-chip buying; Sensex jumps 965 pts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai

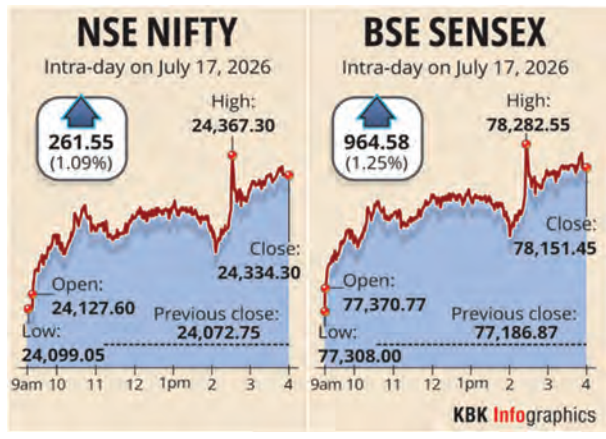
Market benchmark indices ended sharply higher on Friday, with the Sensex climbing 964.58 points and the Nifty reaching the 24,330 level, propelled by buying in blue-chip Reliance Industries, bank and IT stocks.

Additionally, a strengthening rupee against the US dollar improved sentiment, even as the broader market remained predominantly negative due to weak global cues, traders said.

After a subdued ending in the previous trade, the 30-share BSE Sensex bounced back 964.58 points, or 1.25 per cent, to settle at 78,151.45. During the day, it surged 1,095.68 points, or 1.41 per cent, to 78,282.55.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 261.55 points, or 1.09 per cent, to end at 24,334.30.

"There is a shift in market momentum, with strong traction moving toward large-cap stocks, led by the IT and banking sectors. This is supported by optimism around business updates and Q1 earnings expectations," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.



The trend appears to be driven largely by domestic institutional investors rotating out of expensive mid and small-cap stocks and into more attractively valued large caps that offer a better risk-reward profile, he added.

On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark climbed 582.06 points, or 0.75 per cent, and the Nifty went up by 127.4 points, or 0.52 per cent.

From the Sensex pack, Tech Mahindra jumped 3.91 per cent after it reported a 28.4 per cent rise in consolidated net profit for the June quarter to ₹1,465 crore, and expressed confidence about the demand environment.

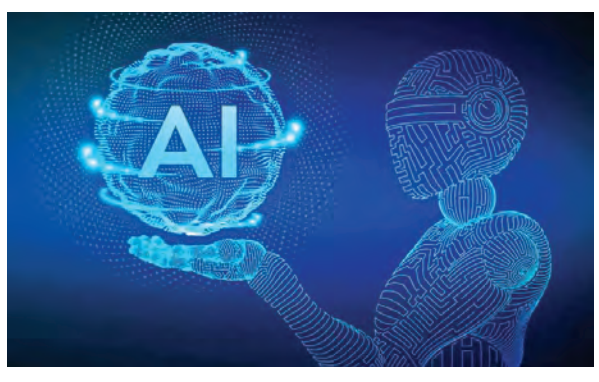
Kotak Mahindra Bank, Tata Consultancy Services, Reliance Industries, Hindustan Unilever, Mahindra & Mahindra, Axis Bank, ICICI Bank and Bajaj Finance were also among the winners.

Reliance Industries is scheduled to announce its June quarter earnings later in the day.

Sun Pharma, Trent, Bharti Airtel and UltraTech Cement were among the laggards.

AI skill demand rises over 17-fold in technology jobs, says report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi



AI fluency is rapidly emerging as a baseline workplace capability, with AI-related skills now featuring in 15.4 per cent of technology job descriptions, while AI skill mentions in non-technology roles have increased nearly sixfold, says a report.

According to Naukri's latest World AI Day Report 2026, AI-related skills now appear in 15.4 per cent of technology job descriptions, up from 0.9 per cent in 2020, reflecting a nearly 17-fold increase in employer demand over the past six years.

The report drew insights from nearly 27,000 professionals across 80+ industries and 15+ cities and analysed over 3 lakh job descriptions.

Interestingly, AI adoption is spreading beyond traditional technology functions. Mentions of AI-related skills in non-technology job descriptions have increased from 0.26 per cent in 2020 to 1.59 per cent in 2026, reflecting nearly six-fold growth.

As AI talent becomes increasingly valuable, professionals with AI skills continue to enjoy a measurable salary advantage.

"AI is no longer a future trend; it is already reshaping how India works. It's showing up in job descriptions, hiring patterns, workplace tools and career decisions. The real question now is readiness," Sumeet Singh, Group CMO, Info Edge (India) Ltd, said.

According to the report, professionals with AI skills earn higher median salaries across both IT and non-IT roles than peers without AI skills. AI-enabled roles have also recorded stronger salary growth over the past four years, reinforcing the growing business value of AI expertise.

AI hiring has grown fastest among professionals with 13 to 16 years of experience, followed by those with 16+ years, as per the report.

Recruiter demand has also increased significantly for higher salary brackets, including ₹40-49 lakh and ₹50 lakh and above, indicating that organisations are investing in experienced professionals capable of leading enterprise AI transformation.

AI usage is particularly high among professionals working in AI-intensive functions. Product Management, Data Science and Analytics, and Engineering, Software and QA report the highest proportion of professionals who rely heavily on AI in their work.

The report noted that India's AI journey has entered a new phase. While organisations are accelerating AI adoption and demand for specialised skills continues to grow, sustained investment in workforce development will determine how effectively businesses and professionals realise AI's full potential.

India's forex kitty jumps $964 million to $675.15 billion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai

India's forex reserves jumped $964 million to $675.157 billion in the week ended July 10, the Reserve Bank said on Friday. In the previous reporting week, the overall kitty had jumped by $7.26 billion to $674.193 billion.

The kitty had expanded to an all-time high of $728.494 billion during the week ended February 27 this year before the onset of the West Asia conflict, which led to several weeks of drop as the rupee came under pressure and the RBI had to intervene in the forex market through dollar sales. For the week ended July 10, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, increased by $930 million to $546.508 billion, the central bank's data showed. Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include the effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

The value of gold reserves increased by $24 million to $105.223 billion during the week, the RBI said. The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were up by $3 million at $18.626 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the IMF was also up by $7 million to $4.793 billion at the end of the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

PNB signs MoU with Digital India BHASHINI for multilingual AI banking

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

Punjab National Bank (PNB), one of India's leading public sector banks, signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Digital India BHASHINI Division (DIBD) at its Corporate Office in Dwarka, New Delhi.

The MoU was formalised in the presence of M Paramasivam, Executive Director, PNB; Amitabh Nag, CEO, Digital India BHASHINI Division (DIBD); and Atish Kumar Rout, Chief General Manager (D), Digital Banking Transformation Division (DBTD), PNB.

Through this partnership, BHASHINI's advanced multilingual AI capabilities will be integrated into PNB's digital platforms. This will empower customers to access banking services seamlessly in multiple Indian languages via both voice and text.

Speaking on the occasion, M Paramasivam, Executive Director, PNB, said, "The collaboration between BHASHINI and PNB demonstrates how digital public infrastructure can accelerate inclusive digital transformation across sectors. By combining multilingual AI with public service delivery, this initiative will help bridge language barriers and ensure that digital banking services are more accessible, equitable, and citizen-friendly for people across the country."

Amitabh Nag, CEO, Digital India BHASHINI Division (DIBD), said, "Language should never be a barrier to essential banking services. Our partnership with PNB advances BHASHINI's vision of a voice first, multilingual banking system. By integrating AI powered language technologies, we are building inclusive digital infrastructure that enables citizens to access financial services seamlessly in their preferred Indian language, making digital banking more intuitive, inclusive, and citizen centric."

Atish Kumar Rout, Chief General Manager (D), DBTD, PNB, remarked, "PNB remains committed to delivering accessible, secure, and customer-centric digital banking services. Our collaboration with the Digital India BHASHINI Division will enable us to leverage cutting-edge multilingual AI technologies, making our digital platforms more inclusive and easier to use for customers across diverse linguistic backgrounds.

FROM THE WORLD

SRI LANKA

Former Indian cricketer held

A former Indian under-19 cricketer, who is a co-owner of the Lanka Premier League (LPL) franchise Jaffna Kings, was arrested by Sri Lanka's sports anti-corruption investigators on Friday over allegations of attempting to bribe a player, the police said.

The arrest took place hours before the sixth edition of the tournament kicked off. The suspect, Manjot Kalra, remembered for his match-winning century in the final of the 2018 Under-19 Cricket World Cup, was arrested by the Police Special Investigation Unit for the Prevention of Offences Relating to Sports and produced before a magistrate, who ordered Kalra to be remanded till July 31. Kalra, 27, who transitioned into sports entrepreneurship, invested in the Jaffna Kings franchise earlier this year. (*PTI*)

DENMARK

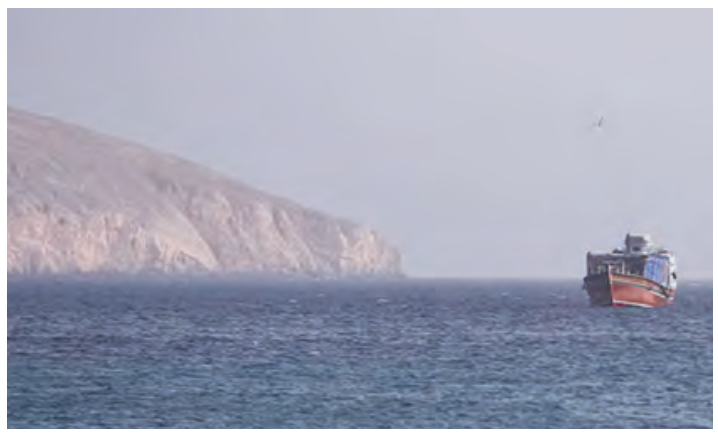
Police officer, 2 others shot

A Danish police officer and 2 other people were shot, including the suspected perpetrator, on Friday, according to media reports.
The shooting occurred in Nørresundby, in the North Jutland region in northern Denmark.

Danish broadcasters TV2 and DR quoted a police spokesperson as saying the injuries were serious. The police department's website was down on Friday in the wake of the shooting.Police received a report of a fire in an industrial area of Nørresundby at 1.39 pm and rushed to the scene, where they were met with gunshots, DR reported. Officers returned fire. Police said that the shooting was over by 3 pm , but the investigation would continue, DR reported. (*AP*)

US strikes Iran Bridges, Tehran hits Kuwait desalination plant

JON GAMBRELL ■ Dubai



The United States expanded its airstrike campaign against Iran early Friday by hitting more bridges, energy sites and collapsing a tower at a key Iranian port, backing up US President Donald Trump's threats to start striking infrastructure to pressure Tehran to ease its chokehold on the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran launched missile attacks against US-allied nations in the West Asia, including Qatar, a mediator in the war, and Kuwait, where a power and water desalination plant — vital infrastructure in the desert nation — was damaged.

The interim ceasefire agreed to last month has collapsed, and the region has endured days of back-and-forth attacks by the US and Iran as they battle for control of the strait. Iranian officials say recent US strikes have killed dozens of people and wounded hundreds of others, with new casualties reported in Friday's strikes.

When the US and Israel launched the war on Iran on February 28, Tehran effectively closed the strait to shipping traffic, a move that sent the price of oil soaring and gave Iran major leverage in negotiations.

As crossings through the strait hit a three-week low, according to an international shipping tracker, the price of oil rose above USD 86 a barrel, close to its highest level in a month. Speaking in a prime-time address to the American public on Thursday, Trump insisted the war was going well.

"We are likewise winning big in Iran, and you will see the fruits of that labour very, very shortly," Trump said.

Before the war began, the US had been in talks with Iran over its nuclear programme. Trump now faces political pressure to bring the war to a close and avoid the kind of prolonged West Asia conflict he had campaigned against. The US airstrikes hit bridges overnight into Friday in Iran's southern Hormozgan province, killing at least seven people, Iranian state television reported. The attacks hit Bandar Khamir, a city on Iran's coast on the Strait of Hormuz.

The highway and railway bridge strikes appeared aimed at cutting off Bandar Abbas, Iran's main port, from roads leading into the Islamic Republic's central region onward to Tehran, the Capital.

While other routes still are open, the US strikes could expand further, potentially disrupting both the movement of military materiel and goods needed for Iran's 90 million people.

Iran also acknowledged "attacks on power infrastructure" during the US airstrike campaign for the first time Friday when its Energy Ministry issued a call for people to use less power in southern provinces. It said those areas "are currently experiencing extreme heat and attacks on power infrastructure." The ministry did not elaborate on whether it was power plants, transmission lines or other equipment that had been attacked.

Such strikes on power infrastructure had been suspected for days. The US military's Central Command said it hit dozens of targets in its latest airstrikes, which concluded at dawn Friday, the sixth night in a row of American attacks. The strikes also collapsed a tower at Iran's Chabahar port on the Gulf of Oman, a key trade route for landlocked, neighbouring Afghanistan, the state-run IRNA news agency reported.

Chabahar port, which Iran had been running with support from India, has been a repeated target of American airstrikes. Iran described the tower as overseeing commercial traffic into the port. However, Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard also operates at ports across the country. As of 6 am Friday, the US strikes had killed at least 38 people and wounded more than 400 in Iran, Health Ministry spokesperson Hossein Kermanpour said. (*AP*)

UK: Burnham elected new Labour Party leader

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Andy Burnham was on Friday confirmed as the newly elected leader of the UK's governing Labour Party, becoming the prime minister-designate to take charge at 10 Downing Street next week.

The 56-year-old member of Parliament for Makerfield in northern England, on track to become Britain's seventh prime minister in a decade, admitted that it was the "last chance" for Labour to deliver the change promised at the last general election in July 2024.

"We are going to give people hope back," said Burnham in his first speech as party leader.

"I am ready to lead, building on the foundations laid by Keir Starmer," he said, thanking the outgoing leader for his "service to the country".

Burnham, the sole candidate in the leadership race since Starmer announced his resignation last month, vowed to "set Britain on a new path" with a less toxic political climate and a greater shift away from centralised power at Westminster in London.

"I will be a leader for every region and nation in this great country, and this party will be unashamedly Labour in our priorities and in the decisions we take," he said.

"We want to give your area more power to build the council and social homes that you desperately need, more power to improve your high street, backing local businesses such as the pubs and the shops that bring them to life... more power to re-industrialise," said in the PM-in-waiting.

In an attempt to highlight a shift in leadership priorities, the former mayor of Greater Manchester took aim at the Opposition Tories' "sweeping privatisation agenda" which began under former prime minister Margaret Thatcher as he indicated plans for greater nationalisation.

"Britain took a series of wrong turns in the 1980s. Political power was centralised and economic power was privatised," he noted.

Tanker boarded by armed group off Yemen, says British military

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

A chemical tanker was boarded by an armed group off the coast of Yemen on Friday while it was transiting in the Gulf of Aden, the British military said.

The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations Centre (UKMTO,) said military authorities had reported that the vessel was boarded by "unauthorised personnel" south of al-Mukalla province in Yemen. Ambrey, a British maritime security firm, said Somali pirates are believed to have boarded the tanker, which does not have an armed security team on board.

The firm said a Korean naval vessel was on its way to assist the tanker which issued a distress call while heading westbound. The data tracker, Maritime Traffic, showed that the Tanzania-flagged oil and chemical tanker Asana was en route to Bosaso, Somalia. Yemen's coast guard in Aden didn't immediately respond to request for comments.

It is the latest maritime attack off one of the world's poorest countries, which has been ravaged by a yearslong civil war.

Somali pirates have been active further away in the Gulf of Aden recently. Suspected pirates attacked a vessel 76 nautical miles (140 kilometers) south of the port town of Balhaf in southeastern Yemen on July 1. Four armed men on a small craft caused minor damage to the ship's bridge, according to the UKMTO. On Thursday, the European Union signed a deal with Djibouti to strengthen Red Sea naval force against the Iran-backed rebel Houthis, who have repeatedly threatened to launch attacks on vessels in the Red Sea.

Rubio to travel to Philippines next week for ASEAN meetings

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio will travel to the Philippines next week for ASEAN meetings, where he will also hold discussions with senior government officials from Indo-Pacific countries.

In a statement, State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott on Friday said that Secretary Rubio will travel to Manila, Philippines, from July 19-23 to attend the ASEAN Post-Ministerial Conference, the East Asia Summit Foreign Ministers' Meeting, and the ASEAN Regional Forum Foreign Ministers' Meeting.

The secretary of state will also meet with senior government officials from Indo-Pacific countries, he said. His visit advances a clear US priority: a free and open Indo-Pacific that delivers safety, security, and prosperity for the region and for the American people, Pigott said. "Secretary Rubio will use this trip to demonstrate the tangible results of the US-ASEAN partnership and to deepen the United States' comprehensive partnership with the Philippines," the spokesman said. Addressing an event here last month, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor announced that a meeting of the Quad foreign ministers was scheduled to take place in the Philippines.

The last Quad Foreign Ministers meeting was held in New Delhi in May. (*PTI*)

London Mayor Sadiq Khan among new UK peers

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

A leading Indian-origin academic in the field of psychiatry, Swaran Singh, and London Mayor Sadiq Khan have been conferred with peerages ahead of Keir Starmer's Downing Street exit as British prime minister next week.

Starmer, who announced his decision to step down as Labour Party leader last month, will have an audience with King Charles III on Monday to formalise his resignation and make way for Andy Burnham to take charge as the new prime minister.

As is customary, the government forwards the names for the monarch to confer political peerages as part of a resignation honours process at the departure of a prime minister.

However, Downing Street indicated that the 26 new members who will be entering the House of Lords are part of a cross-party list of nominations that was already in the works before Starmer made his resignation speech last month.

Swaran Singh, Professor of Social and Community Psychiatry at the University of Warwick; Consultant Psychiatrist, Coventry and Warwickshire Partnership NHS Trust; and former Equality and Human Rights Commissioner, is among three nominations from the Opposition Tories.

Singh, in his 60s, led the independent investigation into discrimination, including Islamophobia, within the Conservative Party, dubbed 'The Singh Investigation'.

According to his University of Warwick profile, Singh initially trained as a surgeon in New Delhi before moving to psychiatry after witnessing the effects of violent trauma on children and young people. He moved to the UK in 1991 and conducted research on ethnic influences in mental health as a lecturer and joined the University of Warwick, where he is Director of the interdisciplinary Centre for Mental Health and Wellbeing Research. (*PTI*)

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Mithilesh Tiwari D/o Daya Shankar Tiwari, R/o D-3, Shri Dhar Dham Apartment, Mehrauli, New Delhi-30, have changed my name to Mithilesh Mishra after marriage with Rakesh Mishra vide affidavitdated 11-07-2026.
PD(192)C

I, No.15442707Y NK (DVR) Devender, R/o- H.No.23 Near Bhole Timber New Indira Complex Old Faridabad, Haryana- 121002, in my service documents my Father's Name is wrongly written as Diwan Chander whereas his correct Name is Diwan Chand, which may be amended accordingly.
PD(194)C

I, Thakor Sangitaben Ranjit Sinh W/o No. 14892750N Sep Thakor Ranjitsinh Ramanbhai, R/o- Vill: Bor, Post: Bar, Teh: Virpur , Dist: Mahisagar, State: Gujarat, Pin: 388265, have changed my name from Thakor Sangitaben Ranjit Sinh to Thakor Sangitaben Ranjitsinh, vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(195)C

I, Tajuddin Gouri, Father of JC-393302P Nb Sub Raffi Shaik, R/o- VPO & Teh- Tenali, Dist- Guntur, Andhra Pradesh- 522201, have changed my name from Tajuddin Gouri to Shaik Tajuddin, vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(196)C

I, Shaik Rahamunisha, Mother of JC-393302P Nb Sub Raffi Shaik, R/o- VPO & Teh- Tenali, Dist- Guntur, Andhra Pradesh- 522201, have changed my name from Shaik Rahamunisha to Shaik Rahimunissa, vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(197)C

I, Veerathavamani P, Mother of No. 15192430H L/Hav Anbalagan P, R/o- North Street, Saluppapatti (Vill) Kudiseri (Po) Peraiyur (Teh) Madurai (Dist) Tamilnadu- 625705, have changed my name from Veerathavamani P to Veerathavamani Kumarthevar, vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(198)C

I, No.14845402F Hav Hasanuzzaman, R/o- Vill & PO- Tantibiral, Teh- Jangipur, Dist- Murshidabad, W.B.- 742235, have changed my Mother's name in my Army Service Record from Rahada Bibi to Raheda Bibi, vide affidavit dated 17/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.
PD(199)C

I, hitherto known as Ashok Kumar Mishra, S/o- Munsi Mishra, R/o- Plot No.22, Second Floor Back Side, Gali No.11, Sidhatri Enclave, Bhagwati Garden, Uttam Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi - 110059, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Ashok Mishra.
PD(200)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, (1) Dilip Kumar Poddar S/o Shri Daya Nand Poddar, (2) Asha Devi Poddar W/o Dilip Kumar Poddar, & (3) Meenu Kumari Poddar D/o Dilip Kumar Poddar, all residents of Flat No. 303, 3rd Floor, Plot No. 886, Ward No. 8, R.A.G. Residency, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030, hereby publicly disown and debar our son/ brother, **Ritik Kumar Poddar**, from all our movable and immovable properties and family affairs due to his unauthorized financial liabilities, business dealings and personal borrowings undertaken without our knowledge, consent or approval.
We shall not be responsible for any of his present or future acts, debts, liabilities or financial commitments. We have completely severed all personal, financial and family relations with him.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of **Mrs. Asha Mittal and Mrs. Sakshi Goel** who are joint owners of Entire Ground Floor (without roof/terrace rights) Part of Freehold Property built on residential Plot of land bearing No.1, area measuring 248.30 Square Yards, Block No.C-7, shown in the lay-out plan of The Mianwali District Co-operative House Building Society Limited, presently colony known as Mianwali Nagar, situated at Paschim Vihar, New Delhi-110087 vide Sale Deed bearing Document no.7766, Book no.I, Volume no.4715, pages 97 to 113, dated 11.11.2022 executed by Mr. Saurabh Nayyar as special attorney of Deepak Khanna s/o late Rajender Kumar Khanna, previouslythe subject property was owned by Mrs. Chander Khanna w/o late Rajinder Kumar Khanna and after her demise the same was owned by her sons namely (1) Mr. Naveen Khanna, (2) Mr. Praveen Khanna, (3) Mr. Deepak Khanna as per Will dated 10.01.2018 document no.110 read with Partition Deed dated 06.08.2021 document no.4298 further Mr. Deepak Khanna through his special attorney Mr. Saurabh Nayyar has sold the subject floor to Mrs. Asha Mittal and Mrs. Sakshi Goel, That **1.** Copy of Death Certificate of Mrs. Chander Khanna **2.** Copy of SMC of Late Mrs. Chander Khanna and **3.** Copy of NRI Special Power Attorney dated 04.07.2022 executed by Mr. Deepak Khanna in favour of Mr. Saurabh Nayyar has been misplaced/lost, now **Mrs. Asha Mittal and Mrs. Sakshi Goel** intend to mortgage the subject property with **Utkarsh Small Finance Bank Limited** So, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/ creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his/her objections, within **07 days** from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. **Lucem Legal LLP**
N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre,New Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

Metro Railway, Kolkata

Chief Signal & Telecom Engineer/Project, Metro Railway, Kolkata for & on behalf of The President of India invites e-Tenders against Open Tender due to open on 12.08.2026 at 15.00 hrs. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. **Name of work:** Replacement and Restoration of TETRA System for Green, Purple & Orange Lines, Metro Railway, Kolkata. **Tender Value (Rs.)** : ₹ 2,70,54,491. **Earnest Money (Rs.):** ₹ 5,41,100. **Completion Period** : 36 Months. The Tender can be viewed at website: **https://www.ireps.gov.in** The tenderer/bidders must have Class-III Digital Signature Certificate & must be registered on IREPS Portal. Only registered tenderer/bidders can participate on e-tendering. All relevant papers must be uploaded at the time of participating in e-Tender
Tender Notice No.: S&T/Work_18-2026
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GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER :: P.W.D :: BUILDING
ASSAM::CHANDMARI::GUWAHATI-3

No.CE/TB-III(B)/85/2024/Pt/ 11

PRESS NOTICE Re- INVITING TENDER

In cancelling the earlier Press notice No: **CE/TB-III(B)/85/2024/Pt/07** dtd. **30-06-2026** due to technical norms, The Chief Engineer, P.W.D. (Building), Assam, on behalf of the Governor of Assam has re- invites Bids for Technical & Financial offer as per **Request for Proposal** from qualified and experienced firms (Criteria as per in RFP document) for the work **"Facility Management of Jyoti Bishnu Antarjatik Kalamandir at Khanapara, Guwahati including operations, Comprehensive, Maintenance, security and housekeeping for a period of 5 (Five) years."** Approx. Value of the project Rs. 54,26,24,800.00

- The details may be seen in e-procurement portal website i.e. **www.assamtenders.gov.in.**
- Work will be allotted after receiving of Administrative Approval from Govt.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, P.W.D (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-03
DIPR/C/PIO/109/18-Jul-26

कार्यालय अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, रूहेलखण्ड वृत्त, उ0प्र0 आवास एवं विकास परिषद, मुरादाबाद

पत्रांक : 1326 /एम-15ए/ 86 दिनांक : 16.07.2026

ई-कोटेशन आमन्त्रण सूचना विज्ञप्ति

उ0प्र0 आवास एवं विकास परिषद की ओर से इस कार्यालय के ई-कोटेशन आमंत्रण सूचना सं0-1292/एम-15ए/84 दिनांक 14.07.2026 द्वारा प्रतिष्ठित उत्पादकों/अधिकृत डीलर/डिस्ट्रीब्यूटर से रुहेलखण्ड वृत्त, मुरादाबाद के अधीन खण्ड कार्यालयों में प्रयोग हेतु सामग्री की आपूर्ति हेतु दिनांक 28.07.2026 अपरान्ह 03:00 बजे तक ई-कोटेशन के अन्तर्गत कोटेशन वेबसाइट https://etender.up.nic.in के माध्यम से कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, निर्माण खण्ड, रूहेलखण्ड-03, उ0प्र0 आवास एवं विकास परिषद, मुरादाबाद में आमंत्रित की जाती हैं :-
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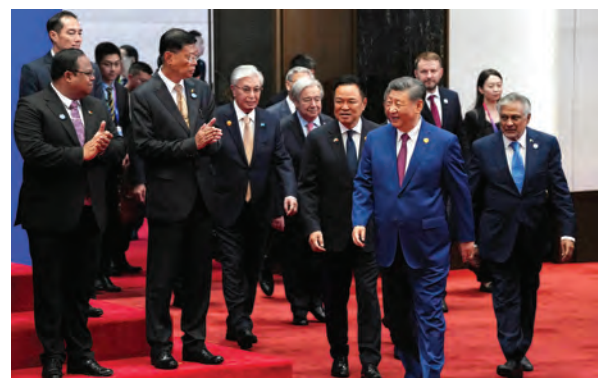
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता

AI should not be solo performance but symphony of global collaboration: Xi

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing/Shanghai



President Xi Jinping arriving for a group photo with other attendees before the opening ceremony for the World AI Conference in Shanghai AP

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Friday said the development of AI should not be a "solo performance" by one country, but a "symphony of global collaboration".

Xi made these remarks while addressing the opening of the 2026 World Artificial Intelligence Conference (WAIC), China's largest annual AI industry event, in Shanghai.

"With AI advancing at a staggering speed, we must ensure its development is positive, for the good and for humanity," he said. "We human beings must answer the questions posed by our times: How to get along with thinking machines? How to ensure security when an algorithm is part of decision making? How to tackle ethical challenges by technologies through adaptive governance? How to realise AI for all when the divide keeps widening? These questions demand serious consideration and real answers from the whole international community," he said.

China wants all countries to take a people-centric approach and develop AI.

"We should ensure that AI is an important driver for shared prosperity and common security. We should join hands to build a just and equitable system for global AI governance," he said. To further support AI development in the next five years, he said China will provide developing countries, including members of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, the Arab League, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the African Union, Latin American and the BRICS member countries with 5,000 research projects in AI, as well as training. Earlier, 29 countries signed an agreement in Shanghai to establish the World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organisation (WAICO). Representatives from the 29 countries, including Kazakhstan, Laos, Pakistan, Russia and Indonesia, besides China, signed the agreement, making their countries the WAICO's founding members.

The United Nations Secretary-General, Antonio Guterres, was also among representatives from countries and international organisations present at the signing ceremony.

The organisation will uphold the purposes of the UN Charter, be committed to extensive consultation and joint contribution for shared benefit and adhere to a people-centred approach, according to the agreement, Xinhua report said.

In recent years, China has made big strides in several frontier technologies, artificial intelligence (AI), electric vehicles (EVs), and battery technology, aided by the massive state support, a huge domestic market, strong manufacturing capabilities, and a large pool of engineers. (*PTI*)

Landslide in China kills eight, leaves 34 missing

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

A landslide Friday in the southwestern Chinese city of Chongqing killed eight people and left 34 missing, burying residential buildings and forcing more than 1,100 people to evacuate, State media reported.

Ten people were rescued from the debris, among them two seriously injured, the State-run Xinhua News Agency reported.

The landslide occurred at around 9.08 am in Chongqing's Pengshui County, when massive amounts of rocks and soil washed downslope, burying more than 10 residential buildings, state broadcaster CCTV said.

Water, electricity and gas supplies were cut off within a 1-km radius of the landslide to prevent further disruptions. Over 800 rescuers were on the site. Images by CCTV showed part of a mountainside collapsing onto a residential area. Several buildings were located next to the collapse site, while rescue crews combed through the debris. Rescue efforts were hindered by the unstable terrain and the risk of another landslide, according to the broadcaster.

Rescuers conduct search and rescue operation on the site of the landslide in Pengshui County in southwestern China's Chongqing on Friday PTI

Images shared on social media showed orange-clad rescuers using excavators to dig through the rubble. At one point, a team of rescuers pulled a survivor out of the debris. Large slabs of rock had slid beside buildings into a waterway below. Two buildings were damaged but still standing.

The rain-triggered landslide occurred near a section of the Wujiang River, which cuts through karst mountains peppered with small towns and terraces.

China rejects Trump's election meddling claims as smear

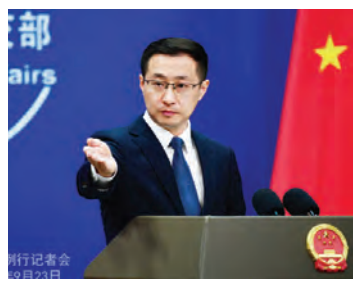
KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

China on Friday hit back at Donald Trump for accusing Beijing of meddling in American elections, dismissing the US President's claims as fabricated and a malicious smear and urging him to stop making baseless allegations.

China has always upheld the principle of non-interference in other countries' internal affairs and has neither any interest in nor ever interfered in US elections, Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian told a media briefing while answering a question on Trump's allegations.

In contrast, the international community knows full well who habitually interferes in other countries' internal affairs, indiscriminately conducts long-term surveillance of Governments, businesses and ordinary citizens around the world, and steals foreign citizens' data on a massive scale, Lin said.

"We urge the US side to reflect on its own conduct, stop making baseless accusations against China, refrain from using China as an election issue, and do more to promote China-US relations," Lin said. Asked whether Trump's allegations against China would affect Chinese President Xi Jinping's plans to visit the US in September, Lin said, "We urge the US to stop making an issue of China in its elections and do something conducive to China-US relations".



Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian

Trump visited China in May and held talks with Xi, following which the Chinese President said both sides reached important common understandings on maintaining stable economic and trade ties, expanding practical cooperation in various fields. (*PTI*)

Oli slams PM Balendra Shah over alleged fascist drift

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal's former premier KP Sharma Oli on Friday criticised Prime Minister Balendra Shah for trying to suppress youth-led protests while accusing his Government of heading towards "Fascism."

Hundreds of Nepalese youth staged a demonstration in Kathmandu last week protesting the Government's move to evict landless squatters without providing an alternative resettlement arrangement.

"The Government doesn't even tolerate if some youths stage a protest on the street," Oli said at the launch of the new edition of the CPN-UML's website and apps at the party's central office at Chyasal in Lalitpur district."A youth activist was badly beaten by the police and then put under detention just because he went to see the conditions of the evicted squatters in one of the holding centres in Kathmandu," Oli pointed out.

He was talking about an incident of police baton charging youth who tried to visit a Government holding centre in Kathmandu's Kirtipur, where around 150 squatters were living.

The centre was hit by floods and its inhabitants had to be evacuated with the help of security personnel. Later, police arrested 26 people who staged a sit-in at the main gate of Morang District Police office in the Koshi province on Sunday as they protested the mistreatment of the Gen Z activists by the police. (*PTI*)

Russian strikes kill 4 in Ukraine as Zelenskyy's defence shake-up sparks anger

ILLIA NOVIKOV ■ Kyiv

Russian attacks on Ukraine overnight killed at least four civilians and wounded 20 other people, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, as he faces a political crisis after firing his popular defence minister.

Zelenskyy's major reshuffle of his Government on Thursday, which included the appointment of a new prime minister, unsettled the country's military leadership and trigged a public outcry. It was an unwelcome difficulty after Ukraine has gained traction in its fight against Russia's more than 4-year-old invasion.

The surprise departure from the defence ministry of Mykhailo Fedorov, a youthful and popular member of the Government, saw thousands of people demonstrate against his dismissal in cities across Ukraine on Thursday. Further street protests were expected on Friday.

Fedorov, 35, who was in the post for just six months, is widely seen as the driving force behind Ukraine's swift and successful technological innovation and other measures, such as fighting military corruption, that have brought fresh hope in the war for Ukrainians.

Relations between Fedorov and Gen Oleksandr Syrskyi, the commander of Ukraine's armed forces who started his military career in the former Soviet Union, had broken down, according to Zelenskyy, and made Fedorov's position untenable. Zelenskyy said he had asked Maj Gen Yevhen Khmara, acting head of the state's security service and a highly regarded special operations expert, to take over the defence minister's duties.

Zelenskyy said late Thursday he would ask Parliament to formally approve Khmara's appointment as defence minister, as required by law. That step could be held up by bureaucratic hurdles, however.

Ukrainian law requires the defence minister to be a civilian, so a serving soldier or security service officer must leave active service before being formally appointed. Also, lawmakers will be on summer recess through mid-August.

Khmara has been in charge of the SBU security service since January. He had previously led the SBU's elite Alpha special forces unit and is known for being an architect of Operation Spiderweb, one of Ukraine's most spectacular attacks when it struck Russian air bases last year. (*AP*)

Sri Lanka's former police chief allegedly commits suicide

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Sri Lanka's former police chief, who served between 2020 and 2023, has allegedly committed suicide on Friday, according to police.

Chandana Wickremaratna, the former inspector general of police, has committed suicide by shooting himself, police spokesman FT Wootler said here on Friday.

Wickremaratna used a personal weapon to kill himself around 7.30 this morning at Athurugiriya, an eastern suburb of the capital Colombo, he said. Wickremaratna, 63, was police chief between 2020 and 2023. From 2019, he had acted as the acting police chief. The reasons for his suicide have not been made public yet. He was declared dead when brought to the hospital. Two police teams have been deployed to carry out investigations, Wootler said.

Pakistan China discuss AI, trade in Shanghai

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar on Friday held talks with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi on ways to advance ties in trade, investment, digital economy and Artificial Intelligence (AI).

The two leaders met on the sidelines of the World Artificial Intelligence Conference in Shanghai.

They "reviewed the broad canvas of Pakistan-China bilateral relations and reaffirmed their shared commitment to further deepening the all-weather strategic cooperative partnership," Radio Pakistan reported.

They underscored the importance of advancing CPEC 2.0 — the upgraded second phase of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor - and enhancing collaboration in trade, investment, science and technology, the digital economy and artificial intelligence, the report said.

The two sides also exchanged views on the latest regional and global developments and reaffirmed their resolve to coordinate on issues of mutual interest, it said.

On Thursday, Dar, who is also the deputy prime Minister of Pakistan, signed an agreement in Shanghai to establish the World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organisation (WAICO).

"Pakistan looks forward to working closely with fellow WAICO member States in efforts to help bridge the global AI divide and to promote equitable access to AI to advance development for all," Pakistan's Foreign Office said in a statement on X. As many as 29 countries - including China, Russia, Pakistan, Kazakhstan, Laos and Indonesia — have signed the agreement to establish WAICO. It is supposed to be an independent inter Governmental organisation headquartered in Shanghai, which will uphold the purposes of the UN Charter, be committed to consultation and joint contribution for shared benefit and adhere to a people-centred approach, China's State-owned Xinhua news agency reported.

Pakistan has reaffirmed its commitment to advancing international cooperation in artificial intelligence, particularly from the perspective of the Global South, its Foreign Office said. (*PTI*)

24 terrorists killed in operations in Pakistan's KPK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Twenty-four terrorists were killed during a series of intelligence-based operations in Pakistan's Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, the army said on Friday.

The operations were launched in and around the restive Bannu district over the last 24 hours, the military's media wing said in a statement.

It said 24 terrorists were killed during the operations, and a cache of weapons and ammunition was recovered from them.

The slain terrorists were involved in multiple terrorist activities and the killing of civilians, the statement said.

Meanwhile, President Asif Ali Zardari lauded the security forces for the "successful operations", according to a statement issued by his office.

Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi also praised the security forces for the operations. According to a statement issued by the Interior Ministry, Naqvi described the intelligence-based operations as essential for restoring peace and stability in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and termed the security personnel "our true heroes".

20 children, 1 adult killed in Uganda elementary school bus crash

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kampala

An elementary school bus carrying pupils back from an educational tour to a scenic waterfall in Uganda veered off the road and overturned, killing at least 20 children and one adult, police said on Friday.

The bus crashed Thursday night in the Kapchorwa District in eastern Uganda while returning from a visit to the region's Sipi Falls, the Uganda Police Force said in a statement posted on X.

Survivors including three adults and several children were taken to several hospitals, according to police, who did not immediately give an exact number of people who were injured.

At least nine children were hospitalised in critical condition, while the adult who died appeared to be the founder and head of the school, Ugandan Minister of Local Government Balaam Ateenyi said on X. Residents of the village where the crash occurred acted as first responders and helped transport injured children to hospitals while trying to save some victims, Barugahara said. The bus belonged to the King David Junior School, an elementary school situated in the capital Kampala, police said.

The driver reportedly lost control of the bus, which veered off the road, struck a rock and overturned, according to the police statement, which added that the information was preliminary and the cause of the crash was under investigation.

A police photo showed the bus lying on its side with the entire roof ripped off and the seats exposed, including some that were mangled. Luggage and clothing lay strewn on the road. Road accidents are common in Uganda and often are blamed on poorly maintained vehicles, speeding and poor road conditions, which are problems across Africa.

Africa has the worst road safety record in the world, with more than 300,000 annual road deaths and around 26 deaths per 100,000 people.

In Europe, which has far more road traffic, there are around 20,000 deaths yearly and nine deaths per 100,000 people, according to the World Health Organisation and the United Nations. (*AP*)

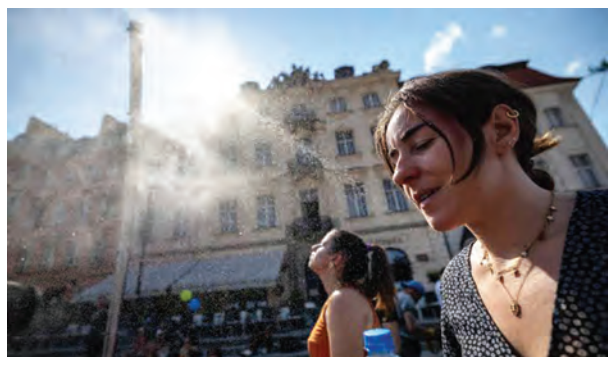
Europe's early heatwave linked to over 10,000 excess deaths

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

Heat that hit Europe exceptionally early and hard this year appears to have led to a spike in deaths, with well over 10,000 more people dying at the height of the heat wave than would normally have been expected, according to figures that are still emerging across the continent.

Measures of what researchers call "excess mortality" — the difference between the normally expected number of deaths and the actual number - spiked in late June, when parts of Europe experienced record temperatures.

Experts caution that it takes a while for a full picture to emerge, and that many heat-related deaths will never formally be recorded as such. For example, a heart attack, which can be triggered by extreme heat exposure, especially in people who are older or have underlying health issues, may be listed on a death certificate simply as a heart attack.



It's an alarming start to the summer. Several heat waves have killed thousands of people in the past few years in Europe. Still, 2003 stands as the deadliest year in Europe for heat, with about 70,000 deaths. The frequency and intensity of heat waves are supercharged by climate change, which comes from the burning of fuels like coal, oil and gas.

The EuroMOMO mortality monitoring hub, which receives data from two dozen countries, gave an estimate of 14,260 for excess mortality from all causes in the week ending June 28, more than 12,000 of those deaths being among people age 65 and older. That's out of a total 84,583 deaths that week. Figures in the preceding and following weeks were far lower.

Lasse Vestergaard of Denmark's Statens Serum Institut, which coordinates EuroMOMO, said that "we attribute this to the heat wave affecting quite a lot of countries in Europe, and we do that because there is no other obvious explanation that could explain such a high excess mortality happening at the moment."

Such a high excess in a single week is "highly unusual," he added. EuroMOMO doesn't give absolute numbers for individual countries, but found the highest rates of excess in France, Belgium and Germany.

Nations that bore the brunt of the heat have issued their own estimates - which don't always follow the same methodology or timelines. Here is a snapshot of heat-related deaths being reported by various countries.

Germany's disease control center, the Robert Koch Institute, directly attributed 6,830 deaths to heat this year through early July, 6,470 of them among people 65 and older. Temperatures in Germany late last month hit their highest levels since records began, peaking with a measurement of 41.7 degrees Celsius (107.06 Fahrenheit) on June 28, according to the German Weather Service.

Gangster Nitish held in Vermont: FBI

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

The FBI has arrested gangster Nitish Kaushal, allegedly involved in murder, kidnapping and drug trafficking in the US, days after adding him to its list of most wanted criminals. "Nitish Kaushal has been arrested in Vermont," the FBI said in a post on X .

Kaushal, an Indian national, allegedly carried out acts of violence on behalf of the Bhagwanpuria organised crime group, including, but not limited to, kidnappings and assaults, the FBI said.

The FBI had added Kaushal to its most wanted list . The FBI was on the lookout for Kaushal for his alleged involvement with a transnational criminal organisation engaged in, among other things, acts involving murder, kidnapping, drug trafficking, extortion, weapons trafficking, money laundering, and human smuggling.

It said the Jaggu Bhagwanpuria Organised Crime Group originated in the Punjab state of India and operated in the Central District of California and elsewhere.

The US District Court of the Central District of California, Los Angeles, issued a federal arrest warrant for Kaushal on June 25 after charging him with racketeer influenced and corrupt organisations conspiracy. The FBI action followed Operation Hard Ball, a coordinated international enforcement action targeting the Bhagwanpuria gang.

The operation involved raids and law enforcement action across the US, Canada, and Europe, highlighting the growing international focus on dismantling transnational criminal syndicates with roots in India. (*PTI*)

PROSPECT

Lt General Neeraj Shukla, GOC, 4 Corps, Indian Army, called upon CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at Lok Sewa Bhawan, Dispur PIONEER PHOTO

GAIL, KABIL sign pact for critical minerals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

GAIL (India) Limited signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) on Friday to collaborate in the field of critical and strategic minerals, supporting India's long-term resource security.

The MoU has been signed by Sanjeev Kumar, Executive Director (R&D & E&P), GAIL, and Sunil Kumar Singh, Chief Executive Officer, KABIL, in the presence of RK Singhal, Director (Business Development), GAIL, and other senior officials from both organisations.

The partnership provides a framework for cooperation in identifying and evaluating opportunities in critical and strategic minerals, facilitating the exchange of technical expertise, capacity building, and exploring joint initiatives across the mining value chain to help strengthen India's long-term supply of these vital resources and clean energy transition.

About GAIL (India) Limited

GAIL (India) Limited, India's integrated energy major, is a Maharatna Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas. GAIL has a diversified presence across the entire natural gas value chain, including natural gas transmission and marketing, LNG sourcing and regasification, LPG transmission, petrochemicals, city gas distribution, renewable energy, and upstream exploration & production.

About Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL)

Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) is a joint venture of three Central Public Sector Enterprises-National Aluminium Company Limited (NALCO), Hindustan Copper Limited (HCL), and Mineral Exploration & Consultancy Limited (MECL).

KABIL was established to identify, acquire, develop, and secure overseas critical and strategic mineral assets to support India's long-term economic growth, industrial development, and energy transition.

Military veterans empowered through entrepreneurship workshop

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Military veterans explored new pathways to self-employment and business success during an entrepreneurship workshop organised by NER Chapter PHDCCI.

The workshop aimed to equip veterans with the knowledge, skills and confidence to transition from military service to entrepreneurship. Sessions covered business planning, financial management, access to government schemes, marketing strategies, digital business opportunities and startup funding. Participants also interacted with successful entrepreneurs and industry experts, who shared practical insights and experiences.

Addressing the participants, AVM Sanjib Bordoloi, AVSM (Retd), emphasised that the leadership, discipline, resilience and problem-solving abilities developed during military service provide veterans with a strong foundation for entrepreneurial success. The speaker encouraged participants to leverage these strengths to create sustainable enterprises and contribute to local economic development.

Representatives from NER Chapter PHDCCI, Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI), MSME Development & Facilitation Office, Guwahati, and The National Small Industries Corporation Ltd (NSIC) highlighted the various support mechanisms available to ex-servicemen, including training, mentoring, financial assistance and networking opportunities to help establish and grow their businesses. The workshop witnessed enthusiastic participation from more than 100 military veterans, who engaged actively in interactive sessions, discussions and networking opportunities. Participants appreciated the practical guidance provided and expressed confidence in applying the knowledge gained to pursue entrepreneurial ventures.

The event concluded with a vote of thanks, reaffirming the organiser's commitment to supporting military veterans in achieving economic self-reliance through entrepreneurship.

REC Limited signs MoA to establish 20 smart classrooms in West Bengal Govt schools

REC Limited, a Maharatna CPSE under the Ministry of Power and a leading NBFC, has signed a Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) with Career Forum for the implementation of a Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) project titled "Establishment of 20 Smart Classrooms in Government Schools of Alipurduar, West Bengal."

The MoA was signed on July 14, 2026, by Arun Kumar Tyagi, Executive Director (CSR), REC Limited, and Anant Chauhan, Chairman, Career Forum, in the presence of LB Nautiyal, HoD (CSR), REC Limited, along with other senior officials of REC Limited.

Under this CSR initiative, 20 smart classrooms will be established in Government schools across the Alipurduar district of West Bengal. The project is expected to benefit more than 1,500 students by providing access to technology-enabled, interactive learning tools that foster greater classroom engagement and improve learning outcomes. The initiative is aimed at strengthening digital education infrastructure in rural and tribal areas of West Bengal by integrating modern teaching technologies into government schools. It reflects REC Limited's continued commitment to bridging the digital divide, promoting inclusive education, and empowering students with access to quality, technology-driven learning opportunities. (*PNS*)

APL: Dibrugarh Warriors announces singer Neel Akash as brand ambassador

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Dibrugarh Warriors franchise of the Assam Premier League (APL) has officially announced Assam's singing sensation Neel Akash as its brand ambassador.

Alongside this premier signing, the franchise launched its high-energy official anthem song. Designed to capture the resilient spirit of Upper Assam, this powerful anthem is set to rally fans and electrify stadiums across the state. On the occasion, the franchises also felicitated their official advisor Bhaskar Papukon Gogoi, who is the current vice president of the Dibrugarh District Sports Association.

To lead their debut campaign, the Dibrugarh Warriors introduced their powerhouse coaching and support staff. The team will be spearheaded by head coach and former cricketer of Assam Dhiraj Goswami, supported by assistant coach Nilesh Sharma. Former first-class cricketer Sujay Tarafdar is the bowling coach, while Bhargav Sarma takes charge of strength and conditioning coaching, among others.

"We are incredibly thrilled to finally step into the Assam Premier League arena, an initiative we believe will completely revolutionise the regional sporting landscape," stated the franchise management.

"The APL is the perfect launchpad to uncover raw, homegrown talent and elevate Assam's cricketing stature to new heights.

By bringing the phenomenal Neel Akash on board, launching an anthem that echoes the true spirit of Upper Assam and uniting an elite coaching staff, we are building something truly special. The Warriors are fully geared up, deeply motivated and ready to deliver a thrilling brand of cricket that will make our fans proud," added the owner of the franchise, Arun Kumar Rai.

VIT-AP University hosts IC4AI-2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Amaravati

VIT-AP University successfully inaugurated the 1st International Conference on Advances in Architectures, Algorithms & Applications for Artificial Intelligence (IC4AI-2026) at its Amaravati campus. The conference brought together renowned academicians, researchers, industry experts, and students from across the globe to deliberate on the latest developments in artificial intelligence and its multidisciplinary applications.

The inaugural ceremony commenced with a warm welcome address by Prof S Sudhakar Ilango, convenor of IC4AI-2026 and dean, School of Computer Science and Engineering (SCOPE), VIT-AP University. In his address, he welcomed the distinguished guests, delegates, researchers, faculty members, and students, highlighting the importance of collaborative research and innovation in shaping the future of AI.

The event was graced by Prof Bidyadhar Subudhi, Director, NIT Warangal, as the guest of honour. He emphasised the growing significance of artificial intelligence in addressing real-world challenges and encouraged young researchers to focus on impactful, interdisciplinary research that contributes to society.

Another guest of honour, Rajiv Sharma, founder and CEO of AgVysor Innovations LLP, shared valuable insights on the role of AI in transforming agriculture and industry. He highlighted how emerging technologies can bridge the gap between academic research and industrial applications, fostering innovation and entrepreneurship.

Addressing the gathering, Prof P Arulmozhivarman, Vice Chancellor of VIT-AP University, reiterated the university's commitment to excellence in research, innovation, and global collaboration. He appreciated the efforts of the organising committee in bringing together eminent researchers and industry leaders on a common platform to discuss emerging AI technologies.

The Chief Guest, Dr Rajkumar ER, Enterprise Tech Architect, Vice President/Senior Manager — Industry X, Supply Chain Engineering, Accenture, Bengaluru, delivered an inspiring keynote emphasising the transformative role of artificial intelligence in digital enterprises, intelligent manufacturing, and next-generation supply chain engineering.

He encouraged participants to develop AI solutions that are ethical, scalable, and socially responsible.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★☆

	9			6	7			8
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HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction-no maths involved.

SOLUTION (17.7.26)

1	7	8	2	5	6	4	9	3
9	3	5	4	7	1	2	8	6
2	6	4	3	8	9	1	7	5
4	8	3	9	2	5	6	1	7
6	9	7	8	1	4	3	5	2
5	1	2	7	6	3	9	4	8
7	4	6	1	3	8	5	2	9
3	2	9	5	4	7	8	6	1
8	5	1	6	9	2	7	3	4

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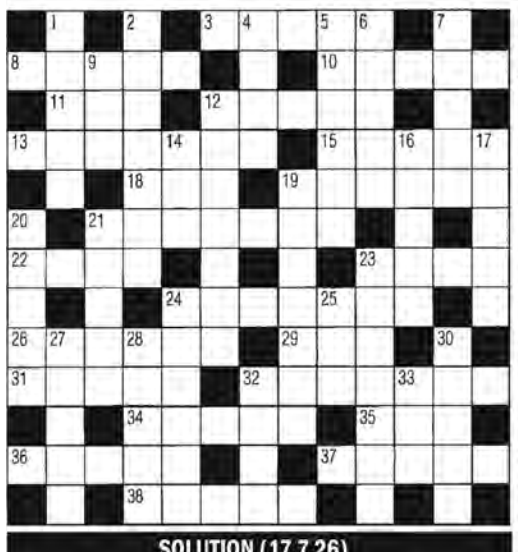
DOUBLE CROSSWORD
SATURDAY | JULY 18, 2026



ACROSS
3 Raise one amid many (5)
8 Rose and dressed (3,2)
10 Should be a bit of a rough time (5)
11 He may well be suspended (3)
12 One heartens a poet to become an inventor (5)
13 Move coal out of a mine to somewhere important (7)
15 Terry may describe it (5)
18 Retiring to copy a piece of poetry out (3)
19 This villain is angry, on the quiet! (6)
21 Immediately present, but without a place (7)
22 Do evening work at the laundry (4)
23 Make steady progress with an old composition for piano (4)
24 Properly suited to audio use? (7)
26 Boxed up and carted around (6)
29 A sound line from the prompter (3)
31 Hellish exclamation by little Desmond (5)
32 Carries around for sale (on a bike?) (7)
34 Capital place to get plastered? (5)
35 Augustinian's familiar name (3)
36 Figures out points of material significance (5)
37 Some doctors consume it (5)
38 The look of an old Indian Army man? (5)

DOWN
1 Not yet having taken a knock (2,3)
2 If you polish up a dud coin, it's the point of no return! (7)
4 Where to egg on the Surrey team (4)
5 The kind, that is, for outgoing soldiers (6)
6 Historic tour roaming around the capital of Denmark (5)
7 These may be used to make paper (5)
9 To finish up best (3)
12 You've had it, man! (7)
14 Pull a shirt tail with a loud cry (3)
16 Woolly headed friend, nominally? (5)
17 At extremities, money one doesn't borrow! (5)
19 Leaps and capers wildly around a pole (7)
20 The dog breeder's complaint? (5)
21 Person of no fixed address (5)
23 Left with uncle, as promised (7)
24 For me, wild seas can have magic significance (6)
25 It's no good turning up another time (3)
27 Can you win them if you have the right cards? (5)
28 Warm as the water when the tide changes around Peterhead
30 With which to start brushing some scattered leaves? (5)
32 Sort of gin with which to fix a cocktail! (4)
33 Courtly lord (3)

SOLUTION (17.7.26)

ACROSS
1. Trial
6. Spock
9. Martial
10. Salad
11. Ma-rr-y
12. Happ-y
13. Colonel
15. Pea
17. Anon
18. Ceral-d
19. Stirs
20. Clutch
22. Me-re
24. Ham
25. Pa-role-d
26. Treat
27. Droo-p
28. BA's-in
29. General
30. C-le-ar
31. Reins

DOWN
2. Reason
3. Amazon
4. Lad
5. Steal
6. S-amp-les
7. Play
8. Ca-R-mel
12. Heath
13. Catch
14. Locum
15. Panel
16. Added
18. Great
19. Scarper
21. Laurel
22. Mor-al-e
23. Region
25. Pared
26. To-ga
28. Bar

Plantation drive conducted in Ecotech-3 industrial sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Greater Noida

As part of the *Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam* campaign, a roadside plantation drive was conducted on Friday in the Ecotech-3 industrial sector by the Greater Noida Authority and the Industrial Business Association.

Greater Noida Authority ACEO Saumya Srivastava planted saplings alongside his wife, Surbhi Srivastava. Along with them, ACEO Srilakshmi VS, ACEO Sumit Yadav, OSD Archana Dwivedi, DGM (Horticulture) SK Jain, and Senior Manager Ajit Bhai Patel also planted saplings. Saplings of Peepal, Neem, and Amaltas were planted.

ACEO Saumya Srivastava appealed to all residents of Greater Noida to participate in this massive plantation drive and to plant and nurture at least one sapling. Present on the occasion were Manager Prashant Samadhiya and Assistant Manager Gaurav Baghel, along with Industrial Business Association President Amit Upadhyay, Vice President Dr Khushbu Singh, Sunil Dutt, Rakesh Agarwal, Naresh Chauhan, SK Sharma, Sudhir Tyagi, and other office-bearers of the association.

'Early financial planning gives children freedom to choose their future'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rajiv Shrivastava

Every child dreams of building a successful future, whether through higher education, entrepreneurship or pursuing a passion.

According to Rajiv Shrivastava, Zonal Director – West, SBI Life Insurance, parents can help turn these aspirations into reality by starting financial planning early.

He said that many key milestones in a child's life, such as higher education and career choices, require long-term financial preparation. Starting early allows parents to gradually build a meaningful corpus through disciplined savings, manage future financial commitments more comfortably and prepare for important life goals with greater confidence.

Shrivastava added that a child insurance plan can support long-term goal-based financial planning by combining savings with financial protection. Depending on the plan, parents may benefit from guaranteed maturity benefits, waiver of premium in case of unforeseen events, continuation of the policy and flexible payout options aligned with future financial needs.

He advised parents to assess the milestones they want to prepare for, the time available to achieve them and the financial corpus required to support their child's aspirations.

कार्यालय कार्यपालन यंत्री, नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन
चतुर्थ निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्यों हेतु ऑन लाईन निविदाओं का आमंत्रण केंद्रीकृत प्रणाली में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निम्नानुसार नगरीय प्रशासन एवं विकास विभाग द्वारा जारी एस.ओ.आर. दिनांक 02.08.2021 से लगसम आधार पर किया जाता है।

नि.स.क्रं.	कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की अनु. लागत	प्रतिभूति राशि	ऑन लाईन निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य	समया वाधि	निविदा क्रय एवं दर प्रस्तुत करने की अंतिम तिथि
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निविदा संबंधित अन्य विवरण एवं विस्तृत निविदा सूचना की जानकारी वेब साइट **https://mptenders.gov.in** पर ऑन लाईन दर्शाई गई है।

कार्यपालन यंत्री
अमृत
नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन

आयुक्त
नगर पालिक निगम उज्जैन

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | JULY 18, 2026

BRIEFLY

Argentine President won't attend World Cup final

Argentine President Javier Milei said on Thursday he won't be attending the World Cup final because of superstition, instead choosing to view Sunday's match between Spain and Argentina from home – where he has watched the defending champion's previous seven games, all victories, in the tournament.

In a bid to help his nation's beloved soccer team secure its second consecutive title, Milei added, he'll be wearing the same heavy jacket, too. Fans and players around the world cling to superstitions they believe can bring good luck to their team – or misfortune to their opponents. But in Latin America, and particularly in Argentina, so-called "cabalas," or ritualistic beliefs and habits, carry unusual weight, reflecting the intensity with which many here watch their national team. (*AP*)

Merlier wins crash-marred 12th stage of Tour de France

Belgian rider Tim Merlier earned another stage win at the Tour de France while several riders fell as they sprinted to the line on Thursday. Defending champion Tadej Pogacar avoided the crash and kept his significant overall lead over second-place Jonas Vingegaard after 12 stages.

It was Merlier's third stage win on this year's Tour and sixth of his career. Dutch rider Olav Kooij finished second and Jasper Philipsen of Belgium was third.

With riders fighting for position on the home straight, Colombian Fernando Gaviria went down after clipping the wheel of another cyclist and fell to his left, bringing Norwegian rider Soeren Waerenskjold – Wednesday's stage winner – down with him. (*AP*)

Pele's jersey from 1958 WC final fetches $4.9M at auction

A Number 10 jersey worn by Brazil icon Pele in the 1958 World Cup final has been sold for $4.9 million, Sotheby's said on Thursday.

Pele, who died in 2022, was 17 when he scored twice in Brazil's 5-2 win over hosts Sweden at the Rasunda Stadium and still remains the youngest player ever to score in a World Cup final.

Sotheby's said the jersey worn by the Brazilian star is the second-most valuable soccer shirt ever sold. Diego Maradona's "Hand of God" jersey sold in 2022 for $9.3 million.

The previous most valuable item of Pele memorabilia was $976,000 for a 1958 trading card last month, the auction house said. (*AP*)

Messi has a message for WC critics of Argentina: Nothing was handed to us

DEBORA REY/LUIS ANDRES HENAO
Atlanta (US)

Lionel Messi has a message for Argentina's detractors: "Nothing was handed to us."

The Argentina superstar responded to critics who have been bashing the reigning World Cup champions over perceptions of beneficial officiating and favoritism by the soccer establishment. He said the team's ability to overturn late-game deficits, most recently the semi-final victory over England, is the result of championship pedigree and nothing more.

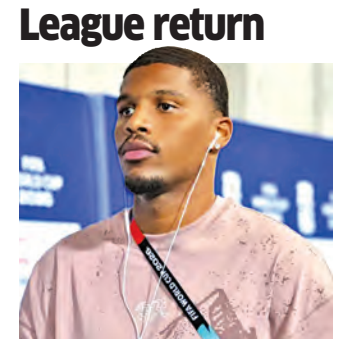
After trailing 1-0 going into the 85th minute, Argentina rallied for a 2-1 win over England on Wednesday to reach the World Cup final. The victory led tens of thousands to flood the streets of Buenos Aires in ecstatic celebrations, and marked another remarkable comeback that showed the perseverance of a team that is now one win from a back-to-back titles. Argentina faces Spain in Sunday's final.

Argentina earlier survived by beating Cape Verde and Switzerland in extra time, and rallied for an improbable 3-2 victory over Egypt after coming back from being down 2-0 with 11 minutes of regulation time to play. But both the Swiss and Egyptian coaches criticised the refereeing. Egypt's Hossam Hassan went as far as to say that his team was the victim of a soccer establishment that favored Messi and Argentina.

The comments fueled criticism sparked by fans who argue that the FIFA bracket favored La Albiceleste, and unfounded allegations on social media claiming that the soccer governing body wants Argentina to once again become World Cup champion.

"We've been the best over these past four years, either you like it or not, and no matter what anyone says," Messi said after the win over England. "Once again, we've established ourselves among the top two teams in the world. That proves that everything we've done is no fluke and that nothing was handed to us." (*AP*)

Aurele Amenda joins Coventry for club's Premier League return



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Coventry (England)

Switzerland defender Aurele Amenda came home from the World Cup to sign for newly promoted Premier League club Coventry. Coventry said the 22-year-old Amenda signed a four-year contract without stating the transfer fee paid to Eintracht Frankfurt, which was reportedly 18 million euros ($20.6 million).

Amenda has played seven times for Switzerland though did not get called from the bench during the team's impressive run to the World Cup quarterfinals. Switzerland lost to Argentina 3-1 after extra time.

Amenda helped Young Boys win Swiss league titles in 2023 and '24 before moving to Frankfurt, where he played in five Champions League games last season.

NZ beats West Indies by 6 wickets in 3rd ODI to take 2-1 series lead

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Providence (Guyana)

West Indies collapsed from 67-1 to be all out for 140, handing New Zealand a six-wicket win in the third one-day cricket international Thursday and a 2-1 lead in the five-match series.

The collapse mirrored that of the second match in which the West Indies fell from 63-0 to 138 all out as New Zealand won by five wickets, leveling the series after losing the first match by seven wickets.

New Zealand's run chase was cautiously paced at 3.5 runs per over and ended in the 40th over at 141-4, with 63 balls remaining. Henry Nicholls made 24 and Will Young 23 in a solid partnership for the first wicket, Daryl Mitchell made 28 in the middle of the innings and Tom Latham and Dean Foxcroft saw New Zealand home in an unbroken partnership of 52 for the fifth wicket.

Latham again was reliable, making 31 from 53 balls while Foxcroft made 22 from 28.

Left-arm wrist spinner Vitel Lawes put some pressure on the Kiwis with three early wickets but the target was too small to maintain that pressure.

West Indies lost eight wickets in just over 20 overs in the face of excellent spin bowling from left-armer Jayden Lennox who took 4-52 to go with his 5-19 in the second match of the series. Mitchell Santner took 2-15 from 8.1 overs and Michael Bracewell 2-33 on another turning pitch at Providence Stadium.

Lennox has been player of the match in the last two internationals. All of his nine wickets have been bowled or lbw.

"There's obviously not secret to it, it's keep the stumps in play," Lennox said in a post-match television interview. "You have to let the pitch do what it does. We can't control that but if we put the ball in the right area we're obviously going to get some rewards."

West Indies opener Campbell injured:

Things began to go awry for West Indies when opener John Campbell was carried from the field on a stretcher in the sixth over after tearing a hamstring while running between wickets.

West Indies was 25-0 at that point and 38-1 when Campbell's opening partner Ackeem Auguste was brilliantly caught by Santner off the bowling of Jacob Duffy to provide a rare wicket for the seamers.

Spain practices outside as smoke fills air in northern New Jersey

STEPHEN WHYNO/SETH BORENSTEIN
New Jersey (US)

With the sun obstructed by haze, Spain's players practiced Thursday ahead of the World Cup final outside in northern New Jersey while air conditions are hazardous because of smoke from Canadian wildfires.

It was not clear how fast-paced a practice Spain held. Media members are only able to observe the first 15 minutes of what was scheduled to be a hourlong session in East Hanover beginning at 11 a.m. EDT.

Argentina remained in the Atlanta area to work out less than 24 hours after rallying to beat England and reach the final for a second consecutive tournament. Marietta, Georgia, is far enough south to avoid the effects of the fire, which are being windblown to the southeast from northern Ontario, triggering warnings from the US Midwest through the Northeast.

Officials urged people to stay inside or wear masks outside as air quality reached unhealthy to hazardous levels, meaning it's unhealthy for anyone, regardless of health conditions. Experts expressed concern over holding practice outdoors.

"These are high-level athletes who are moving a lot of air through their lungs during every practice in every game, and really they shouldn't be practicing outside if the air quality levels are at hazardous sort of ranges for wildfire-related air pollution," said Dr. Courtney Howard, an emergency room physician and Global Climate and Health Alliance official.

"That's time to schedule a practice inside. You could put an N95 mask on them, but trying to make sure that everybody's mask is well-fitted, I suspect that's not the best choice. I would go find an air-conditioned indoor facility that's a clean-air shelter." (*AP*)

English media, ex-players criticise Tuchel after team's WC letdown

JAMES ROBSONAP Atlanta

England hired a German coach to end 60 years of hurt but will exit the World Cup in the most English of ways. Another defeat in the semi-finals. Another defeat from a winning position. The English media was predictably critical of coach Thomas Tuchel after Wednesday's 2-1 loss to Argentina. "Same old story" read one headline. Another declared that "Tuchel just shrank."

Tuchel, a title-winning coach with Borussia Dortmund, Paris Saint-Germain, Chelsea and Bayern Munich, was hired to put a second star on England's jersey and end the decades-long wait for a first trophy since the World Cup in 1966. The wait goes on.

Former England captain Gary Lineker raised the question about Tuchel's future, saying he was "brought in specifically to take us over line." (*AP*)

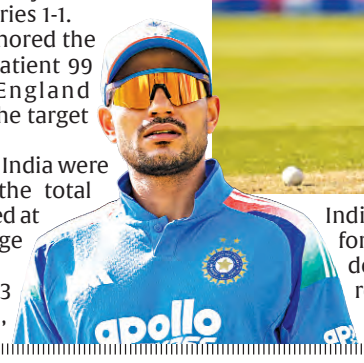
Shubman Gill rues middle-order collapse after defeat

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA Cardiff

India captain Shubman Gill blamed his side's middle-order collapse after England chased down a modest 234 with four wickets in hand in the second ODI here on Thursday to level the three-match series 1-1.

Joe Root anchored the chase with a patient 99 not out as England chased down the target in 44.1 overs.

Gill admitted India were well short of the total they had targeted at the halfway stage of the innings.



From 178 for 3 at one stage, India slumped to 193 for 7 in a space of 26 deliveries and never recovered.

"We thought 300-310 would be a good total after 25 overs when we were in a good position, but we lost too many wickets in the middle overs," Gill said.

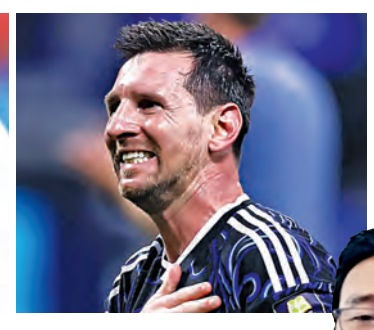
The skipper expected greater contribution from the lower middle-order after the top-order had laid a solid platform. "Our tailenders are not the best batsmen, but we expected more from the lower middle-order batters and they were not able to capitalise on their starts," Gill said.

Gill also lamented the injury of Washington Sundar, saying it robbed India of bowling option at a crucial stage. "Never a good feeling when you ping one to cover. (Washington) Sundar is a key part of our team. Maybe it would have played a part, squeezing in the pressure."

The India captain said the visitors had little option but to rely heavily on their frontline pacers after Washington's departure, though he felt the conditions continued to favour the seamers.

Messi can match Maradona if Argentina win 2026 WC: Bhutia

PHILEM DIPAK SINGH New Delhi



Former India captain Bhaichung Bhutia rates Diego Maradona above Lionel Messi in their World Cup performances but said the current Argentine skipper would reach the status of the 1986 Cup-winning hero if the South American country wins the 2026 edition title on Sunday.

Argentina face Spain in the 2026 World Cup final in New York on Sunday. Messi also led Argentina to title in the 2022 World Cup in Qatar.

Maradona led the 1986 Argentina side to victory and was also the captain of the team that lost to Germany in the final in 1990.

For Bhutia, Maradona's exploits of single-handedly winning the 1986 World Cup for Argentina would put him above Messi. But he said a second World Cup trophy for Messi on Sunday will take him on equal standing with Maradona.

"It's difficult to compare. But for me, it's Maradona because he single-handedly won the 1986 World Cup which I don't think any player in history has done that. I watched him in 1986 World Cup and other matches as well," Bhutia told PTI in an interview, when asked to rate Maradona and Messi in the World Cups.

"I think Messi is almost near. If he can win this World Cup, I think he will obviously reach the status of Maradona. He (Messi) has already won one World Cup but to overtake Maradona I think he needs one more World Cup to win," said the former India striker.

"Messi is a great player but he's got a great team around him who really works for him. For Maradona he had to work for everybody and also create those goal-scoring opportunities (for himself)." (*PTI*)

Max Verstappen leaves his F1 future open

JAMES ELLINGWORTHAP
Brussels

Max Verstappen has left his future in Formula 1 open again ahead of the Belgian Grand Prix and praised his "really good" relationship with Red Bull team principal Laurent Mekies.

Verstappen has yet to commit to staying with Red Bull for next year after he was linked to McLaren and suggested he'd consider leaving F1.

"I don't want to go here, say yes, and no, and this and that about my future. I said already many times that if there was something new I would say it myself," the four-time world champion said on Thursday.

Open and transparent' with Mekies: Mekies is marking a year in charge of the team after replacing long-time boss Christian Horner midway through 2025, and Verstappen had warm words for him.

"It's been really good. I get on very well with Laurent. We speak a lot on track, but also off track," he said. "I think the relationship that he has also within the team is great.

"Everything for me feels very positive and I think it's always nice when you can discuss a lot of things with your team boss. So from that sense, yeah, very happy. It's all very open and transparent." After faults with the rotating rear wing pitched Verstappen into the barriers at high speed two weeks running in Austria and Britain, Red Bull is reverting back to an old wing design for Belgium this week.

"It's quite obvious, no, why? So we'll go back on the old one and then see whenever the latest or new one is ready again to be used for us," Verstappen said.

He crashed out of the British Grand Prix and delivered an expletive-laden rant at the car over the radio before branding it "dangerous" to drive.

A history of uncertainty: It's the third year running that Verstappen has kept his future open, only to recommit to Red Bull halfway through the season. Last year, he didn't pledge to stay with the team until the Hungarian Grand Prix on July 31. (*AP*)

The Pioneer
NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | JULY 18, 2026

AIFF invites retired players for SOM roster under new sports law

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

The All India Football Federation (AIFF) on Friday invited applications from retired players for inclusion in its Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit (SOM) roster, a key requirement under the National Sports Governance Act which the AIFF adopted at its Special General Body Meeting in May.

The federation said it will prepare separate rosters comprising 20 male and 20 female Sportspersons of Outstanding Merit, who meet the eligibility criteria prescribed under the new legal framework. A minimum of four SOMs with voting rights (two male, two female) are required to be inducted into the General Body.

According to the AIFF notice, applicants must be Indian citizens, at least 25 years of age, of sound mind, and must have retired from active competition, having not participated in any event leading to district, state or national selection for at least one year before submitting the application.

Applicants must also satisfy at least one of the tier-based eligibility criteria. The highest tier is for applicants who have been Olympic or Paralympic medallists. Tier 2 is for participants in at least two separate Olympic or Paralympic Games.Tier 3 covers participants in at least one Olympic or Paralympic Games. Tiers 4 to 9 comprises those who have been medal-winners at the World Championships, Asian Games, and Commonwealth Games. Tier 10 covers domestic champions who have won at least one gold, silver, or bronze medal in the National Games, or the National Championship.

If the number of eligible candidates within a particular tier exceeds the available vacancies, seniority by age will be the deciding factor.

If Lord's is Rohit's last, I hope he plays a knock to remember: Parthiv

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Amid speculation that the series-deciding third and final ODI against England would be Rohit Sharma's last international game, former India player Parthiv Patel has said that he expects the ex-captain to roar back to form with a defining hundred that would silence critics.

Rohit, it is learnt, has been told by the national selectors that he is not in the scheme of things for the 2027 World Cup in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia. This has given rise to the possibility of Rohit either announcing retirement or being dropped for good after Sunday's game.

He has already retired from Tests and T20 Internationals. "If the Lord's ODI is indeed the last match of his career, Rohit Sharma would want to sign off with a century. He is more than capable of doing that. We've seen it throughout his career - after two or three low scores, he often bounces back with a match-winning knock in the very next innings," Patel told 'JioStar'.

"The difference between Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma has always been consistency. Rohit may not score heavily in every game, but when he does, he plays a substantial innings and often ends up winning the Player of the Match award. He didn't look comfortable in this game," he added referring to the lost second ODI in which Rohit scored a 47-ball 26.

Patel acknowledged that Rohit was troubled by the variable bounce in Cardiff and never found his rhythm.

Former India captain Anil Kumble, while steering clear of the speculation surrounding the senior batter, spoke about how similar his approach is to England star Joe Root and Virat Kohli.

India pick proven performers for Women's Hockey World Cup

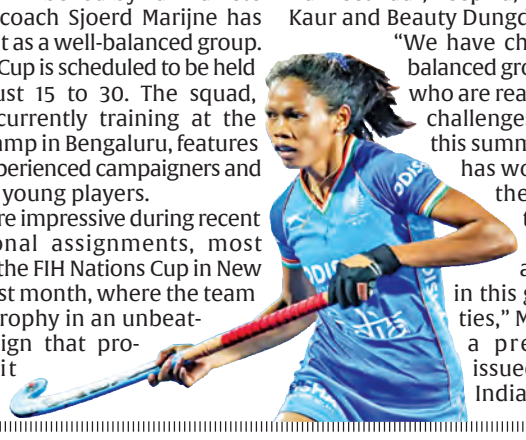
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

There were no surprises on offer in the Indian women's hockey squad announced for next month's World Cup in Belgium and the Netherlands with the selectors naming the same 20-strong group that has been picked for the Asian Games in September-October.

The 20-member squad, announced on Friday, will be led by Salima Tete and chief coach Sjoerd Marijne has described it as a well-balanced group. The World Cup is scheduled to be held from August 15 to 30. The squad, which is currently training at the national camp in Bengaluru, features a mix of experienced campaigners and promising young players.

They were impressive during recent international assignments, most notably at the FIH Nations Cup in New Zealand last month, where the team lifted the trophy in an unbeaten campaign that promoted it back to the elite FIH Pro League. Savita and Bichu Devi Kharibam are the two goalkeepers. The defensive unit comprises Ishika Chaudhary, Sushila Chanu Pukhrambam, Lalthantluangi, Jyoti and Shilpi Dabas.

Captain Salima, Nikki Pradhan, Sakshi Rana, Sunelita Toppo, Neha and Deepika Soreng will anchor the midfield. The forward line features Lalremsiami, Rutuja Dadaso Pisal, Navneet Kaur, Deepika, Ishika, Baljeet Kaur and Beauty Dungdung.



"We have chosen a well-balanced group of players who are ready for the big challenges we will face this summer. The team has worked hard in the lead-up to the tournament and we are confident in this group's abilities," Marjne said in a press release issued by Hockey India.

'Kohli, Gambhir talk 10 times in a day'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Cardiff

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak has denied a breakdown in communication between head coach Gautam Gambhir and star batter Virat Kohli, insisting that the two talk to each other "10 times a day" even though they appear distant during training sessions.

There is speculation that Gambhir and Kohli have not been on talking terms for quite some time and it has been suggested to the BCCI that a mediator can be used to make the duo sit across the table and sort out their differences.

Even during training sessions in Birmingham and Cardiff, the two weren't seen interacting. Kohli was seen talking to Kotak after a net session.

When asked if he is the "bridge" between Kohli and Gambhir, the former Saurashtra left-hander laughed.

"Virat Kohli and Gautam Gambhir speak to each other at least 10 times a day. I don't think he (Kohli) needs a bridge to communicate with head coach," Kotak claimed, contrary to what is being spoken about in the corridors of power of Indian cricket. "You asked about communication, I don't know from where you hear these things but these are rumours," he further asserted.

Kotak reiterated his predecessor Abhishek Nayar's recent remark that unless the legend himself looks for advice on his batting, one should give him none.

"When Virat goes out to bat, what I have felt as a batting coach is that if he doesn't ask for inputs or there is something major that warrants attention, there is no point in disturbing him. You shouldn't give him unsolicited advice," he said.

I wouldn't say Rohit is struggling: Batting coach

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Cardiff

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak has dismissed criticism of Rohit Sharma's form, insisting that the former India captain is neither under pressure nor enduring a slump despite his failure to come good in the second ODI against England here.

Rohit, who now plays only the ODI format, managed 26 off 47 balls on Thursday as India went down by four wickets, allowing England to level the series.

In the opening ODI too, the veteran opener had failed to make an impact, scoring just 11, though India cruised to victory thanks to half-centuries from Shubman Gill, Washington Sundar and Axar Patel.

India batting coach Sitanshu Kotak

With Rohit's modest returns inevitably coming under scrutiny, Kotak threw his weight behind the skipper.

"I don't think a player of Rohit's calibre will come under any kind of pressure. He's too good a player to feel that," said Kotak during the post-match press conference.

Japan Open: Sindhu enters into her first Super 750 semifinal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Tokyo

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu sailed into her first Super 750 semifinal in nearly three years after former world champion Nozomi Okuhara withdrew ahead of their women's singles quarterfinal match at the Japan Open here on Friday.

The 31-year-old Indian, the 2019 world champion, will feature in the last four of a Super 750 event for the first time since the Denmark Open in 2023. It is also her third semifinal appearance of the season, following impressive runs at the Malaysia Open Super 1000 and the Australian Open Super 500.

Ironically, Okuhara had herself benefited from a withdrawal in the pre-quarterfinals, progressing after South Korea's An Se-young pulled out with a left foot injury.

Sindhu's reward is a semifinal clash against Tokyo Olympic champion Chen Yufei, who brushed aside South Korea's Sim Yu Jin 21-10, 21-12 to secure her place in the last four at the Tokyo Metropolitan Gymnasium.

The fourth-seeded Chinese holds an 8-6 head-to-head advantage over world No. 12 Sindhu and has won each of their last four meetings, including a straight-games victory at this year's Indonesia Masters.

Dan Brown lights up British Open

STEVE DOUGLASAP
Southport (England)

Dan Brown is lighting it up again at the British Open. One of the few smokers in golf, Brown went through "seven or eight" cigarettes during his 4-under 66 that left him tied for second place, one shot off the lead, after the first round at Royal Birkdale on Thursday.

After weeks of sunshine in this northwest corner of England, the fairways here are baked and parched - making them a potential fire hazard from discarded cigarettes.

"I've been making sure that they're out," the 31-year-old Englishman said reassuringly.

Not that he sounds too proud of a habit that makes him stand out on the circuit, but which he feels is needed to relieve some stress.

"Sorry, Mum," he said with a cheeky smile.

The burly and bearded Brown is an interesting character, not least because of the 10 tattoos on his body — three of which are of little birds — and his YouTube channel called "BeersForeBogeys" which has around 4,000 subscribers. (*AP*)

Putting woes hurt Rory McIlroy at British Open

STEVE DOUGLASAP
Southport (England)

There were no "I'm so bad at golf" exclamations from Rory McIlroy this time. The puzzled looks, shakes of the head and sagging shoulders said it all.

McIlroy was just 10 holes into his bid to win the British Open for the first time since 2014 and he was veering dangerously close to playing himself out of title contention. Missing one putt from four feet wasn't necessarily unusual. But doing it three times? In the space of four holes? That trio of bewildering close-range mishaps — on Numbers 7, 8 and 10 — came either side of McIlroy driving the green to make birdie on the 415-yard Number 9. Go figure.

And it pretty much summed up the world Number 2's wild late-afternoon ride in a 2-over 72 that included six bogeys and left him seven shots off the first-round lead, held surprisingly by 115th-ranked Jackson Suber on Thursday. "Just too many stupid mistakes," McIlroy said — and he was specifically referring to his putting on greens he described as "very inconsistent"

"I missed a couple early on that looked like they were going to break one way and they actually went another way, and then when you get the next one, you're over it and it's just very hard to trust that the ball is going to do what you think it's going to do. Then you maybe don't make quite as committed of a stroke." McIlroy arrived at the Open after a seventh-place finish at the Scottish Open, where he went viral by shouting "I'm so bad at golf" following a poor approach shot late in his final round. The sixth player — and only European — to complete the career Grand Slam rarely hides his emotions and he cut a frustrated figure for most of his round Thursday, not least when he chipped through the green and into a bunker at the par-5 Number 17. (*AP*)

Root digs in as England level series with four-wicket victory over India

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Cardiff

A steadfast Joe Root anchored England's series-levelling four-wicket win over India in the second ODI here after the visitors' batting once again seemed vulnerable with senior player Rohit Sharma's struggles triggering fresh speculation around his future.

Root delivered an unbeaten 99 off 133 balls to steer England home and keep them alive in the three-match series that will conclude at the Lord's on Sunday. That game could well be Rohit's final in India colours after he struggled to a 47-ball 26, adding to the pressure on him.

He looked out of touch as India were dismissed for 233 in 44 overs on Thursday. Virat Kohli (65) and Shreyas Iyer (66) ensured that the bowlers had something to fight with after other batters disappointed.

In reply, Root's was a model innings that showed how to control a chase on a track that offered sharp bounce, making the Indian pace troika menacing during the early part of the run chase. His 72-run stand for sixth wicket with Will Jacks (30) sealed the game after England had their own struggled after being reduced to 125 for five. The chase was completed in 44.1 overs.

Root used the big square dimensions of the field to keep the scoreboard ticking. Since the target was a small one, England were never under scoreboard pressure which allowed Root to score runs at a slow pace.

He came tantalisingly close to a hundred but Gus Atkinson hit the winning boundary to deny him.

Earlier, Rohit once again found himself under intense scrutiny with every dot ball adding to the pressure. Opposition teams have decoded the flaws in his technique and left-arm seamers, who create awkward angles, are quickly introduced to pose problems for the former India skipper.

YOUNG TEAM-MATES MUST LEARN ON THE JOB IN ODI CRICKET: ROOT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Cardiff

Former England captain Joe Root believes the country's next generation of ODI cricketers will have to "learn on the job" due to their limited exposure to 50-over cricket, saying the lack of experience makes adaptability under pressure crucial after his match-winning knock helped level the series against India.

Root struck an unbeaten 99 off 133 balls as England chased down a modest 234 with four wickets to spare in the second ODI here on Thursday, ending a poor run in the format and drawing level in the three-match series 1-1 ahead of Sunday's decider at Lord's.

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